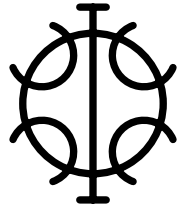
OWN THE DAY

OWN THE DAY

A Manifesto for Gratitude, Focus, and Becoming Who You Were Meant to Be



J. JOSEPH ADAMS

Own the Day: A Manifesto for Gratitude, Focus, and Becoming Who You Were Meant to Be

Copyright © 2026 J. Joseph Adams. All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced, stored, or transmitted in any form or by any means without written permission from the author, except for brief quotations in reviews and articles.

ISBN: [to be assigned by KDP]

First edition

Typeset in EB Garamond and Cinzel.

For Jennifer, first in my gratitude every morning, and my ever-fixed mark.

For my parents, my grandmother, and Uncle Philip, who taught me more than they knew.

For Levi and Jeyben, and for Katherine and Danielle.

And for the examples and the warnings. I learned from all of you.

"When I write, I can shake off all my cares."

ANNE FRANK

CONTENTS

Introduction 1

PART ONE *Wake Up*

1 The Sculpture Is Already There 11
2 Warning or Example 21
3 The Filter Behind Your Eyes 31
4 Gratitude Is an Operating System 41

PART TWO *Die to Yourself*

5 The Day I Died to Myself 55
6 Two Hundred Seventy-One 65
7 The Monkey Trap 75
8 Ask a Better Question 85

PART THREE *Train the Mind*

9 Your Thoughts Are on a Loop 97
10 Alpha 109
11 State Before Strategy 121
12 Callus the Mind 133

PART FOUR *Face the Storm*

13 The Obstacle Is the Way 145
14 Quail the Fear 157
15 Brave Enough to Be Seen 169

PART FIVE *Live It Out*

16 An Ever-Fixed Mark 183
17 The Work You Chase 195
18 Give More Than You Get 207
19 It Is Later Than You Think 217
20 Your Hero Is Ten Years Away 229
The Final Word 239



INTRODUCTION

A Year in the Life of You

A FEW YEARS AGO I wrote a little book. It was a writing journal, fifty-two weeks of prompts, one for every week of the year. Each week started with a quote I loved and ended with a push. Write down who you are right now. Write a letter to your younger self. Spend thirty minutes going all out. Record everything that passes your lips for seven days. Find the smile in the sunrise. I called it *A Year in the Life of You*, and my wife Jennifer and I poured hours into it at the kitchen table. She was my editor, my sounding board, and the person who scribbled notes in the margins like "OPEN WITH ANNE FRANK quote please.... Love you!!!!"

So let's honor that note right now.

"When I write, I can shake off all my cares." Anne Frank wrote that in her diary while she was hiding from people who wanted her dead. Think about that for a second. A teenage girl, stuck in an attic, with every reason in the world to give in to despair, and she found a way to put her fear on paper and walk out of it lighter. If she could do that, I think the rest of us can manage a little better than we have been.

I pitched that journal to literary agents. Most of them passed, which is what agents do. One of them told me something that stuck. She said, in

so many words, that the ideas were good but publishers would want something more substantial. Something with more meat on the bone. More of me in it.

I sat with that for a long time. Honestly, it stung a little. Then it started to make sense. A journal hands you a question and gets out of the way. That's useful, but it's a little like a coach who yells "Run!" and then goes to get a sandwich. The prompts were the tip of something bigger. Behind every one of those fifty-two weeks was a belief I hold in my bones, and most of those beliefs were paid for with pain. I never really explained them. I never told you why I believe what I believe, or where I learned it, or what it cost.

This book is me explaining.

What this book is, and what it isn't

This is not a journal. There are no blank lines here, no fill-in-the-boxes, no homework. You're not going to be graded. If you want to keep a notebook next to you while you read, I think that's a fantastic idea, and you know how much I love putting pen to paper. But this book stands on its own.

Think of it as a manifesto. That word sounds a little dramatic, and I'm fine with that. A manifesto is a public declaration of what you believe and what you intend to do about it. This is mine. It's what I believe about how a person can live better, feel better, love better, and become someone they're genuinely proud to be. It's written for you, but it's also a letter to the version of me that needed it years ago and didn't have it.

It's also not a book written by a guru on a mountain. I'm a car guy. I've spent my career on showroom floors and in sales offices and, these days, in the general manager's chair at a dealership. I've hired people, fired people, trained people, lost sleep over month-end numbers, and watched hundreds of human beings walk through the front door carrying their hopes and their worries. I've learned more about human nature from that job than from any class I've ever taken. A dealership is a laboratory for

how people think, what they fear, and how they make decisions. You'll hear about that world in these pages, because it's my world.

You'll also hear about some darker places I've been. I'm not proud of all of them. I was a nineteen-year-old kid standing at a second-floor apartment window with a torch in one hand and a glass pipe in the other, absolutely certain I'd be doing drugs for the rest of my life and that the rest of my life wouldn't be very long. I was a twenty-three-year-old who stepped on a bathroom scale and watched the needle settle on 271. I was a young husband who got the door slammed in his face and ended up with everything he owned fitting in the back of a two-door Jeep Wrangler. I was the guy sitting on a closed toilet lid for the better part of a day with tears running down his face because the woman he loved had left him for someone with more money.

I tell you all of that up front for one reason. I want you to know that whatever you're carrying, I'm not judging it. I've carried some heavy stuff too. And I want you to know that change is real. I don't mean change as a slogan. I mean the kind of change where the person you used to be becomes almost a stranger.

Why a car guy?

You might be wondering what qualifies a guy who runs a dealership to write a book about better living. Fair question. I've asked it myself, usually around two in the morning.

Here's my honest answer. I don't have a PhD. I'm not a therapist. I haven't sat on a mountain for ten years. What I have is a front-row seat to human nature, every single day, and a personal history that forced me to learn some of these lessons the hard way or not survive.

A dealership is one of the most honest places in the world to study people, because buying a car pulls everything to the surface. Money fears. Family pressure. Pride. Trust, or the lack of it. Hope about the future. I've watched people walk in stiff with suspicion and walk out laughing. I've watched salespeople who were sure they'd fail become the best on the team, and salespeople with every natural gift burn themselves out in a

year. I've watched managers build cultures people love and managers poison a building in a month. Almost every time, the difference came down to the same few things you'll read about in this book: what people were grateful for, what they were focused on, and who they believed they were.

So I'm not writing as an expert who has it all figured out. I'm writing as a practitioner. Someone who has used every tool in these pages on himself, in real life, with real stakes. Some of them I've used for decades. Some I'm still learning. When something hasn't worked for me, I'll tell you. When I'm not sure whether something is scientifically proven, I'll tell you that too.

What I can promise is that nothing here is theory to me. It's what got me out of the yellow room, off the toilet lid, and into a life I'm grateful for every morning.

The three ideas that run through everything

When I went back through all fifty-two weeks of that old journal, I noticed something. Almost every page, no matter what it was about on the surface, came back to three ideas. They're the spine of this book. I'm going to name them here, and then I'm going to weave them through every chapter, because they don't live in separate boxes. They work together, all day, every day.

The first is gratitude. Not gratitude as a nice feeling you have at Thanksgiving. Gratitude as an operating system. The software that runs underneath everything else. I start every single day with it. I have told my wife, "Every day I start my meditation with the three things I am most thankful for. Every day you are the first one." That's not a line. It's a practice, and it changed my life. I've come to believe it is impossible to be fearful when you are truly grateful, and very hard to be angry, jealous, or small. Gratitude isn't the reward at the end of a good life. It's the engine that builds one.

The second is focus. Specifically, a little network in your brain that decides what gets your attention and what gets ignored. Scientists call part of it the reticular activating system. I'll explain it properly later, in plain

English, and I'll be careful not to oversell it. But here's the short version: what you focus on, you find. What you find, you feel. And what you feel, you act on. If you've ever bought a new car and suddenly seen that same car on every road in town, you've already met this system. It's running your life right now, whether you've given it instructions or not. Most people never give it instructions. They let the news, their worst memories, and whoever yelled at them last program it for them. We're going to fix that.

The third is identity. This is the big one, and it's the one most self-help books tiptoe around. You can change your habits for a week. Anybody can. Anyone can stop smoking for ten days. Any addict can clean up for thirty. Any diet can be followed for the three days after you catch yourself in the mirror at a bad angle. The difference, the thing that makes change stick, comes when you stop being the person who does the old thing. When you refer to yourself as a nonsmoker instead of a smoker who's trying to quit. When you turn down the donut not because you're white-knuckling it but because you just don't eat that stuff. We will do whatever, and I mean whatever, it takes to stay consistent with who we believe we are. That's the most undeniable and hardest to accept fact of human life. So if you want a different life, you have to be willing to become a different person. Not a better-behaved version of the old you. A new you.

I know how that sounds. It sounds huge. It is huge. It's also doable, and I'll show you how, because I've done it more than once.

The people who taught me

I didn't figure any of this out on my own. Nobody does. I've been shaped by my parents, who have shown me unconditional love no matter what it cost them, by a grandmother I've always measured my life against and am still trying to catch up to, and by an uncle who told me on hole nine of a golf course at the local Army base to stop trying to kill the ball and just hit it. I've been shaped by a mentor named Steve Uiterwyk who looked at a broken glass and called it half full. And by Jennifer, who, as I wrote in the

dedication of that first journal, resurrected me and taught me how to love and, more importantly, how to live.

I've also been shaped by a lot of voices I've never met in person but who've spent countless hours in my car, my headphones, and my nightstand. Tony Robbins, whom I've thought of as a mentor for years, taught me that everybody's life is either a warning or an example, and that the quality of your life comes down to what you focus on, what things mean to you, and what you do with your body. Marcus Aurelius, a Roman emperor who wrote private notes to himself almost two thousand years ago, taught me that the thing in my way can become the way. Jose Silva taught me that the quiet, relaxed state of mind right before sleep is a place where you can do real work. David Goggins taught me that when my mind says I'm done, I'm usually nowhere close. Brené Brown taught me that courage and vulnerability are the same muscle. Matthew McConaughey taught me that your hero can be you, ten years from now. Chase Hughes taught me to pay attention to what people's bodies are saying, starting with my own. And a couple of guys named Lincoln and Washington taught me that character is built in private and proven in public.

I'll bring them in where they belong, not in a list. When I quote somebody directly, it's because I'm sure they said it. When I'm not sure of the exact words, I'll tell you what they taught in my own words. I've seen too many motivational books slap a great line on a famous name and call it a day. You deserve better than that.

A word about faith

You'll notice I talk about God in this book, and also about the universe, and providence, and mystery. I want to explain that up front so nobody feels ambushed.

I'm a man of faith. I pray. I believe there's something bigger than me that has had a hand in my life, especially in the years when I wasn't doing much to deserve it. When I offer thanks in my morning practice, I'm offering it to God.

But I've never believed you have to share my beliefs to use what's in this book. In the old journal, when I described the gratitude meditation, I told people to offer thanks to God, the universe, or whatever they found most appropriate. I meant it then and I mean it now. Some of the people I respect most in the world are devout. Some aren't religious at all. Every one of them can practice gratitude, direct their focus, and become someone new.

So when I say "God," translate it into whatever language fits your heart. The tools work either way. I've seen them work for people across every belief I can think of.

How to read this

Read it however you want. Front to back is how I built it. It moves in five parts. First, we wake up and look honestly at where we are. Second, we talk about dying to yourself, which is the hardest and most freeing thing I know. Third, we train the mind. Fourth, we face the storms: obstacles, fear, and the terror of being seen. Fifth, we live it out, in love, in work, in the time we have left, and in the person we're becoming.

Some chapters are stories. Some are arguments. Some will feel like I'm standing in your kitchen jabbing a finger at your chest, and I'm sorry in advance, but also I'm not, because sometimes that's what it takes. Every chapter is trying to move you one step further.

When I wrote the introduction to that old journal, I told readers this, and I'll tell you the same thing now. When Michelangelo was pressed on how he sculpted such masterpieces, he responded something to the effect of, "The sculpture was always there. I just knocked away the unneeded bits." The you that you want to be is in there already. You are dying, imploring yourself to get out of your own way.

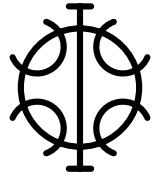
Growth is sometimes painful. It will not always be easy. My guess is you know that already. My guess is if you are reading this, you are not opting for the easy life. You have chosen the extraordinary one.

I want you to know that I honor you for taking this journey.

Let's make a real difference. Let's make a lasting difference. Let's own this day. It is ours, if only we summon the will to take it.

Ready?

Go.



PART ONE

Wake Up



CHAPTER ONE

The Sculpture Is Already There

HERE'S THE THING NOBODY tells you when you're stuck. You are not missing a piece.

When you're sitting in the wreckage of a bad decision, or a bad year, or a bad decade, it feels like the problem is that something is missing. Willpower. Talent. Money. Luck. The right partner. The right boss. A better childhood. You look at people who seem to have it together and you figure they got issued some part at the factory that you didn't get. So you go shopping for it. You buy the book, the program, the supplement, the membership. You wait for the thing to arrive that will finally make you the person you want to be.

I did that for years. I'm telling you, from the other side, that it doesn't work that way.

Michelangelo supposedly said something to the effect of, "The sculpture was always there. I just knocked away the unneeded bits." Historians will argue about whether he said those exact words, and that's fine. The idea is too good to leave on the table. Picture a massive block of marble sitting in a workshop in Florence. Rough, ugly, heavy. Most people walk by and see a rock. He walked by and saw a man inside it, waiting. His job

wasn't to add anything. His job was to take away everything that wasn't the man.

That's your job too.

The version of you who is calm, disciplined, generous, healthy, brave, and grateful is not a stranger you have to go find. They're in there. They are underneath the habits you picked up to survive, the stories other people told you about yourself, the fear you inherited, the excuses that made sense once and have long since stopped serving you. Your work, for the rest of this book and for the rest of your life, is mostly subtraction.

That is good news. It means you already have the material. It means you don't need permission. It means you can start today.

A kid at a window

Let me tell you where I was when I had no idea any of this was true.

I was nineteen years old. The walls of the apartment were painted brick, a nasty off-white that had yellowed from years of cigarettes smoked in that room. I was standing at the bedroom window of a second-floor apartment, looking down at our road. I had a torch lighter in one hand and a glass pipe in the other. As I inhaled and felt the rush hit my brain, I remember thinking, very clearly, I will be doing this for the rest of my life.

And I didn't expect the rest of my life to be much longer than four or five years.

I'm going to tell you the whole story of how I got out of that room in Part Two. For now, I just want you to sit with the kid at the window. If you'd shown him a picture of the man writing this book, a guy who runs a dealership, who's married to his best friend, who gets up early and meditates and starts his day by listing the things he's grateful for, he would have laughed at you. Then he would have asked you if you had anything on you.

That kid did not have a missing piece. He had a buried one. Everything that eventually showed up in my life was already in him. The empathy that later made me good at sales. The drive that later made me outwork everybody on the floor. The stubbornness that later kept me from quit-

ting. The love that later found Jennifer. It was all there, buried under a mountain of garbage. Some of the garbage I'd piled on myself. Some of it had been handed to me. It didn't matter who put it there. The chisel was mine.

You are not your worst chapter

One of the most damaging ideas floating around in our culture is that your past is a prediction. That if you've been a certain way, you'll always be that way. People say it with a shrug. "That's just how I am." "I've always been bad with money." "My family's all big people." "I'm not a morning person." "I have a temper, I get it from my dad."

Listen to those sentences. Every one of them is an identity statement wearing the costume of a fact.

We'll spend a whole chapter on this later, but I need to plant the flag now, because everything else in this book depends on it. The single most powerful force in your personality is the need to stay consistent with who you believe you are. Tony Robbins has been teaching this for decades, and I have watched it prove true in my own life and in the lives of every salesperson, manager, and customer I've ever worked with. People will act consistently with their view of who they truly are, whether that view is accurate or not.

Read that last part again. *Whether that view is accurate or not.*

That means you can be walking around with a completely false picture of yourself, and you will still bend your whole life to match it. If you see yourself as someone who always gets passed over, you'll find a way to get passed over. You'll hesitate when you should speak up. You'll show up a few minutes late. You'll talk yourself out of applying. And then when you get passed over, you'll say, "See? Told you."

It also means the reverse is true. If you begin to see yourself, genuinely and in your gut, as a person who follows through, you will start to find yourself following through. Not perfectly. Not all at once. But the pressure of that new identity will start pulling your behavior toward it the same way the old one pulled you down.

This is why I don't believe in willpower as the main event. Willpower is a sprint. It's great for the first mile. Identity is the whole race.

Three tools and one chisel

So how do you knock away the unneeded bits? I've been at this a long time, and I've tried just about everything. When I boil it down, there are three tools that do most of the work, and I'm going to keep coming back to them all through this book.

The first tool is **gratitude**. I know. You were hoping for something edgier. Stay with me. Gratitude is the most underrated performance tool on the planet. It isn't soft. It's strategic. When you are genuinely grateful, your body calms down, your mind opens up, and fear loses its grip. I've said for years that it's impossible to be fearful when you are grateful. I've tested that sentence against some of the scariest moments of my life, and it has held up every time. Gratitude is what makes change feel safe enough to attempt.

The second tool is **focus**. Your brain has a filtering system built into it that decides, every second, which tiny sliver of the world gets your attention. You can't notice everything. You'd go crazy. So your brain picks. And the way it picks is based largely on what you've told it matters. When you get deliberate about what you focus on, the world literally starts to look different, because you're noticing different things. Opportunities that were always there show up. People who were always kind start to look kind. Problems start to look like puzzles.

The third tool is **identity**. This is where the other two are headed. Gratitude calms you down enough to change. Focus shows you what to change toward. Identity is the change itself. At some point you stop trying to do new things and you start being a new person who does those things naturally.

And the chisel? The chisel is decision. Every blow against that marble is a decision. Get up or stay in bed. Eat it or don't. Say it or swallow it. Pick up the phone or scroll. You don't sculpt a person with one mighty

swing. You do it with ten thousand small taps, most of them boring, many of them uncomfortable, all of them adding up.

The honest record

When I wrote the first page of that old journal, I asked people to do something that sounds simple and isn't. I asked them to write down who they were, right now. The things they loved about themselves, and the things they'd rather not talk about. Their driving force, what they wanted, where they wanted to be, what they had, where they were, what they looked like physically and emotionally, their greatest worries and their greatest joys. I asked them to be brutally honest, because a year later they'd want to look back and be crystal clear on who they had been.

I'm not going to give you that assignment here. But I am going to ask you to do the thinking behind it, because you can't sculpt what you won't look at.

Most of us avoid an honest look at ourselves for the same reason we avoid stepping on the scale. We already suspect the number, and we don't want it confirmed. So we live in a fog. We tell ourselves things are "fine." We describe ourselves to other people in the most flattering terms we can get away with, and then we lie awake at night describing ourselves to ourselves in the cruelest terms we can think of. Neither version is true.

What you need is the version in between. Not better, not worse. Just as you are. That's enough to start.

Here's why this matters so much. You can't aim at a target from a location you refuse to admit you're standing in. Every navigation system on earth needs two points: where you are and where you're going. If you lie about the first point, the directions will be wrong, no matter how clear the destination is.

The good news is that looking at yourself honestly doesn't have to be an exercise in shame. It can be an exercise in curiosity. Picture a detective walking into a room. She's not angry at the room. She's not embarrassed by the mess. She's interested. What happened here? What does this tell

me? What's the next clue? That's the posture I want you to take toward your own life. Interested, not ashamed. Curious, not cruel.

Why most change fails

Let me describe a pattern I've seen a thousand times, in myself, in friends, in employees, in people I've coached through a tough season.

Something hurts. A doctor's visit, a breakup, a bad review, a bank statement. The pain creates a burst of motivation. Suddenly you're all in. New gym membership, new budget spreadsheet, new resolution. You tell everyone. For a week, maybe two, it goes great. You feel like a new person.

Then a Tuesday happens. You're tired. The kid is sick. The boss is on your back. The motivation that felt like rocket fuel two weeks ago now feels like a distant rumor. You skip one day. Then two. Then you say something to yourself like, "Well, I guess I'm just not a gym person." And you're back where you started, except now you've added one more piece of evidence to the pile that says you can't change.

What happened there? The goal was fine. The plan was probably fine. What failed was that the change never got below the surface. It lived at the level of behavior. The person who joined the gym was still, in their own mind, a person who doesn't go to the gym. They were just temporarily acting out of character. And the character always wins.

Every time you try to change behavior without changing identity, you're borrowing against your own willpower. Eventually the loan comes due.

The alternative isn't to try harder. It's to go deeper. To decide who you are, and then let your behavior catch up. That can sound backwards. How can I decide I'm a healthy person when I'm forty pounds overweight? How can I call myself disciplined when I just hit snooze four times?

Because identity isn't a report card. It's a direction. When I decided I was no longer a guy who did drugs, I was still, technically, a guy who had done drugs that week. That didn't matter. What mattered was which way

I was pointed. The past tense and the present tense split apart, and I chose to live in the present tense.

A word about gratitude in the rubble

I want to go back to the kid at the window for one more minute, because there's something I only understood years later.

If you'd asked him what he was grateful for, he would have looked at you like you had two heads. Grateful? For what? For this apartment with the yellow walls? For this life? And that, right there, was part of the trap. His entire focus was pointed at what he didn't have, what had gone wrong, what hurt, what he needed to numb. His brain was doing exactly what he'd trained it to do, which was scan the environment for pain and for the next escape from pain.

Gratitude would have been a revolution in that room. Not because it would have magically made things better. It wouldn't have paid the rent or cleaned his blood. But it would have done something more important. It would have turned his head. Even one honest thing, even "I'm grateful my mom still picks up when I call," would have forced his mind to look at something other than the pit. And once you start looking out of the pit, you start seeing handholds.

This is why I put gratitude first, before goals, before plans, before discipline. It's the thing that turns your head toward the light long enough for you to see a way out.

Proof that it's possible

I want to give you a little evidence before we go any further, because I know how easy it is to nod along to a nice idea like "the sculpture is already there" and not actually believe it.

I've been a lot of different people in one lifetime. I've been a kid who thought he'd die young with a pipe in his hand. I've been a skinny, sick-looking twenty-one-year-old at 154 pounds. I've been a heavy, ashamed twenty-three-year-old at 271. I've been a young husband standing outside a slammed door, and a broke single guy sharing ramen with his dog. I've

been a salesman who outworked everyone on the floor, and a manager, and now a general manager. I've been a man so armored against pain he couldn't let love all the way in, and a man who runs through the house to find his wife when he gets home.

Those aren't small differences. If you lined those versions of me up in a row, you might not guess they were the same person. And not one of those changes happened because somebody handed me a missing part. Every one of them happened because I knocked something away. The drugs. The night eating. The victim questions. The armor. Each time, what was underneath was already there, waiting.

I'm not special. That's the point. If it worked for me, with my history, it can work for you, with yours.

What the unneeded bits usually are

When people ask me what exactly they're supposed to be chiseling off, I usually point to four kinds of marble that seem to cover almost everyone.

The first is borrowed beliefs. Things you absorbed from parents, teachers, coaches, and friends before you were old enough to question them. "People like us don't go to college." "Money is the root of all evil." "Men don't cry." "You'll never amount to anything." Some of those were said out loud. Some were just in the air. Either way, you're carrying them.

The second is other people's expectations. The career your dad wanted. The body your culture told you to want. The life your friends think you should have. It's amazing how many of us are chasing goals we never actually chose.

The third is numbing habits. The drink, the scroll, the snack, the show, whatever you reach for to not feel something. They made sense once. They got you through. Now they're just in the way.

The fourth is armor. The walls you built to protect yourself from being hurt again. We'll spend a whole chapter on this one later, because it's sneaky. Armor feels like strength. Very often it's just marble.

You don't have to chip away all four at once. But it helps to know what you're looking at.

Not Monday

One last thing before we move on. Don't wait until Monday.

I know the Monday move. I've made it a hundred times. You decide on a Wednesday that you're going to change, and then you think, "Well, the week's already half gone. I'll start fresh Monday." And then you spend Wednesday, Thursday, Friday, Saturday, and Sunday doing the old thing extra hard, because it's your "last chance." And Monday arrives, and you're exhausted and bloated and behind, and the fresh start feels like a punishment.

Monday is a monkey trap. So is January first. So is "after the holidays," "after this project," and "when things calm down."

The sculpture doesn't care what day it is. The chisel works just as well on a Wednesday afternoon. Make the first tap today. Not the whole transformation. Just one tap. Drink the water. Take the walk. Write down one thing you're grateful for and feel it for a full minute. Delete the app. Say the hard thing kindly.

Then tomorrow, tap again.

The day you start is the day you start becoming someone new. Every day you wait is a day the old identity gets to vote.

What's under the marble

So let me ask you, not as homework, just as a question to carry around: what's under your marble?

When you picture the version of yourself you'd be proud of, who is that? Not the Instagram version. Not the version your parents wanted or your ex would have liked. The real one. How do they spend their mornings? How do they talk to the people they love? How do they handle it when things go sideways? What do they do with their Saturday? What do they eat? What do they refuse to tolerate anymore?

You probably have a sharper picture than you think. Most of us do. We just don't let ourselves look at it very long, because the gap between that person and where we are feels embarrassing.

Don't be embarrassed. Be excited. That gap isn't a verdict. It's a work order. And every single thing in the gap is something you can knock away.

Some of it will come off easy. A habit you've been meaning to drop, a relationship that's been draining you, a few hours of screen time that were never really doing anything for you. Some of it will take real force. Old beliefs about what you deserve. Old wounds you've built your personality around. Old identities you've worn so long they feel like skin.

We'll get to all of it. For now, I only want you to believe one thing. The sculpture is already there.

You don't have to become someone you're not. You have to stop being someone you're not.

That's the whole game. Let's pick up the chisel.



CHAPTER TWO

Warning or Example

"Everybody's life is either a warning or an example."

I first heard Tony Robbins say that years ago, and it went into me like a splinter. I couldn't get it out. I still can't. It's one of those sentences that's so simple you want to dismiss it, and so true you can't.

Think about the people who have shaped you the most. I'd bet that a lot of them fall cleanly into one of those two categories. Some showed you what to do. Some showed you, very clearly, what not to do. When I wrote the dedication for that first journal, I included a line for exactly this: "To the countless others who have been the examples and the warnings. To the ones that hurt and taught me to heal. To the ones that blessed and taught me gratitude."

I meant every word. I'm grateful for the warnings too. Some of the most valuable lessons of my life came from watching people I cared about walk off cliffs. They didn't mean to teach me anything. They taught me anyway.

Here's the part that's harder to swallow. You are one or the other to somebody right now. Today. There is no neutral. Somebody is watching you.

Somebody is always watching

We all have good days and bad days. But no matter what the day holds, we're an example or a warning to the people around us. Whether you're the leader of the company or somebody just trying to make it through the shift, there are always people watching.

Your kids are watching how you talk about your body. Your coworkers are watching how you handle a rude customer. Your spouse is watching how you speak about your parents. The new hire is watching what time you walk in and whether you keep your word. Your friends are watching whether you actually do what you said you'd do on New Year's Day, or whether it quietly disappears by February.

In a dealership, this is painfully obvious. I have learned that the culture of a store is not what's written on the wall. It's what the leaders do at 6:45 on a Saturday night when a deal is falling apart and everybody's tired. Do they stay calm or start throwing things? Do they tell the truth to the customer or fudge it? Do they take care of the porter who's been there since seven in the morning, or do they walk past him? Everybody sees. Everybody learns. Nobody needs a memo.

You don't have to be a manager for this to be true of you. Picture a salesperson who's been on the floor for two years. A brand new kid gets hired and is assigned to shadow her. The new guy doesn't learn from the training binder. He learns from how she answers the phone, how she talks about customers when they leave, whether she takes a smoke break every forty minutes, whether she follows up on the people who said "maybe." Within a month, he's a copy of her. If she's an example, the store just got two good people. If she's a warning, it just got two problems.

That's a lot of pressure. It's also a lot of power.

It's a decision, not a destiny

The reason I love this idea so much is that it isn't about talent or luck. It's about choice. Every day, every moment, every action is a decision. You don't wake up and discover whether you're a warning or an example. You decide it, one small choice at a time.

When I wrote about this in the journal, I asked people to spend a week recording the decisions they made, good and bad, without judging themselves. Just record them and ask why. Then write down what they'd do differently tomorrow. I still think that's a great practice. But the insight underneath it is the part that matters: most of our decisions are made on autopilot, and autopilot is programmed by identity.

The person who sees themselves as a victim of circumstance will make victim decisions. They'll wait for someone else to fix it. They'll blame. They'll explain. The person who sees themselves as responsible will make owner decisions. They'll ask, "What can I do right now?" even when the situation isn't their fault.

That doesn't mean everything is your fault. Plenty of things aren't. Bad stuff happens to good people every day. The economy tanks. People get sick. Spouses leave. Somebody runs a red light. I'm not asking you to take the blame for the weather.

I'm asking you to take ownership of your response to it.

Own it

In the journal I wrote a short, fiery page on ownership that I still stand behind. Unless you fully own, you have no control. Unless you admit your life is yours, you have only blame and circumstance. Unless you're moving forward, you're falling behind. The entropy of the universe will take everything from you unless you wake up every day with a fire in your heart to take the day.

That's my high-octane way of saying something the Stoics said much more calmly two thousand years ago. Marcus Aurelius, the Roman emperor who spent his nights writing notes to himself that we now call *Meditations*, returned again and again to the idea that we can't control what happens to us, but we can control how we judge it and what we do next. That was his whole practice. Not controlling the world, which even an emperor couldn't do, but controlling himself inside it.

There's a real freedom in this. As long as your life is someone else's fault, it's also someone else's to fix. You're stuck waiting. The minute you

own it, even the parts you didn't cause, you get your hands back on the wheel.

Picture two people who get laid off on the same day from the same company. The first one goes home, opens a beer, and spends the next three months telling anyone who'll listen how unfair it was. Every word is true. It was unfair. The second one goes home, has the same beer, feels the same anger, and then the next morning at 8 a.m. starts making calls. It was just as unfair to her. She just decided that unfair wasn't going to be the end of the sentence. Six months later, those two people are living in different worlds. Not because one had better luck. Because one owned it.

The first one is a warning. The second is an example. And they started from exactly the same spot.

The boy who copied rules

I want to tell you about a teenager who decided to become an example on purpose.

When George Washington was a boy, around fourteen or so, he copied out by hand a list of 110 rules called *Rules of Civility and Decent Behaviour in Company and Conversation*. They came from an older set of maxims, probably originally written by French Jesuits, and they were the kind of thing young gentlemen of the time were drilled on. Some of them sound funny now. There are rules about not killing fleas in front of other people and not spitting in the fire. Some of them still land. Things like speaking no evil of the absent, and showing respect to everyone you're with.

The last one is the one I love. It says, roughly, to labor to keep alive in your breast that little spark of celestial fire called conscience.

Now, here's what I find so fascinating. Washington was not born calm. By most historical accounts, he had a fierce temper. People who knew him described a man who had to work to keep it in check. He wasn't a natural saint. He built the character people later admired. Copying those rules as a kid wasn't just penmanship practice. It was a boy deciding what kind of

man he intended to become, and then writing it down so many times it sank in.

That's identity work. That's a person consciously choosing to be an example, knowing full well his natural tendencies might make him a warning.

Later in this book I'll tell you about some of the moments where that character got tested in public, and how it held. For now, I just want you to notice that it started in private, with a kid and a pen, deciding who he was going to be.

Guiding principles

In the journal, I borrowed an idea from a novel called *Sweetbitter* by Stephanie Danler. It's about a young woman who moves to New York from Ohio and starts working at a fine-dining restaurant. In the employee handbook, the restaurant lists the qualities they want in their people. Unfailingly optimistic. Insatiably curious, and humble enough to ask questions. Precise, no shortcuts. Compassionate, with a core of emotional intelligence. And honest, not just with others, but most essentially with yourself.

I love that list. I told readers back then: those are great ones, but pick your own. Start with three if you want, or two, or one. The point isn't to copy someone else's rules. The point is to have rules at all.

Most people don't. Most people are running on a vague mix of what their parents said, what their friends do, and whatever feels good in the moment. That works fine when life is easy. When life gets hard, it collapses, because there's nothing solid to stand on. You end up making decisions based on your mood, and your mood is the worst advisor you'll ever have.

Guiding principles are what keep you steady when your mood is terrible. They're the answer you already decided on before the question showed up. If one of your principles is "I tell the truth even when it costs me," then when the moment comes where a little lie would make things

easier, you don't have to deliberate. You already decided. The principle carries you.

Isaac Newton gave us the law that an object in motion stays in motion unless acted on by an outside force. Most of us live our lives as the thing being acted on. We get pushed around by the will of the world, by random interpretations of random experiences. Guiding principles let you be the force in motion instead.

The mirror test

Here's a simple way to figure out which one you are, warning or example, in any given area of your life. Imagine the person you love most in the world, maybe your kid, maybe a younger sibling, maybe a niece or nephew, copying exactly what you do in that area. Not what you say. What you do.

Would you be proud if they handled money the way you handle money? Would you want them to talk to their spouse the way you talk to yours? Would you want them to treat their body the way you treat yours? Would you want them to handle a setback the way you handled your last one?

If the answer is yes, that's an example. Keep going.

If the answer makes your stomach drop a little, that's a warning. And that's okay. The fact that you felt your stomach drop means your conscience is working, that little spark of celestial fire Washington wrote about. Now you know where to aim the chisel.

I've done this test on myself more times than I can count. Early on, the results were brutal. I was a warning in about nine out of ten categories. Health, money, relationships, substances, how I handled pressure. I remember thinking there was no way to fix all of it.

You don't fix all of it at once. You pick one. You become an example in one area. And a funny thing happens. The identity of "someone who can change" starts to spread. Once you've proven to yourself that you can turn one warning into an example, the others start to look less permanent.

Gratitude for the warnings

I want to circle back to something I said at the start of this chapter, because it ties into the first of our three big themes.

It's easy to be grateful for the examples in your life. The mentor who believed in you. The parent who sacrificed. The friend who showed up. I'm grateful for all of those every single day.

It's harder, but just as important, to be grateful for the warnings.

I've watched people close to me lose their families to addiction. I've watched talented salespeople burn out because they couldn't stop lying. I've watched good people become bitter because they could never let go of one injustice. I didn't enjoy watching any of it. But every one of those people taught me something I couldn't have learned any other way. They showed me the end of roads I was tempted to walk down. That's a gift, even if it was never meant as one.

When you can look at the people who hurt you, or disappointed you, or scared you, and find something to be grateful for in what they taught you, you take away their power over you. They're no longer a wound. They're a lesson. That shift, from wound to lesson, is one of the most important moves you can make on the way to becoming someone new.

And here's a quiet truth. Some of the people who look at your life are going to see a warning no matter what you do, because they're looking through their own pain. You can't control that. What you can control is the direction you're walking. Walk toward example, day after day, and let the chips fall.

Leading when you're not in charge

A lot of people hear "warning or example" and think it's a message for bosses and parents. It isn't. Some of the most powerful examples I've ever seen had no title at all.

Picture a service advisor, the person who greets you when you bring your car in for repairs. It's a hard job. People show up stressed, often angry, usually hoping to hear that the problem is cheap and fast when it's almost always neither. Now picture one advisor who, day after day, treats

every angry customer with patience. She doesn't take the bait. She explains things clearly. She calls people back when she said she would. She doesn't bad-mouth the technicians when something goes wrong.

She doesn't manage anybody. But within a year, the whole service drive starts to look like her. The new advisors copy her phone manner. The technicians trust her more, so they communicate better. Customers ask for her by name. She's shaping the culture of an entire department without a single person reporting to her.

That's influence. That's example. And it's available to every single one of us, regardless of where we sit on the org chart. You don't need authority to set the standard. You just need to live it where people can see.

The reverse is true too. One chronically negative person, the one who greets every new idea with "that'll never work here" and every rough day with complaints, can drag down a whole team without ever being in charge. Warnings don't need titles either.

The smallest audience

There's one more person watching you that I haven't mentioned yet, and it's the one who matters most.

You.

Every time you keep a promise, you're watching. Every time you cut a corner, you're watching. Every time you snap at someone you love and then justify it, you're watching. And the person you're watching is forming an opinion about who you are.

We talked in the last chapter about identity, about how we act consistently with who we believe we are. Well, a big part of how you come to believe who you are is by watching what you do. If you see yourself break your word over and over, you'll come to believe you're someone who breaks their word. If you see yourself show up, day after day, you'll come to believe you're someone who shows up.

So when you're deciding whether to be a warning or an example, don't just think about your kids or your coworkers. Think about the person in the mirror. They're keeping score more carefully than anyone.

Examples aren't perfect

I want to clear up one misunderstanding before we go on, because it keeps a lot of people from even trying.

Being an example doesn't mean being perfect. If it did, nobody would qualify, least of all me.

Some of the most powerful examples I've seen are people who messed up and then handled it well. The manager who loses his temper in a meeting and comes back an hour later to apologize to the whole team. The parent who snaps at their kid and then kneels down and says, "I'm sorry. That wasn't okay. I was frustrated, and I took it out on you." The friend who drops the ball and owns it without excuses.

Kids especially learn more from how we recover than from how we perform. If they only ever see you be perfect, which they won't, they learn that mistakes are shameful and should be hidden. If they see you fall and get back up with honesty and grace, they learn that mistakes are survivable, and that repair is possible. That's a much more useful lesson.

So don't let the fear of being imperfect stop you from choosing to be an example. Choose it anyway. When you fall short, and you will, let the way you recover be part of the example.

Nobody is only one or the other

I want to be careful with this idea, because it can turn into a way of judging people. That's not how I mean it.

Nobody is only a warning or only an example. Every one of us is both, often on the same day. I've been a good example to my team in the morning and a warning to my family by dinner, because I let the stress of the day follow me through the front door. I've been an example of discipline in the gym and a warning with a Diet Coke in my hand an hour later.

The people I've learned the most from were mixed too. Some of the people who taught me my best habits also showed me, without meaning to, exactly what I didn't want to become. That doesn't cancel out the good they gave me. It just means they were human.

So when you look at other people through this lens, hold it loosely. Take the lesson and leave the judgment. You're not grading anyone. You're just paying attention, so you can borrow what works and steer clear of what doesn't.

And when you look at yourself through this lens, be honest, but be kind. If you catch yourself being a warning today, that's not a verdict on your whole life. It's information. Tomorrow morning you get to choose again. That's the beauty of it. The choice doesn't get made once. It gets made every single day.

What they see is up to you

I'll leave you with the line I closed that journal page with, because I still can't say it any better.

Remember, there are always people around you watching to see how you react to a specific situation. What they see is up to you.

That's not a burden. That's an invitation. Every morning you get to wake up and decide, again, what kind of story your life is going to tell. Not the whole story. Just today's page. Will it be the kind of page someone reads and thinks, "I want to be like that"? Or the kind where they think, "Whatever I do, don't let me end up like that"?

You can't go back and rewrite yesterday's pages. Believe me, I've tried. But today's page is blank. Nobody's written a word on it yet.

Decide to be the example. You've got this.

JA



CHAPTER THREE

The Filter Behind Your Eyes

EVERY CAR PERSON KNOWS this one.

A customer spends three weekends shopping. She test-drives four vehicles, reads every review, argues with her brother-in-law about resale value, and finally drives home in a new midsize SUV. Let's say it's blue. Two weeks later she comes back in for her first free oil change, and the first thing she says, practically every time, is some version of: "I swear, I never noticed how many of these there are. They're everywhere now!"

They were always everywhere. The number of blue SUVs on the road didn't double the day she signed the paperwork. What changed was her brain. Before, a blue SUV was just part of the scenery, filtered out along with a thousand other things. Now it matters to her. It's hers. And so her brain started flagging every single one.

People have a name for this. Some call it the frequency illusion. Some call it the Baader-Meinhof phenomenon, after a newspaper reader who noticed he kept hearing about the same obscure group everywhere once he'd heard of it once. Whatever you call it, you've experienced it. You learn a new word and suddenly you hear it three times that week. You find out you're pregnant and suddenly the world is full of pregnant women.

You start thinking about a career change and suddenly every conversation seems to be about somebody who switched careers.

This isn't magic. It's machinery. And once you understand the machinery, you can start running it on purpose.

What's actually going on in there

I want to be careful here, because the reticular activating system has become a buzzword in the self-help world, and a lot of people say things about it that go way beyond what science actually supports. I'm not a neuroscientist. I'm a car guy who reads a lot. So let me tell you what I understand to be true, in plain English, and where I think the popular version gets stretched.

The reticular activating system, the RAS for short, is a network of neurons running through your brainstem, the old, deep part of the brain that sits right on top of your spinal cord. Its main job is arousal. Not the romantic kind. The awake kind. It's heavily involved in regulating whether you're asleep or awake, alert or drowsy. When you're dozing on the couch and someone says your name from across the room, and you snap awake even though they didn't say it very loud, the RAS is part of what just happened. It helped decide that signal was important enough to wake the rest of you up.

That's the key word: important. Your senses are taking in an enormous amount of information every second. The feeling of your socks, the hum of the refrigerator, the color of every car in the lot, the light on the wall, the conversation at the next table. You cannot consciously process all of that. Nobody can. So your brain has a whole set of systems, of which the RAS is one piece, that act together like a bouncer at the door of your awareness. Most of the stuff coming in gets turned away. Only a small amount gets waved through to your conscious attention.

Here's where the popular version and the real version meet. The deciding of what gets through isn't random. It's shaped by what your brain has learned to treat as relevant. Your name is relevant, so it gets through. Danger is relevant, so it gets through. Your baby crying is relevant, so a new

parent can sleep through a thunderstorm and then wake up instantly at a tiny whimper from the next room. And the things you've been thinking about, worrying about, wanting, and valuing become relevant too. Your attention systems start giving them priority.

The popular self-help version sometimes makes it sound like the RAS is a tiny genie in your brainstem that makes your goals come true if you think about them hard enough. That's not what happens. It doesn't bring things to you. It changes what you notice among the things that are already around you. But that's plenty. Honestly, that's more than plenty, because most of what we need in life is already around us. We just can't see it.

So let's put it simply. What you focus on, you find. Not because the universe rearranges itself, but because you stop filtering it out.

The filter works both ways

This is where it gets serious.

If the filter just helped you find blue SUVs, it would be a fun party fact. But it works on everything, including the stuff you don't want.

Picture a guy I'll call Dave. Dave believes the world is out to get him. His boss doesn't respect him. His wife doesn't appreciate him. Other drivers are idiots. The system is rigged. Now, Dave's brain has been told, over and over for years, that evidence of disrespect is extremely relevant. So what does it do? It finds disrespect everywhere. The coworker who didn't say good morning, noticed. The waitress who took a little long with his check, noticed. The guy who cut him off on the highway, noticed and remembered for the rest of the day. Meanwhile, the coworker who brought in donuts, the neighbor who waved, the wife who made his favorite dinner, the dozen drivers who let him merge? Filtered out. Not relevant. Not part of the story.

Dave isn't lying when he says the world is out to get him. From inside his filter, that's exactly what the evidence shows. He's been handed a highlight reel of every bad thing that happens to him, and a blacked-out screen for everything else.

This is why I wrote in the journal that your thoughts define you, period, end of story. If you're cynical as hell, it's probably because your brain loops the same cynical patterns day after day, making your world the same world you've grown used to. If you're optimistic to a fault, the same thing is happening in the other direction.

When I wrote about knowing what you don't want in your life, I added a warning. I said to do it lightly. Don't over-focus on the things you don't want. Too much thought on that stuff, and it kicks in in a nasty way. Back then I called it the law of attraction. Today I'd describe it more carefully. It's not that the universe punishes you for thinking about bad things. It's that the more attention you pour into what you fear, the more your brain treats it as relevant, and the more of it you notice. You end up living in a world that looks like your fears, not because your fears came true, but because they became the lens.

Where focus goes, energy flows

Tony Robbins has a phrase for this that I've probably repeated to salespeople a thousand times: where focus goes, energy flows. He's been teaching for decades that the quality of your emotional life comes down to a handful of things, and focus is right at the top of the list. What are you focusing on right now? Is it what you have or what you're missing? What you can control or what you can't? The past, the present, or the future?

Most people never ask. Their focus just happens to them. They wake up, grab their phone, and let the first thing on the screen decide what they're going to think about for the next hour. Maybe it's a news story designed to make them angry. Maybe it's a friend's vacation pictures that make them feel poor. Maybe it's a text from their ex. Whatever it is, it grabs the steering wheel before they've even brushed their teeth.

Then they wonder why they feel anxious, envious, or angry all day. Of course they do. They let someone else set the filter.

In one of the margins of the journal, Jennifer left me a note I've never forgotten. It said, in her words, to reprogram your information intake. Program out the negative and cynical stuff from the media and society.

Reduce how much you take in. Then program in positive news and entertainment, more of your own thoughts, and useful stuff like personal growth podcasts and books. Be selective and keep it positive. She ended it with, "seems logical, Captain."

It is logical. It's also rare. Almost nobody guards the door of their mind as carefully as they guard the door of their house. We lock our front doors at night, but we let anybody with a screen walk right into our heads and start rearranging the furniture.

Setting the filter on purpose

So how do you actually program this thing? Here's what I've learned works.

First, decide what you're looking for. Your brain can't prioritize something you haven't named. If you walk around with a vague wish to be "happier" or "more successful," your filter has nothing specific to grab onto. If you decide, "I'm looking for opportunities to grow in my career this month," or "I'm looking for moments of kindness today," or "I'm looking for any evidence that I'm becoming a healthier person," suddenly the bouncer has a guest list.

This is why I've always been such a believer in writing down what you want. In the journal, I asked people to write down what they wanted out of life for three straight minutes without lifting their pen, then read it every night before bed and every morning when they woke up. I didn't have a fancy explanation back then. I just knew it worked. Now I think I understand part of why. Every time you read it, you're reminding your brain what's relevant. You're updating the guest list.

Second, feed the filter with gratitude. I'll spend the whole next chapter on gratitude, but I need to connect it here, because this is where the first two themes of this book lock together like gears. When you deliberately look for things to be grateful for, you are training your brain to treat good things as relevant. You're telling the bouncer, "These people are VIPs. Let them in." Over time, you start noticing them without trying. The kind word, the good light in the morning, the customer who

says thank you, the fact that your car started. They were always there. Now you see them.

This is not the same as pretending bad things don't happen. The bouncer still lets in real danger. Gratitude doesn't make you naive. It makes you balanced. Instead of a highlight reel of only the bad stuff, you get the whole game film.

Third, ask better questions. Your brain loves a question. It will chew on it in the background long after you've stopped consciously thinking about it. This is why the question you ask yourself matters so much. If you ask, "Why does this always happen to me?" your brain will dutifully go looking for reasons, and it'll find them. If you ask, "What's good about this?" or "What can I learn here?" or "How can I turn this around?" your brain will go looking for those answers instead. I'll tell you in Part Two about the single question that changed the entire course of my career. For now, just know that a question is an instruction to your filter.

Fourth, watch your words. The words you use to describe your experience become the labels your brain files it under. If you say you're "devastated" when you're really just "disappointed," you've told your brain this is a bigger threat than it is, and the filter will respond accordingly. Robbins talks about this a lot, how the words we habitually use shape the emotions we habitually feel. When a deal falls apart at the dealership, I've learned to catch myself before I say something like "this is a disaster." It's not a disaster. It's a Tuesday. Calling it a disaster just makes my brain go hunting for more disasters.

Fifth, repeat. The filter doesn't change overnight. It's built on years of habit. Every time you redirect your focus, you're laying down a new track. The first few times, it feels forced. You'll catch yourself sliding back into the old grooves constantly. That's normal. Keep redirecting. Eventually the new track gets deep enough that your mind starts running on it by default.

The filter and who you are

Now let's tie in the third theme, because this is where the real power is.

Your filter doesn't just respond to what you want. It responds to who you think you are. If you believe you're a person who always gets overlooked, your brain will find every instance of being overlooked and file it as proof. If you believe you're a person who has something to offer, your brain will start noticing the openings where you can offer it.

This creates a loop. Identity sets the filter. The filter finds evidence. The evidence reinforces the identity. Round and round. This is why people get stuck for decades. It's not that they're lazy or dumb. They're living inside a self-reinforcing system that keeps showing them exactly the world that matches who they already believe they are.

The good news is that loops can run in either direction. If you can make even a small shift in how you see yourself, your filter starts finding different evidence. That new evidence strengthens the new identity. Which shifts the filter a little more. You can turn a vicious cycle into a virtuous one.

I've watched this happen with salespeople over and over. Picture a young woman who comes onto the floor convinced she's "not a sales person." She's quiet, a little shy, doesn't like the idea of pushing people. For her first few weeks, she notices every rejection. Every customer who walks away is proof. Then one day a family buys from her and, on the way out, the mom says, "You're the first person who actually listened to us." Something clicks. Maybe she's not a pushy salesperson, but maybe she's a listener, and maybe listeners sell cars. She starts seeing herself that way. And now her filter starts catching all the moments when listening works. The customer who relaxes when she asks a real question. The deal that closes because she heard what they actually needed. Within a year she's one of the best on the team, and she'll tell you she didn't change her personality. She changed what she was looking for, which changed who she thought she was.

What the filter can't do

Since I promised to be straight with you, let me tell you what I don't think the filter can do, because I've seen people get burned by overselling it.

It can't replace action. You can notice every opportunity in the world and still sit on the couch. Seeing the open door is step one. Walking through it is on you.

It can't make wishful thinking come true. If you focus hard on winning the lottery, you'll notice a lot of lottery ads. Your odds won't change. The filter changes what you see, not what's there.

And here's the big one: it can fool you. The same system that helps you spot opportunities can help you spot "evidence" for whatever you already believe, even when you're wrong. Psychologists call this confirmation bias, our tendency to notice and remember information that supports what we already think and to overlook what doesn't. It's the dark twin of everything I've been describing. If you're convinced your coworker is out to get you, your filter will hand you a stack of proof, and it'll feel airtight.

So the goal isn't just to set the filter to "positive." The goal is to set it to "true and useful." Look for the good on purpose, yes. But also stay honest enough to ask, every so often, "What am I not seeing? What would change my mind?" The best leaders I've worked with do this constantly. They're optimistic, but they go looking for the bad news, too, because they know their filter has blind spots.

Gratitude helps here, oddly enough. A grateful person isn't threatened by the truth. They don't need every piece of evidence to prove they're right. They're secure enough to look.

A day with the filter set

Let me show you what this looks like in an ordinary day, because it isn't mystical. It's practical.

Picture someone who decides one morning that today, she's going to look for evidence that she's becoming a more patient mother. That's it. That's the whole setup. She says it to herself over coffee.

At breakfast, her son spills his cereal. Old her would have sighed loudly. New her notices she has a choice, and she takes a breath first. Small win. Her filter flags it.

In the car, her daughter tells a long story about a friend at school. Old her would have been half-listening, thinking about work. Today she notices herself actually asking a follow-up question. Another flag.

At dinner, she loses it a little when the kids start fighting. Old her would have filed that as proof she's a bad mom. Today she notices something else too: she came back ten minutes later and apologized, which she wouldn't have done a year ago. The filter catches that as well.

By bedtime, she has a handful of real, specific evidence that she's changing. Not perfect, but changing. And that evidence makes tomorrow's patience a little easier, because she's beginning to believe it's who she is.

Nothing magical happened. She just told her brain what to look for, and it looked.

Write it down

Of all the ways to set your filter, the one I trust most is also the oldest: write it down.

There's something about putting words on paper that thinking alone doesn't do. When a goal lives only in your head, it's slippery. It changes shape. It hides behind other thoughts. When you write it, it becomes concrete. You can look at it. You can read it tomorrow. It's a message from you to your own brain, in writing, saying, "This matters."

In the journal, I had people do this in a lot of different ways. Write what you want out of life for three minutes without lifting your pen. Write the dark stuff you want to avoid, lightly, and the light stuff you want to embrace, in detail. Write your targets and the steps to reach them,

and write them with power: I will, I am, I have. Read them in the morning and at night.

Anne Frank said that when she wrote, she could shake off all her cares. I'd add that when you write, you can also pick up your intentions and hand them directly to the part of your brain that decides what you notice.

You don't need a fancy notebook. A napkin works. The back of a receipt works. What matters is that the words leave your head and land somewhere you can see them.

What are you scanning for?

I'll leave you with a question I ask myself all the time.

What is my brain scanning for right now?

Not what do I want to be scanning for. What is it actually scanning for? You can usually tell by your mood. If you're anxious, you're scanning for threats. If you're angry, you're scanning for offenses. If you're depressed, you're scanning for proof that it's hopeless. If you're grateful, you're scanning for gifts. If you're excited, you're scanning for opportunities.

Your mood is the readout. It tells you what the filter is set to.

Once you can see that, you can change it. Not always instantly, and not always easily. But you can change it. You can stop, notice what you've been scanning for, and deliberately point the searchlight somewhere else. And every time you do, you're doing more than improving your mood for a few minutes. You're teaching your brain what matters. You're sculpting the lens you'll look through tomorrow.

The world you see is not the whole world. It never has been. It's the slice your brain has decided to show you. So make sure you're the one deciding what goes in the slice.

That blue SUV was always on the road. The question is what else has been driving right past you all these years, waiting for you to notice.



CHAPTER FOUR

Gratitude Is an Operating System

"Every day I start my meditation with the three things I am most thankful for. Every day, you are the first one."

I said that to Jennifer. I put it at the top of one of the weeks in that old journal because it was the truest thing I knew how to say about gratitude. I've said it to her more than once since, and it's still true. Most mornings, before the phone, before the coffee kicks in, before the day shows up at the door in a tank, I sit, I breathe, I put my hands on my heart, and I think of three things I'm grateful for. She's always first.

People sometimes hear that and think it's sweet. It is sweet. But I want you to understand that it isn't just sweet. It's strategic. It's the single most important thing I do all day, and it's the foundation that everything else in this book is built on.

What gratitude isn't

Let me clear some brush first, because gratitude has a branding problem.

When most people hear "gratitude," they picture something soft. A throw pillow with cursive writing on it. A forced round of "what are you thankful for" at Thanksgiving dinner while everybody stares at the turkey. A well-meaning friend telling you to "count your blessings" right after

something terrible happened, which makes you want to throw the blessings at their head.

That's not what I'm talking about.

Gratitude isn't pretending things are fine. It isn't denying pain. It isn't a way to shut down legitimate complaints or avoid hard conversations. It isn't a guilt trip ("people in other countries have it so much worse, so stop whining"). And it definitely isn't a feeling you wait around to have.

Gratitude, the way I practice it, is a deliberate act of attention. It's choosing, on purpose, to point your mind at what is good, what is working, what you have, and who has helped you. It's a discipline, like lifting weights. And like lifting weights, it changes the shape of the thing you exercise, which in this case is your mind.

Why I call it an operating system

Your phone has apps, and it has an operating system. The apps are the things you notice: the camera, the maps, the games. The operating system is the thing underneath that makes all the apps run. You don't think about it much, but if it's corrupted, nothing works right. The camera freezes, the maps crash, the battery drains for no reason.

Most of us are trying to fix our apps. We want a better career app, a better relationship app, a better fitness app. So we download new ones. We try new diets, new jobs, new partners. And they keep crashing, because the problem isn't the app. It's the operating system.

For a lot of people, the operating system running underneath their life is scarcity. Not enough time, not enough money, not enough love, not enough respect. Every app runs on top of that. So even when something good happens, the operating system interprets it through lack. You get the raise and immediately think about how it's still not enough. You get the compliment and wonder what they want. You get the weekend off and spend it worrying about Monday.

Gratitude replaces the operating system. When abundance is running underneath, the same apps behave completely differently. The raise feels like a gift. The compliment lands. The weekend is a weekend.

Remember the filter from the last chapter, the system in your brain that decides what gets through to your awareness? Gratitude is how you reprogram it at the root. Every time you deliberately notice something good, you're telling your brain, "This category matters. Show me more of these." Over weeks and months, the filter shifts. You start seeing the good stuff automatically, without trying. That's what I mean by an operating system. It's not something you do once in a while. It's what's running all the time.

Impossible to be afraid

I've been saying this for years, and I'll keep saying it until someone proves me wrong: it is impossible to be fearful when you are truly grateful.

Try it right now. Think of something genuinely scary in your life, a bill you can't pay, a diagnosis, a conversation you're dreading. Feel the fear. Now, without letting go of that situation, think of one person you are deeply, specifically grateful for. Not in general. A specific moment. The time they showed up. The look on their face. The sound of their laugh. Really go there. Let it fill you up.

What happened to the fear?

For most people, it gets quieter. It might not disappear, but it loses its grip. That's because fear and gratitude pull your mind in opposite directions. Fear narrows. It tunnels your vision down to the threat. Gratitude widens. It opens you back up to everything else that's true. You can bounce between them, but it's very hard to feel both at full volume at the same moment.

This is why, in the journal, when I wrote about pushing through fear to make a big decision, the method I gave wasn't "be brave." It was "fill yourself with gratitude." Gratitude that you're about to be closer to what you want. Gratitude for your spouse, your kids, your life. Gratitude for anything and everything you can think of. Once you're full of that, the fear doesn't have room to sit.

I've done this in the moments before walking into a meeting where I knew I'd have to deliver bad news to people I cared about. I've done it

lying in bed at 3 a.m. with my mind spinning about month-end numbers. It works. Not like a magic trick. Like a tool. You pick it up, you use it, it does its job.

The same goes for anger and resentment and jealousy. When I wrote about marriage in the journal, I said it plainly: when we are grateful, we can't be mad, hurt, upset, or jealous. Not for long, anyway. Gratitude and resentment can't share a room. One of them has to leave.

Don't just list it. Feel it.

Here's where most gratitude practices go wrong, and where I had to learn the hard way.

For a while, I did the thing a lot of people do. I'd rattle off a list. "Grateful for my wife, grateful for my health, grateful for my job." Check, check, check. It took thirty seconds, and it did almost nothing. It was like saying grace so fast you don't even know what you said.

Then I figured out the difference. When I wrote about gratitude in the journal, the instructions weren't "write down three things." They were: stop. Don't just write them down. Feel the way the person or the moment made you feel. Take a full minute for each one. Feel the way you felt. Breathe the way you were breathing. Go back to the experience.

That's the whole secret. Gratitude is not a thought. It's a felt experience. You have to go back into the moment with your body. Where were you standing? What did the air smell like? What was the light doing? What was the expression on their face? What did your chest feel like?

When I think of Jennifer first thing in the morning, I don't think "grateful for Jennifer." I go to a specific moment. Sometimes it's her dancing around the kitchen after eating the world's best cupcake, with Avicii playing in the background, laughing and telling me, "It's not the music I'm dancing to." Sometimes it's something from the day before, the way she looked at me across a room. I let myself feel it. And that feeling carries me into the day in a completely different state than if I'd skipped it.

Specific beats general, every time. "I'm grateful for my health" is fine. "I'm grateful that I walked up the stairs this morning without my knee

hurting, and I remember a time when I couldn't" is powerful. The more detail, the more your body believes it.

If you HAD to

Some days, gratitude doesn't come easy. I know that. There are days when you look around and honestly can't find much to be thankful for. You're exhausted, you're broke, someone you love is sick, and a well-meaning book telling you to feel grateful makes you want to scream.

On those days, I use a trick I put in the journal a long time ago. I ask: if I HAD to be grateful for something right now, what would it be?

That little shift changes the question from "What am I grateful for?" (answer: nothing, leave me alone) to a challenge. If you HAD to. Gun to your head. What would you pick? And almost always, something shows up. The coffee is hot. The dog is happy to see me. The sun came up. I have a bed. Someone texted to check on me. My lungs work.

Robin Williams, a man who knew darkness better than most, once said, "You will have bad times, but they will always wake you up to the stuff you weren't paying attention to." That's one of the strange mercies of hard times. They strip everything down so far that you finally notice what's left. The missed thankful moments that were there all along.

I used to tell people to collect those moments and come back to them on their darkest days. They might just be the light at the end of a tunnel that you're going to need. I still believe that. Gratitude on a good day is a pleasure. Gratitude on a bad day is a lifeline.

Thanksgiving in the middle of a war

If you think gratitude is a luxury for people whose lives are going well, let me tell you about a very dark year in American history.

In 1863, the United States was in the middle of the Civil War. Hundreds of thousands of men had already died. That summer, the Battle of Gettysburg alone had left tens of thousands of casualties. Families across the country were grieving. The outcome of the war was far from certain.

Abraham Lincoln, a man who struggled with deep melancholy his whole life, was carrying the weight of the whole thing on his shoulders.

And in October of that year, Lincoln issued a proclamation setting apart the last Thursday of November as a national day of Thanksgiving. The proclamation, which was drafted by his Secretary of State William Seward and signed by Lincoln, opens by talking about the blessings of the year, and then acknowledges the war directly. It describes those blessings as coming "in the midst of a civil war of unequaled magnitude and severity." It goes on to list what the country still had: fields that had produced harvests, industry that kept going, a population that kept growing even through the losses.

Think about that. In the middle of the worst crisis the nation had ever faced, the man at the center of it called for gratitude. Not instead of grief. Alongside it. The proclamation also asks for care and prayers for the widows, orphans, mourners, and sufferers of the war. Gratitude and grief, side by side.

That's gratitude as an operating system. It doesn't wait for the war to end. It runs in the middle of the war.

Joy and gratitude travel together

Brené Brown is a research professor who has spent years studying shame, vulnerability, courage, and what she calls wholehearted living. One of the findings from her research that stopped me in my tracks was about joy. When she looked at the people in her research who described their lives as joyful, she found that they had something in common. They practiced gratitude. Not as a vague attitude, but as an actual practice. They didn't describe themselves as grateful because they were joyful. They described themselves as joyful because they practiced gratitude.

She also talks about something she calls foreboding joy. It's that moment when things are going great, you're looking at your sleeping kid or holding your partner's hand, and instead of letting yourself feel it fully, your mind jumps to imagining something terrible happening. We do it to protect ourselves, like we're bracing for impact. If I don't let myself feel

this too much, it won't hurt as much when it's taken away. According to her work, the people who were best at leaning into joy used gratitude as the antidote. When they felt that shiver of fear in a joyful moment, they turned it into thankfulness for the moment itself.

That hit me hard. I've done the foreboding thing more than I'd like to admit. When your early life includes the kind of wreckage mine did, part of you never quite trusts that the good stuff is going to last. Gratitude is how I answer that part of me. Not by promising it'll last forever. By being fully present to it while it's here.

Gratitude reciprocates

When Matthew McConaughey won the Academy Award for Best Actor in 2014, he started his acceptance speech by thanking God. He said, in a line I've never forgotten, that it's a scientific fact that gratitude reciprocates.

I'm not going to stand behind the "scientific fact" part the way he phrased it. I don't know of a study that proves gratitude sends good things back to you like a boomerang. But I know exactly what he meant, and I've lived it. When you move through the world grateful, people respond to you differently. You're more pleasant to be around. You notice what others do for you and you thank them, which makes them want to do more. You spot opportunities because your filter is set to find good things. You recover from setbacks faster because you're not stuck in a spiral of lack. From the outside, it can look like luck. From the inside, it's a system working exactly as designed.

In a dealership, I've watched this play out a hundred times. The salesperson who thanks the detail crew, the finance manager, the receptionist, gets their deals pushed through a little faster and their cars cleaned a little better. Not because anyone's keeping score. Because people like being around someone who sees them. Gratitude reciprocates. Maybe not scientifically. But practically, every day.

Gratitude and becoming someone new

I want to finish by connecting gratitude to the third big theme of this book, identity, because I think this is the part people miss.

Changing who you are is scary. It involves letting go of an old version of yourself, and even if that old version was miserable, it was familiar. Familiar feels safe. The brain is wired to prefer the known misery over the unknown possibility. That's one of the biggest reasons people don't change.

Gratitude makes the unknown feel safe enough to walk into. When you're grounded in what you already have, you're not grasping. You're not desperate. You can take a risk because you know that even if it fails, you'll still have the things that matter most. A desperate person clings to the old identity because it's all they've got. A grateful person can loosen their grip, because they know their worth isn't riding on it.

It also lets you be grateful for the old you, which is a strange and powerful thing. I am genuinely grateful for the kid at the window with the pipe. Not for what he was doing. For the fact that he survived long enough to become me. For the lessons he paid for so I wouldn't have to pay for them again. When I can look back at him with gratitude instead of disgust, I don't have to keep fighting him. I can let him rest.

Say it out loud

Here's a piece of the gratitude practice that I think gets overlooked: gratitude that stays inside your head is only doing half its job.

The morning practice is for you. It sets your operating system. But gratitude also has an outward side, and that side changes the people around you.

Tell people. Specifically. Not just "thanks," although that's a good start. "Thank you for staying late last night to get that customer's car finished. I know you had somewhere to be, and it made a real difference." "Thank you for making dinner. I noticed you made the thing I like." "Thank you for calling me back so fast. It took a weight off my day."

I try to do this every day, at work and at home. I'm not always great at it. But when I do it, two things happen. First, the person on the other end lights up. Most people go weeks without anyone noticing the specific things they do. Being seen is a gift. Second, something happens in me. Saying it out loud makes the gratitude more real. It moves it from a thought to an action, and actions are what build identity.

Some of the most powerful moments of my working life have been handwritten notes. A few lines to a salesperson after a great month, or to a technician who went above and beyond. It takes three minutes. People keep those notes for years. I know, because I've seen them pinned to cubicle walls long after I forgot I wrote them.

The first Thanksgiving proclamation

Lincoln wasn't the first president to call the nation to gratitude. That honor goes to George Washington.

In the fall of 1789, during his first year as president, Washington issued a proclamation recommending a day of public thanksgiving. The country was brand new. The Constitution had only just taken effect. Nobody knew whether this experiment in self-government would survive. And one of the first things its first president did was call the people to stop and be grateful. He named the blessings: the favorable end of the war, the peaceful way they'd been able to set up a government of their own choosing, the civil and religious liberty they enjoyed. He also asked people to pray for help in doing better, to be forgiven their failings, and to perform their duties well.

I find it moving that gratitude sits right at the beginning of the country's story, and again in its darkest hour with Lincoln. It's almost as if the people at the helm understood what I've come to believe: that gratitude isn't something you do after you've made it. It's how you make it.

Gratitude for the hard people

Here's the advanced level of the gratitude practice, and I'll be honest, I'm still working on it.

Every so often, instead of picking three people I love for my morning practice, I'll pick one person who's difficult for me. Someone who frustrates me, or who hurt me, or who I just don't get along with. And I'll try to find one thing about them, or about what they've brought into my life, that I can genuinely be grateful for.

Sometimes it's easy to find. The tough boss who pushed me harder than I wanted, and made me better. Sometimes it takes a while. The person who betrayed me, who taught me something about who to trust. Sometimes all I can find is: I'm grateful this person is teaching me patience, because I clearly need the practice.

It's not about pretending the person is wonderful. It's about loosening the grip they have on me. Resentment is a way of letting someone live in your head rent-free. Gratitude, even a sliver of it, evicts them. You get your head back.

I don't do this every day. But when I do, I notice that the next time I deal with that person, something has shifted. I'm calmer. Less defensive. More able to see them as a human being with their own battles. And very often, they respond to that shift, even though I never said a word about it.

Running the system

So here's what the operating system looks like in practice, day to day.

In the morning, before anything else gets in, I spend a few minutes feeling gratitude. Three specific things, felt, not listed. Jennifer first.

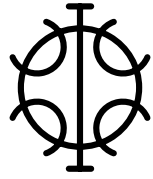
During the day, when I notice fear or anger or envy creeping in, I use it as a signal. That feeling is telling me my filter has slipped back to scarcity. I ask, "If I had to be grateful for something right now, what would it be?" And I go find it.

When someone does something for me, big or small, I say thank you out loud, and I try to mean it. A customer, a coworker, a stranger holding a door.

At night, I think back over the day and find the moments I missed. The good stuff that happened while I wasn't paying attention.

That's it. It's not complicated. It takes maybe fifteen minutes spread across a whole day. And it has done more to change my life than any goal I ever set or any habit I ever tracked.

It's not a feeling. It's the ground you stand on. Build everything else on top of it, and it will hold.



PART TWO

Die to Yourself



CHAPTER FIVE

The Day I Died to Myself

I PROMISED I'D TELL you how the kid got out of the room with the yellow walls. Here it is.

I've told this story to very few people over the years, and almost never in writing. When I first drafted it for the journal, I stared at the page for a long time before I let it stay. It's not a comfortable story. But I've come to believe that the stories we're most afraid to tell are usually the ones someone else most needs to hear. So here goes.

The room

For about three and a half years of my life, I did enough meth, coke, and amphetamine on a daily basis that it would have killed some people. I'm not saying that to sound tough. There's nothing tough about it. I'm saying it so you understand how deep the hole was.

I was obsessed. When I ran out, I would dig through the carpet looking for anything I might have dropped, anything I could smoke, snort, or swallow. I would swallow the debris from the bottom of my pockets in the hope that there was enough residue in there to get me high. Lint. Dust. Whatever. If you've never been there, that probably sounds insane.

If you have been there, you're nodding right now, and I want you to know I see you.

I was nineteen, standing at that second-floor window with the torch in one hand and the pipe in the other, when I had the thought I told you about in the first chapter: I will be doing this for the rest of my life. It wasn't a scary thought at the time. That's the part that chills me now. It was just a fact. The way you'd think, "I'll be living in Michigan for the rest of my life," or "I'll always like pizza." It was simply who I was. And the rest of my life, as I pictured it, was maybe four or five more years.

I had a whole identity built around it. I don't mean I walked around saying "I'm a drug addict." I mean that every part of how I saw myself had been shaped to fit. The people I hung out with. The way I talked. The things I thought were funny. What I thought I deserved. What I thought was possible. It was a complete system, and like all complete systems, it defended itself. Any time a thought like "maybe I should stop" floated up, the rest of the system rushed in to shut it down. That's not you. You're not that kind of person. People like you don't get out.

The morning

Then one day, it all changed.

I'd love to tell you there was a dramatic intervention, a near-death experience, a rock-bottom moment that makes for a great movie scene. There wasn't one I can point to like that. I woke up one morning so disgusted with myself that I wanted away. I wanted to be light years away from who I was. I hated myself. I wanted to die.

So I did.

I died to myself.

I know how that sounds. Let me be really clear about what I mean. I did not hurt myself. What died was the guy. The version of me who did drugs. I didn't try to fix him. I didn't try to negotiate with him or get him to use a little less. I didn't give him a thirty-day plan. I killed him off. I decided, in a way that went deeper than any decision I'd ever made, that he was over.

And the habits died with him. That's the part people don't believe until they experience it. When the identity goes, the habits lose their host. They have nowhere to live. I no longer saw myself as the guy who did drugs, because that guy sucked. I reimagined myself as the person I needed to become, and then I set about becoming that guy. I replaced the habit.

Now, I'll be honest, because honesty is the only reason to tell this story at all. The replacement wasn't perfect. One of the things I replaced drugs with was food, and that led me straight into the next chapter of my life, which you'll read about soon. Change is rarely a clean line. But the drugs were done. The guy who used them was gone. I've never been him again.

Humanity's cardinal rule

What happened to me that morning wasn't a miracle. I've come to see it as the most dramatic possible example of a rule that runs every single human life, including yours. I've called it humanity's cardinal rule: we do not act against the idea of who we are.

We will do whatever it takes to stay consistent with who we see ourselves as. There is no exception to this. None. Zero. Zilch. Nada. If you see yourself as big-boned, you'll never keep the weight off. If you see yourself as someone who enjoys a cocktail every night, you're not going to stop drinking. If you're counting the days since your last cigarette, you might still be a smoker who's quitting instead of a nonsmoker who used to smoke.

Tony Robbins has been making this point for decades, that the strongest force in the human personality is the need to remain consistent with how we define ourselves. I believe it completely. And I've lived both sides of it. For three and a half years it kept me locked in a room. Then it became the key that got me out.

Here's what I mean by that. Anyone can stop smoking for ten days. Any addict can clean up for thirty. Any diet can be followed for the three days after you glimpse yourself in the mirror at an inopportune time. Behavior change is easy for a little while. What's hard is maintaining behav-

ior that contradicts your identity. Eventually, the identity wins. It always does.

The difference comes when you refer to yourself as a nonsmoker. When you feel repulsed by the idea of what the drug would do to you. When you turn down the sugary snack because you just don't eat that kind of food. The difference is made when you don't have to make the choice, because you're simply not that person.

That's the whole secret right there. The goal isn't to become someone who resists temptation well. The goal is to become someone for whom it isn't much of a temptation anymore.

Your version of the room

Maybe your room isn't as dark as mine was. Maybe it's the cigarette after your morning coffee, or after dinner. Maybe it's the sixth or seventh or eighth beer you slam before bed because you can't imagine falling asleep any other way. Maybe it's the dessert after most meals because that's just how meals end in your house, and something sugary needs to be part of every day. Maybe it's the phone you pick up two hundred times a day. Maybe it's the online shopping, the gambling app, the porn, the rage you let loose on your family when work goes bad. Maybe it's a relationship you keep going back to even though you know exactly how it ends.

It could be any of these things. I've struggled with a lot of them. I know you're fighting your own battles. You have things in your life that you can't see yourself living without. Habits, rituals, and paths you follow because "that's just me." I get it.

But I want to ask you the question I finally asked myself: what if you could define you?

Not your parents. Not your past. Not the people you hang out with. Not your diagnosis or your history or your family tree. You.

What if you got to decide who you are, starting right now, and then let your behavior follow?

How to die to yourself

I don't want this to be a nice story you nod along to and forget. So let me break down what I think actually happened that morning, in a way you can use. I've watched this same pattern work for other people too, in all kinds of situations, and it comes down to a few moves.

First, you have to feel the full weight of the old identity. Mine hit me all at once, as disgust. Yours might come slower. But at some point you need to look at the person you've been, clearly, without excuses, and feel how much you don't want to be them anymore. I don't mean wallow in shame. Shame keeps you stuck, and we'll talk about that later in the book. I mean something closer to clean disgust. "That's not who I'm going to be." Pain is information. It's telling you that you've been living below your own standards. Let it tell you.

Second, draw a line between past tense and present tense. This is the part that makes the whole thing work. The old you did those things. The new you doesn't. You don't have to pretend the past didn't happen. You just stop living in it. When someone offers you a cigarette, the old sentence was "No thanks, I'm trying to quit." The new sentence is "No thanks, I don't smoke." Same situation, completely different person. The first sentence keeps you in the fight every single time. The second one ends the fight before it starts.

Third, define the new person in detail. In the journal, I had a whole week built around this. I asked people to describe their best self in detail. How do they spend their time? What are their hobbies? What are their acceptable guilty pleasures? Put it all in. Nothing left out. Then read it every day. I did a rough version of this in my head long before I ever wrote it down as an exercise. I pictured the guy I needed to become. What did he do in the morning? Who did he hang out with? What did he do on a Friday night? What did he think was funny? The more detail, the more real he became. And the more real he became, the easier it was to act like him.

Fourth, act the part before you feel it. This is the one people fight me on the most. They say, "But I don't feel like a healthy person. It would be fake to act like one." I understand. It does feel fake at first. Do it any-

way. Jennifer had a note in the margin of the journal about exactly this: if you don't feel motivated or enthusiastic, act like it, and within a few minutes you'll actually start to feel it for real. She's right. Feelings follow actions far more reliably than actions follow feelings. You don't wait until you feel like a nonsmoker to stop smoking. You stop smoking, and one day you realize you feel like a nonsmoker. Act the part. Become the person you want to be. Have the habits of the person you want to be. See yourself as the person who does the things you want to do.

Fifth, replace, don't just remove. Nature hates a vacuum. If you rip a habit out and leave a hole, something will rush in to fill it, and it's usually not something good. I learned this the hard way when food filled the hole the drugs left. The better move is to decide ahead of time what goes in that space. We'll talk about this a lot more in the chapter on the monkey trap. For now, know that the new identity needs new habits to live in, just like the old one had its habits.

Sixth, collect evidence. Every time you act like the new person, it's a piece of evidence that you are that person. One day without the drug. One morning at the gym. One honest conversation. One healthy meal. Your brain is keeping score, and remember from the chapter on focus, it's looking for evidence that matches what you've told it matters. Point it at the evidence of your new self. Notice every win. Be grateful for every one. Each one makes the new identity a little more solid and the old one a little more faint.

Watch who you stand next to

There's something I wrote in the journal about relationships that belongs here too, because it's one of the most practical truths I know: your standards will be as high as the lowest standards of the people you surround yourself with.

When I died to myself, I couldn't keep the same friends. That's hard to say, because some of them were people I genuinely cared about. But the whole social world I'd built was built around the guy I was trying to kill. If I kept hanging out in that world, he'd keep getting invited back. Every

conversation, every inside joke, every Friday night plan would be calling him home.

This isn't about judging people. Some of those folks eventually got out too, and some didn't, and I have nothing but compassion for all of them. It's about recognizing that identity is partly social. We are, in part, who the people around us expect us to be. If everyone around you expects the old you, it's going to be very hard to be anybody else.

You may not have to move to a new city or cut off everyone you know. But you probably need to take an honest look at who you're spending your time with and ask whether they're calling the old you or the new you. The ones who truly love you will understand in the end, even if it takes them a while. The ones who don't will try to hold you back. Don't let them.

What about the slip?

Here's a question I get a lot, and it's a good one. What happens when you slip? When the new nonsmoker bums a cigarette at a party, or the new healthy eater crushes a whole sleeve of cookies at 11 p.m.? Doesn't that prove you haven't really changed?

No. And this is so important that I want you to underline it.

A slip is a behavior. It's not an identity. When you slip, you did something the old you would have done. That doesn't mean you are the old you. It means you had a moment. Your job in that moment is not to decide that the whole change was fake. Your job is to say, "That's not who I am anymore," and go right back to acting like the new person.

The old identity loves a slip. It'll jump all over it. "See? You were never really going to change. Might as well give up." That voice is the old you trying to get back in the door. Don't open it. One cookie doesn't make you a person who binges. One bad day doesn't make you a person who quits. One angry outburst doesn't make you an angry person. It makes you a person who had a bad moment and is choosing, again, who they are.

Every morning is a chance to choose again. I love that line attributed to the Buddha that says every morning we are born again, and what we do today is what matters most. Yesterday is gone. You can't do anything about it. That's the genius of it. Today, you get to be who you are now.

Grieve the old you

Here's something nobody warned me about. When you die to yourself, you might grieve.

That sounds strange. Why would you miss a version of yourself you hated? But I did, a little. Not the drugs. The life around them. The friends, the routines, the sense of belonging, even the familiar misery. For all its darkness, that life was known. The new one wasn't yet. There were nights, early on, when I felt like I'd moved to a foreign country where I didn't speak the language and didn't know anyone.

If you feel that, it doesn't mean you made the wrong choice. It means you made a real one. Any real change involves loss. You're allowed to feel it.

What helped me was the same thing that helps with any grief: letting it be there without letting it drive. I didn't pretend I wasn't lonely. I also didn't go back. I let myself feel the gap, and I kept filling it with the new person's life, one day at a time. Over time, the new life got familiar, and the old one started to feel like something that had happened to somebody else.

Gratitude helped too, maybe more than anything. On the lonely nights, I'd make myself find something to be thankful for in the new life, even something tiny. Clean clothes. A clear head in the morning. A phone call with my mom where I didn't have to lie. Those little things were the first bricks in the new house.

The words you use about yourself

One of the most practical tools for identity change is paying attention to the way you describe yourself, especially the sentences that start with "I am" or "I'm just."

"I'm just not good with money." "I'm a mess." "I'm an addict." "I'm the kind of person who always screws things up." "I'm not a runner."

Every one of those sentences is an instruction. You're telling your brain who you are, and your brain, remember, will do whatever it takes to stay consistent with that.

I'm not saying you should lie to yourself. If you're in recovery, you might find real strength in naming what you've struggled with, and I respect that deeply; plenty of people build their sobriety on exactly that kind of honesty. What I'm saying is to be deliberate about the story you tell. There's a difference between "I'm a mess" and "I'm someone who's been through a lot and is putting my life back together." Both are honest. One keeps you stuck. One points you forward.

Try catching your "I am" sentences for a few days. Just notice them. Then ask, for each one: is this who I want to be? If not, what's a sentence that's still true but points toward the person I'm becoming? "I'm not a runner" can become "I'm someone who's starting to run." "I'm bad with money" can become "I'm learning to handle money well." It feels small. It isn't. You're rewriting the instructions.

Compassion for who you were

Once you've died to your old self, there's a temptation to look back at that person with contempt. I did it for years. I'd think about the kid in the yellow room and feel a wave of disgust. How could he have been so stupid? So weak?

Disgust was useful in the moment of change. It gave me the push I needed. But I've learned that carrying contempt for your old self long-term isn't healthy. It keeps you tied to him. You're still fighting him, which means he's still in the room.

What finally let me put him to rest was compassion. When I look at that nineteen-year-old now, I see a kid who was in a lot of pain and didn't know any other way to handle it. He wasn't evil. He was hurting. He made terrible choices, and I don't excuse them, but I understand them.

And I'm grateful to him, in a strange way, because he survived long enough to become me.

If you've got an old self you're ashamed of, try this. Picture that version of you as a younger friend who came to you for help. What would you say to them? Probably not "you're disgusting." Probably something more like "I see how much you're hurting. You don't have to live like this. There's a way out, and I'll help you find it."

Say that to yourself. Then keep walking forward.

The phoenix

When I closed that section in my journal drafts, I used an image I still love. Like the phoenix, you can burn what you are to become what you want to be.

The phoenix is a mythical bird that, according to the old stories, lives a long life, then bursts into flame and burns down to ashes. And from those ashes, a new phoenix rises. It's not a repaired version of the old bird. It's not the old bird with a few new feathers. It's new. The old one had to burn completely for the new one to exist.

That's what dying to yourself feels like. It's not an improvement. It's a transformation. And it requires a willingness to let the old version burn, even the parts that felt comfortable, even the parts you were attached to.

Any of us can do this at any time. That's the part I most want you to believe. You don't need permission. You don't need to wait for rock bottom. You don't need a perfect plan. You can die to yourself any time you choose.

I know the kid at the window didn't believe that. If he'd read this chapter, he probably would've tossed the book across the room. But he was wrong about so many things, and this was one of them. There was another version of him waiting under the marble. All it took was a morning where he finally decided the old one was done.

Your morning might be tomorrow. It might be today. It might be right now, while you're reading this.

The choice is yours. Make the best ones.



CHAPTER SIX

Two Hundred Seventy-One

I LIFTED MY ARMS and felt a sad pang of dread creep over me like a cold blanket, starting at the crown of my head and working its way down until it settled in my heart. There was no mistaking the feeling. It was complete and utter despair.

I was standing in my bathroom. I'd just brushed my teeth, and the water was still running. The fan was humming. I was putting on deodorant, Degree, the one with the light blue label. I can still smell it. Funny what the mind holds onto. And as I raised my arm, I saw them in the mirror. Stretch marks. Coming from my armpits and working down the upper part of my back, on both sides. They hadn't been there a year before.

I spent a couple of minutes just staring at them. They looked like stripes in the skin, like someone had pulled the surface too tight over something that was too big for it and the skin had started to give way. I remember thinking they looked absolutely irreversible. I remember thinking it was disgusting. I was twenty-three years old, and I felt like my life was over.

The scale was leaning against the bathroom wall. I hadn't dared to step on it in months. I already knew that whatever it said, I wasn't going to be

happy. Those marks were proof enough that I'd lost all control over my diet and my body. I turned off the water, set the scale down, watched the needle settle on zero, held my breath, and stepped on.

The dial moved. And moved. And finally settled on 271.

Maybe that was a light day. I hadn't weighed myself in months. I could've been heavier at some point. It doesn't really matter. What mattered was that in that moment, I knew I couldn't keep going this way.

How I got there

Here's the crazy part. Just two years earlier, I'd had almost exactly the same moment, going in the completely opposite direction.

At the end of my drug years, I weighed 154 pounds. I'm five-eleven. I looked weak and scrawny, like a stiff breeze would knock me over. When I died to myself and walked away from that life, I turned that around. But, like I told you in the last chapter, I replaced one bad habit with another.

Instead of snorting a line, I found myself eating an entire serving of Alfredo sauce from Olive Garden. Instead of smoking from a glass pipe, I found myself destroying entire pizzas from Pizza Hut. Meat Lover's, pan crust. It's still my favorite, if I'm being honest. I binged and binged and binged. Between the new eating habits and a metabolism that had crashed after coming off the drugs, the pounds piled on like I was being fattened up for something. I ballooned so fast that people who'd seen me just a couple of months earlier did double takes, and I could see them fighting the urge to say something out of politeness.

I'd killed off one identity and hadn't built a solid enough new one to replace it. So the hole got filled with whatever was easiest. That's what happens when you remove without replacing. I'm telling you this so you don't make the same mistake.

Not a Rocky moment

So there I was on the bathroom floor, figuratively if not literally, at 271 pounds. And I decided to make a change.

I want to be really clear about something here, because I think it's one of the most important lessons in this entire book. It wasn't some great, crazy change. It wasn't a Rocky moment with the training montage music blaring in my head while I ran up the steps. It was more like a desperate plea to myself to just try and do a little better.

Here's what I decided. I gave up eating at night. That's it. No more eating after 8 p.m.

No more late-night ice cream binges eaten standing at the freezer door with a spoon in my hand. No more handfuls of cookies. And definitely no more bowls of Goldfish with slices of cheese on the side to round it out. (Don't judge me. You've done something similar.)

That was the whole plan. One rule. One decision.

And here's what happened. Not eating at night led to better choices during the day, because I wasn't waking up bloated and groggy and looking for sugar. Better choices during the day led to more energy, which led to jogging. Jogging led to working out. Working out led to caring about what I ate, which led to more working out. My weight eventually leveled off, and today I stay within about ten pounds of what I weighed in high school.

It was always about making one decision, and doing that until I could make the next one.

The first domino

I think a lot of people fail at getting healthy because they try to change everything at once. They wake up on January 1st and decide to go to the gym six days a week, cut out sugar, cut out carbs, cut out alcohol, drink a gallon of water, meditate, journal, and get eight hours of sleep. By January 9th they're face down in a bag of chips, feeling like a failure.

The problem isn't that they're weak. The problem is that they tried to install a whole new identity overnight, with no evidence to support it. Their brain had years of proof that they were an unhealthy person, and suddenly they were asking it to believe they were a fitness model. The old identity rejected the transplant.

One rule is different. One rule is believable. "I don't eat after eight" is something even a 271-pound twenty-three-year-old can believe about himself. And every night I kept that rule, I was collecting evidence. I'm a person who keeps his word to himself. I'm a person who can say no. I'm a person who's getting healthier. That evidence gave me the credibility to make the next decision, and the next.

If you're overwhelmed by everything you need to change, stop. Pick one thing. The smallest thing that you know, deep down, would actually matter. Make it your rule. Keep it until it's boring. Then pick the next one.

All pain comes from broken standards

When I look back at that bathroom moment, here's what I understand now that I didn't understand then. The pain I felt looking at those stretch marks wasn't really about the stretch marks. It was about the gap between who I knew I should be and who I'd let myself become.

All pain, at least the kind we're talking about here, comes from breaking our own standards. From being less than we know we should be.

That's actually good news, because it means pain is a messenger. It's telling you exactly where your standards and your reality have come apart. The pain of those stretch marks moved me to take one step in a direction I wanted to go. If not for that pain, I might never have taken it. I might have stayed at 271, or kept climbing.

Tony Robbins talks about this in terms of standards. He says, and I'm paraphrasing, that we don't get what we want in life, we get what we're willing to tolerate. When your "shoulds" become "musts," that's when things change. I should lose weight. I should stop drinking so much. I should call my mother more. Shoulds are wishes. They're nice. They don't move you. A must is different. A must is a line you won't let yourself fall below.

That morning, getting healthier went from a should to a must. Not because I suddenly got more disciplined, but because the pain made the

current situation intolerable. I raised my standard for what I would accept from myself.

So let me ask you: what are your standards? What is the least you'll accept from yourself? Not what you wish, but what you actually accept, day in and day out? And what should that be? What do you want it to be?

You don't need a scale reading of 271 to raise your standard. You can decide to raise it today, because you're tired of the gap.

A temple, not a landfill

The actor Jason Ritter once said, "If my body is my choice, then I choose a temple." I put that quote at the top of one of the physical weeks in my journal, because it stuck with me. I love the choice in it.

For most of my early twenties, I treated my body like a landfill. First, I dumped chemicals into it. Then I dumped pizza into it. I wasn't making choices about it at all. It was just the container I happened to live in, and I filled it with whatever made me feel something.

Choosing a temple doesn't mean you have to become a fitness fanatic or a monk. It means you treat your body as something worth caring for. Something that deserves real fuel and real movement and real rest. It means you stop outsourcing the decision to whatever's closest, cheapest, and loudest.

I'll give you the same disclaimers I gave in the journal, because I mean them, and because my lawyer would want me to: talk to a doctor before you start any big change, don't work out injured, don't do anything that gets you killed, and if you have special circumstances, adjust to fit your needs. Okay, enough disclaimers?

Here's what I've learned works. None of it is complicated.

Know what you're actually eating. Most of us have no idea. We think we eat pretty well. Then we write it down for a week and are shocked. In the journal, I asked people to record everything that passed their lips for seven days, without changing anything yet. Just recording. I used an app for years called MyFitnessPal, and it was eye-opening. You can't change what you won't measure, and awareness alone changes a lot.

Eat food that looks like food. I gave people an easy rule in the journal for a week of clean eating: if you can drive through it, if it's white (sugar, potatoes, bread, pasta), if it's been heavily processed, or if it doesn't come pretty directly from nature, don't eat it. Bear Grylls once joked that you don't see many donuts growing on trees in the wild. That's about the whole nutrition philosophy right there.

Move every day, and sometimes go all out. One of the weeks I'm proudest of in the journal said this: thirty minutes, that's it. Not two hours. Not an hour and a half. Not even an hour. Nada. Thirty minutes. And for those thirty minutes, go all out. Give it everything you've got. "I think I'm going to die" should be part of the week at some point. If your version of all out is a brisk walk, fine. Thirty minutes, don't stop. If you're already exercising, expect more from yourself. You deserve it.

Let momentum carry you. Don't be surprised if once you start, the habit sticks. Momentum is a beautiful thing. Let it fuel you. The hardest workout is the first one. The second is a little easier. By the tenth, you start to miss it on the days you skip.

The pain of discipline or the pain of regret

Jim Rohn, one of the great old-school personal development teachers, said we all must suffer one of two pains: the pain of discipline or the pain of regret. The difference, he said, is that discipline weighs ounces while regret weighs tons.

I've felt both. I know exactly what he means.

The pain of discipline is getting up an hour early when the bed is warm. I still fight it. Some mornings I'd much rather stay cuddled up with Jennifer than go to the gym, and I'm not going to pretend otherwise. The pain of discipline is walking past the freezer at 10 p.m. It's the burn in your lungs at minute twenty-two of a thirty-minute run. It's real. It's uncomfortable. It's also small, and it's over quickly.

The pain of regret is standing in front of a mirror at twenty-three, seeing stretch marks that feel permanent, and knowing you did it to yourself. It's the doctor's appointment where the news isn't good. It's being too

winded to play with your kids. It's looking at old photos and wondering where the years went. That pain doesn't go away when the workout ends. It sits on your chest for years.

Ounces or tons. Every day, you pick which one you'd rather carry.

Gratitude at sunrise

I want to share one more piece from the journal, because it ties the body back to the heart, and I think that connection matters.

In one of the workout weeks, I laid out a simple plan: walk or jog, push-ups, sit-ups, some stretching or yoga on the off days. Nothing fancy. But on the seventh day, the instruction was different. I asked people to just take a walk early enough to see the sunrise. As the sun comes up, close your eyes and feel the first rays of the day wash over you, and make yourself feel grateful for all the blessings in your life, the big ones and the small. You've earned that moment of peace.

I put that in there because I didn't want people to think getting healthy is only about punishment and restriction. It's not. It's about giving yourself a body you can enjoy living in. It's about being alive enough to feel the sun on your face and actually notice it.

Gratitude for your body, even the body you have right now, even at 271, changes how you treat it. It's very hard to keep poisoning something you're genuinely grateful for. When I started being thankful that my legs could carry me on a jog, I wanted to take better care of them. When I started being thankful for every breath, I stopped wanting to fill my lungs with garbage.

The body goes first

I've come to think of health as the best place to start for anyone trying to become a new person, even if health isn't the thing they most want to change.

Here's why. Changes in your body are visible and measurable, and they come back to you as evidence fast. You can see the scale move. You can feel the stairs get easier. You can notice your clothes fitting differently. Com-

pare that to changing how patient you are, or how confident, where progress is real but slippery and hard to see. The body gives you proof.

And proof is what identity runs on. When I stopped eating after eight and started seeing results, it didn't just change my weight. It changed what I believed about myself in every area. If I could do this, maybe I could do other things. Maybe I wasn't just the guy who couldn't control himself. The discipline I built at the kitchen table started leaking into how I worked, how I handled money, how I showed up for people.

The body is also the fastest lever on your state, which I'll talk more about in Part Three. A person who's moved, eaten decently, and slept is simply a different decision-maker than one who hasn't. Every other change in this book gets easier when your body is on your side.

So if you're not sure where to start, start here. One rule. One walk. One glass of water instead of one soda. Let your body be the first place you prove to yourself that you can change.

Record it without judgment

I mentioned tracking what you eat, but I want to come back to it, because the spirit of it matters as much as the practice.

When I asked people in the journal to record everything they ate for a week, I was clear about one thing: this week, we won't stop any of it yet. Just record. No judgment. No guilt. Just the truth on paper.

That's harder than it sounds. The minute you start writing down what you're eating, the voice of shame shows up. "Ugh, another cookie? You're pathetic." And that voice makes people quit tracking, because who wants to be yelled at every time they eat?

So here's the trick. Treat it like the detective I described in the first chapter. Curious, not cruel. "Interesting. I eat most of my junk food between three and five. I wonder why." "Huh, I'm eating a lot more on days I skip breakfast." That's information, not a verdict. And information is what you need to make your next one-rule decision.

Give yourself a guarantee

Jennifer had a note in the margin of the journal that I think belongs here. She pointed out that in sales, a guarantee often closes the deal, and suggested people give themselves one. Her example made me laugh: want the new black skinny jeans from Macy's? You're guaranteed to have them, if you lose ten pounds.

It's playful, but there's something real in it. Your brain likes a clear reward attached to a clear target. Picture the jeans, or the trip, or the new running shoes, or whatever it is for you, and tie it to a specific result. Then keep the promise to yourself in both directions: don't buy the reward until you've earned it, and when you've earned it, actually buy it.

That second part matters more than people think. A lot of us are great at denying ourselves and terrible at celebrating. We hit the goal and immediately move the finish line without acknowledging what we did. That teaches your brain that effort never pays off. Celebrate the wins. You earned them. It's part of how the new identity locks in.

The scale is a liar and a friend

The scale taught me a lot during those years, and not all of it was about weight.

Some mornings I'd do everything right for a week and step on the scale and it wouldn't move. Or it would go up. Water, salt, a hard workout, who knows. And the old voice would come roaring back. "See? It doesn't work. You'll always be the fat guy. Why bother?"

Other mornings it would drop more than I deserved, and I'd feel invincible, and that feeling would give me permission to slack off.

Either way, if I let a number decide how I felt, I was handing my state over to something that bounces around for reasons that have nothing to do with my effort.

What I learned was to trust the trend and the process, not the day. One weigh-in means almost nothing. A month of weigh-ins tells you the truth. The same is true everywhere else in life. One bad sales month, one rough week in a marriage, one failed attempt at something new, those are single

readings on the scale. They're noisy. The trend is what counts, and the trend is built by what you do every day regardless of what the number says this morning.

So use the scale, whatever your scale is. Measure. Track. But don't let a single reading tell you who you are. Keep showing up, and let the trend speak.

The new guy in the mirror

These days, when I look in the mirror, I don't see the guy at 271, and I don't see the guy at 154. I see someone who takes care of himself. It's not because I'm perfect. I'm not. I still love a slice of pan pizza. I still have days where I skip the gym. But I'm not that person anymore, and I know that when the chips are down, I will never let myself get back to where I was.

That's not willpower talking. That's identity. The guy I am now doesn't live at 271. It's not an option. Not because I'm white-knuckling it, but because it doesn't fit who I am.

So what's your pain? Is it weight? Is it drinking? Is it something else? Whatever it is, listen to what it's telling you. It's pointing right at the place where your standards and your life have split apart.

Make the decision. Take one step, no matter how small. It won't fix itself overnight. But it will never fix itself if you don't start.

We've all been there. I'm here. I'm in your corner. I know you can do it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Monkey Trap

"WHEN I LET GO of what I am, I become what I might be." That line is usually credited to Lao Tzu, the ancient Chinese sage traditionally named as the author of the *Tao Te Ching*. Scholars would probably tell you it's a loose modern rendering rather than a direct translation, and that's fine. The idea is ancient even if the wording is new. I put it at the top of one of my favorite weeks in the journal, right above a story about monkeys.

I want to tell you that story now, because once you see it, you'll never unsee it.

How to catch a monkey

There are cultures all over the world that have developed techniques for trapping monkeys. I don't condone or support monkey trapping. But the monkey trap story has a lot to teach us, so for the sake of becoming better than we were yesterday, let's imagine how you'd trap a monkey if you absolutely had to.

Many people have figured it out. The way the story is usually told, you anchor a gourd or a coconut to the ground with a line. You cut a small

opening in it, just big enough for a monkey's hand to slide in. You put a bit of food inside. Then you sit back and wait.

Eventually a monkey wanders by, smells the food, and sticks his hand in. He grabs the treat. And here's the thing: once the monkey has the food in his fist, he will not let go. With his hand closed around the prize, it's too big to pull back out through the opening. He's stuck. He pulls and screeches and fights, but he will not open his hand.

All the hunter has to do is walk over and pick him up.

The monkey was never really trapped. He could have walked away free at any moment. All he had to do was let go.

My coconut

I'll go first, because it's only fair.

When I wrote this week of the journal, I admitted something that still makes me laugh a little. I drink Diet Coke by the gallon. I have for years. I've held onto it even after I stopped enjoying it as much, simply because it's what I've always done. My hand is in the coconut, wrapped around a can of Diet Coke, and I'm not letting go, even though I'm not even sure I want the thing anymore.

That's a small one. Mostly harmless, maybe. But it shows you how the trap works. It's not always about the thing itself. It's about the grip. It's about the habit of holding on.

I've had much bigger coconuts. For three and a half years, my fist was wrapped around a glass pipe. Then it was wrapped around a pizza box. At different points in my life it's been wrapped around a relationship that was clearly over, a grudge I'd been nursing for years, a picture of myself that didn't fit anymore, and a need to be right that was costing me more than it was worth.

Every one of them had me stuck in place. And every time, the way out was the same. Open the hand.

What's in your fist?

How often do we act just like that monkey? We get so busy holding onto what we believe we have, old ideas of who we think we are, addictions, dead relationships, that we get trapped. We can never grasp our present or our future because our energy, our hands, and our minds are all tied up with something that isn't productive or helpful.

We all have monkey traps. Some are bigger than others. Here are a few of the most common ones I've seen, in my own life and in the lives of the people I've worked with.

The old story about yourself. "I'm not a math person." "I've always been shy." "I'm the screwup in my family." These stories often started as a way to explain something painful when we were young. They might have been useful once. Now they're just a fist around a rotten banana.

The relationship that's already over. Sometimes it's a marriage. Sometimes it's a friendship. Sometimes it's a business partnership. Everyone can see it's done except you, because letting go would mean admitting it's done, and admitting it's done would mean feeling the grief. So you hold on, and you stay stuck.

The grudge. Someone hurt you. Maybe they hurt you badly. And you've been holding onto that hurt for years, replaying it, rehearsing what you'd say if you saw them again. It feels like you're holding them accountable. You're not. They've probably moved on. The only one in the trap is you.

The need to be right. This one is huge in business and in marriage. You'd rather win the argument than solve the problem. You'd rather prove your point than keep the customer. You'd rather be right than be happy. Your fist is wrapped around being right, and it's costing you everything else.

The comfortable habit. The Diet Coke, the third glass of wine, the two hours of scrolling before bed, the drive-through on the way home. Not dramatic. Just constant. Just enough to keep you in the same spot, year after year.

The past success. This one sneaks up on people. You were great at something once, and you keep holding onto the way you did it back then, even though the world has changed. I've seen salespeople who were killers ten years ago refuse to learn new tools because "that's not how I do it." They're holding a trophy so tight that they can't pick up anything new.

Why we won't let go

If letting go is the answer, why is it so hard? Why does the monkey hold on even while the hunter is walking toward him?

Part of it is simple wiring. Psychologists have found, pretty consistently, that people tend to feel a loss more strongly than an equivalent gain. Losing a hundred dollars stings more than finding a hundred dollars feels good. That tendency makes sense from a survival standpoint. For our ancestors, losing food or shelter could be fatal, so the brain learned to guard what it had. But it means we'll often hold onto something that's hurting us just because letting go registers as a loss.

Part of it is what people call the sunk cost trap. We've already put so much into this thing, the relationship, the career, the habit, the grudge, that walking away feels like admitting all that time was wasted. So we keep investing, hoping to justify what we already spent. It's the same reason people keep pouring money into a car that's falling apart. "I just put new tires on it."

But the biggest reason, I think, is identity. Again. Always. The thing in our fist has become part of who we are. The smoker's cigarette isn't just nicotine. It's the break, the ritual, the thing they do with their hands, the people they stand outside with. Letting go of the cigarette means letting go of a version of themselves. The grudge isn't just a memory. It's part of our story about who we are and how we've been wronged. Letting go of the grudge means we have to rewrite the story.

That's why the Lao Tzu line is so powerful. When I let go of what I am. Not what I have. What I am. The monkey isn't just holding food. He's holding onto who he thinks he is in that moment: the monkey who got the prize. And he'd rather be caught than stop being that monkey.

Replace it

So how do you get out of the trap?

In the journal, I gave an answer that I still think is right. You replace it.

Smoke? No problem, chew sunflower seeds. Overeat? No issue, let go of that and do sit-ups every time you crave chips. Anxiety? Start meditating. All of these solutions are simple. Not easy, but simple.

The reason replacement works so much better than pure resistance is that your hand needs something to hold. A monkey who has nothing else to grab will keep reaching back into the coconut. Give him something better, and he'll let go of the old thing to take the new thing.

This is exactly the lesson I learned the hard way when I traded drugs for pizza. I let go of one thing, but I didn't choose what to grab next, so my hand grabbed whatever was closest. The next time I made a big change, with my weight, I was more deliberate. I didn't just stop eating at night. I eventually replaced it with going to bed a little earlier and getting up to jog. The new habit filled the space the old one left.

Here's the key question to ask about any monkey trap: what was this thing giving me? Because it was giving you something, or you wouldn't be holding it. The cigarette gave you a break and a moment to breathe. The drinks gave you a way to turn off your brain after a stressful day. The grudge gave you a feeling of being right and a sense of control. The relationship gave you the comfort of not being alone.

Once you know what the old thing was giving you, you can find a healthier way to get the same need met. A walk instead of a cigarette. A workout or a hot shower instead of the fourth beer. Forgiveness, and maybe a good talk with a friend, instead of the grudge. Time on your own to rebuild instead of a relationship that's slowly killing you. You're not just removing. You're trading up.

Anything, not everything

J.M. Barrie, who wrote *Peter Pan*, has a line in one of his works that I used in the journal: "Dreams do come true, if only we wish hard enough. You can have anything in life if you will sacrifice everything else for it."

I read that as a nod to an idea I've come to believe deeply: you can have anything you want, but you can't have everything you want. Every yes is a no to something else. Every new thing you grab requires letting go of something old.

That's the part nobody likes to hear. We want to add the new life on top of the old one. We want to get fit without giving up the late-night snacks. We want to grow our career without giving up any of our leisure time. We want a deep marriage without giving up our need to be right. We want to become someone new without letting go of anything the old person held onto.

It doesn't work that way. The coconut has a small opening. You can't fit your old fist and your new dream through it at the same time.

When I decided to chase success after my divorce, which I'll tell you about in the next chapter, I let go of a lot. Relationships, time, leisure hours. Anything that didn't have to do with where I was headed got cut. If I'm being honest, it was painful much of the time. But it was my decision. I decided what I wanted, and I chased it. Nothing is gained without sacrifice. The only question is whether you're sacrificing for something you actually want.

Letting go is an act of gratitude

Here's something I didn't understand when I first wrote about the monkey trap, and it ties right back into the first theme of this book.

It's really hard to let go of something when you're operating from scarcity. If you believe there isn't enough, if you believe this is the only food, the only relationship, the only chance you'll ever get, of course you'll hold on for dear life. A starving monkey is never going to open his hand.

Gratitude changes that. When you're grounded in everything you already have, your grip naturally loosens. You don't need to cling to the thing in the coconut because you're not starving. You can see that there's a whole jungle full of food out there. You can let go of the bad relationship because you're grateful for the people who genuinely love you. You

can let go of the grudge because you're grateful for the life you've built since. You can let go of the old story about yourself because you're grateful for the evidence that you've already started to change.

And here's the other side of it. You can be grateful for the thing you're letting go of. That relationship taught you a lot. That habit got you through a hard time. That old version of yourself kept you alive. You don't have to hate what you're releasing. You can thank it, and then set it down.

I think that's the healthiest way to let go. Not with a slam and a curse, but with an open hand and a thank-you.

Training your eyes to see the trap

Remember the filter from Chapter 3, the system that decides what gets your attention? Once you've heard the monkey trap story, something interesting happens. Your brain starts flagging traps. You'll be standing in line at the gas station, and you'll reach for the candy bar you always grab, and a little voice will say, "Coconut." You'll be in the middle of an argument with your spouse, digging in on some small point, and you'll think, "My fist is closed." You'll catch yourself rehearsing an old grudge on the drive to work and realize your hand's been in the gourd for years.

That's the filter doing its job. You've told it the monkey trap matters, so now it's pointing them out to you.

When you spot one, don't beat yourself up. Just notice. Name it. Then ask yourself: what would it look like to open my hand here?

Sometimes you'll do it right away. Sometimes you won't be ready yet. That's okay. The first step is seeing the trap. You can't let go of something you don't know you're holding.

"I'll let go when..."

There's a sneaky variation of the monkey trap I want to warn you about, because I fell into it for years. It sounds like this: "I'll let go when..."

"I'll quit drinking when things settle down at work." "I'll leave the relationship when the kids are older." "I'll forgive him when he apologizes."

"I'll stop working so much when I hit my number." "I'll start taking care of myself when I have more time."

Every one of those sentences keeps your hand in the coconut while making you feel like you've got a plan to get it out. It's a delay dressed up as a decision.

And here's the problem: the "when" almost never comes. Work never settles down. The kids are never quite old enough. He never apologizes. The number keeps moving. There's never more time. Meanwhile, the hunter keeps getting closer.

The monkey doesn't get free by planning to let go later. He gets free by opening his hand now.

If you catch yourself saying "I'll let go when," try swapping it for a simpler question: "What would it look like to start letting go today?" Not all the way, necessarily. Just start. Loosen a finger. Drink one fewer. Have the first honest conversation. Make the first call. Motion breaks the spell of "when."

Letting go of the outcome

There's one more thing to let go of that I think trips up even people who've done a lot of work on themselves. It's the grip on the outcome.

The Stoics were big on this. They taught that you should put your full effort into what's in your control, your preparation, your choices, your actions, and then hold the result loosely, because the result is partly up to forces you don't control. A good archer does everything he can to aim well and release cleanly. Whether a gust of wind moves the arrow isn't up to him.

I've watched salespeople strangle deals because they were gripping the outcome so hard. They needed this sale. You could feel it coming off them. And the customer could feel it too, and backed away. The ones who did best were the ones who prepared fully, served the customer honestly, and then let the chips fall. Ironically, letting go of the outcome often made the outcome better.

It's the same in love, in health, in everything. Do your part completely. Then open your hand.

"We've always done it this way"

Businesses get caught in monkey traps just like people do, and I've seen some big ones.

The most common one sounds like "we've always done it this way." A process that worked great ten years ago becomes sacred. Nobody questions it, even as the world changes around it. Customers start buying differently. Technology shifts. Competitors adapt. And the business keeps its fist wrapped around the old way, because letting go would mean admitting the old way isn't working anymore, and that feels like a loss.

I've had to catch myself doing this as a leader. Something that got me where I am becomes the thing I'm most reluctant to change, precisely because it worked. But what got you here won't necessarily get you there. The discipline of regularly asking, "What are we holding onto that we should let go of?" is one of the healthiest habits a team can build.

The same question works for families, friendships, and marriages. What routines, roles, or expectations are you holding onto because "that's how we've always done it"? Do they still serve you? If not, open your hand.

Open hands

I closed that week in the journal by saying it isn't a one-time fix. It's a mirror of sorts. Seeing yourself for who you are will light up your entire world in a way most of us rarely experience.

So look in the mirror. Find your hang-ups. What do you need to let go of to become who you're meant to be? The habit, the grudge, the relationship, the story, the need to be right. Whatever it is, it's got your hand stuck in a coconut, and the hunter's getting closer every day.

You are not trapped. You never were. You're just holding on.

Let go of what you were. Embrace who you will be. You won't regret it.



CHAPTER EIGHT

Ask a Better Question

I WAS SITTING ON the closed lid of a toilet, staring at a tattered bathroom rug, with tears running silently down my cheeks.

It felt like the organs in my chest had been bored out and replaced with a lead weight. I couldn't draw a breath of any significance. It felt like my world was over.

Let me set the scene. I had just gone through my divorce. I'll tell you more about that marriage later, in the chapter on love, but for now it's enough to say that when it ended, everything I owned fit in the back of a two-door Jeep Wrangler. Not even the four-door Unlimited. The short one. I was broke in a way I hadn't been since I was a kid. I mean literally sharing my ramen noodles with the dog so neither of us went hungry.

And I had started dating someone. We got along great. We had fun together. We were compatible in pretty much every way, and I'd never been happier with another person. Then she told me she was leaving me for another guy.

The reason wasn't really about the relationship. It was financial. She wanted someone more stable. Someone with better prospects. Someone who could buy her the Louis Vuitton bags and take her on weekend

shopping trips to Manhattan. And I was the guy splitting ramen with his dog.

I was devastated. My lobster brain melted, and for a moment I lost every bit of forward momentum I'd built since the divorce.

I don't know how long I sat in that bathroom. Looking back, it feels like hours. It was probably the better part of a day. But at some point, sitting there, something shifted. I resolved to make a difference in my situation.

She was right, and she was wrong

Here's the thing. That relationship was never going to work. She and I wanted different things, and while it was a great time in the moment, it didn't have the legs to go the distance. I can see that clearly now. At the time, all I could see was the rejection.

But that situation opened my eyes in a way they'd never been opened before. Sitting on that toilet lid, I decided, and I mean I cut away every other option right then and there, that I was going to be successful. I was going to have the money and the cars and the house and all the things that would've kept me from feeling the way I felt in that moment. I told myself I'd never, as long as I lived, be in that position of hurt again. I'd never be that vulnerable again.

Now, I want to flag something about that last part. "I'll never be vulnerable again" is not a healthy goal, and later in this book we'll talk about why. Brené Brown has a lot to say about what happens when you armor up against ever being hurt, and none of it is good. The younger me didn't know that. He was just hurting and wanted to build walls high enough that nothing could get over them.

But the fire that got lit on that toilet lid was real, and it was useful. The anger and the hurt and the humiliation turned into fuel. The question was what I was going to point that fuel at.

The question that changed everything

Here's the secret, if there is one. I asked a better question.

Up to that point, the question running my life had been some version of: How am I going to pay my bills? How do I get through this month? How do I keep from drowning?

Those are survival questions. They're not bad questions. When you're drowning, you need to figure out how to breathe. But they have a ceiling built into them. The best possible answer to "How do I pay my bills?" is... you pay your bills. That's it. You end up exactly where you started, just not underwater. Your brain goes looking for the minimum.

Sitting in that bathroom, I stopped asking how I could pay my bills. I started asking: How can I have everything I want? What would it take?

That's an awesome question. It's still one of my favorites. Just asking it made me sit up straighter. Because it doesn't have a ceiling. It forces your mind out of the defensive crouch and into the open field. What would it take? Your brain can't help but start answering. Well, I'd need a career that pays based on performance, not a fixed salary. I'd need to get really good at something people will pay for. I'd need to outwork everybody. I'd need to use what I'm naturally good at.

The first question kept me alive. The second question built a life.

Your brain is a question-answering machine

Tony Robbins has been saying for decades that the quality of your life is determined by the quality of the questions you ask yourself. When I first heard that, I thought it was one of those things that sounds good on a poster. Then I started paying attention to the questions running through my own head, and I realized he was right.

We're asking ourselves questions all day long, mostly without noticing. You wake up and the first question is, "Do I really have to get up?" You look in the mirror and ask, "Why do I look so tired?" You get to work and ask, "What's going to go wrong today?" Something goes sideways and you ask, "Why does this always happen to me?"

Here's the problem. Your brain is a very obedient machine. You ask it a question and it goes and finds an answer. It doesn't stop to evaluate whether it's a good question. It just answers.

Ask "Why does this always happen to me?" and your brain will come back with reasons. Because you're unlucky. Because people take advantage of you. Because you're not smart enough. Because the universe hates you. It'll find evidence for all of those, too, because that's what it was told to look for.

Ask "What's good about this?" and it goes looking in a completely different direction. Well, I learned something. Well, now I know what not to do. Well, this frees me up for something better.

This is the filter from Chapter 3 all over again. A question is an instruction to your brain about what's relevant. It tells the bouncer what to let in. Ask a disempowering question, and you've basically handed the bouncer a list of reasons to feel bad and told him to go find them. Ask an empowering one, and you've sent him looking for possibilities.

Some of my favorite questions, the ones I come back to again and again:

- What would it take?
- What's great about this that I'm not seeing yet?
- What can I learn from this?
- What am I grateful for right now?
- How can I use this?
- What would the person I want to become do here?
- How can I add value to this situation?
- If I could have everything I want, what would it look like?

Notice how each one pulls your mind toward action and possibility. You can't ask "What would it take?" and then sit on the couch feeling sorry for yourself. The question won't let you.

Questions on the showroom floor

I've spent a big part of my career watching how the questions people ask themselves shape their results, and nowhere is it more obvious than in sales.

Picture two salespeople having a slow Tuesday. No customers on the lot. The first one leans against a car and asks the person next to him, "Why is it so dead today?" And then they spend the next hour answering that question. The weather. The economy. Interest rates. Marketing isn't doing its job. The competition down the street is undercutting us. By the time a customer finally pulls in, that salesperson is in a lousy state, convinced nobody is buying, and it shows.

The second salesperson has the same slow Tuesday and asks a different question: "What can I do with this time that'll make next week great?" So she starts calling past customers to check on them. She follows up on the people who said they'd think about it. She reviews her notes. She practices her walkaround. By the time a customer pulls in, she's warmed up, she's in a good mood, and she probably has two appointments lined up for the weekend.

Same lot. Same Tuesday. Same economy. Different question, different result.

I've come to believe the questions you ask are more important than almost any skill you have. Skills matter. But the question decides where you point the skills.

Who are you to not ask?

There's another kind of asking I want to talk about, and it's the kind most people are scared to death of: asking other people for what you want.

In the journal, one of my favorite weeks opened with a verse from the Bible, Luke 11:9. "So I say to you: Ask and it will be given to you; seek and you will find; knock and the door will be opened to you." Whatever your faith, or lack of it, there's a practical truth in there that anyone can use. A lot of what we want in life is available if we just ask for it. And most of us don't.

We don't ask for the raise. We don't ask for the promotion. We don't ask the person out. We don't ask for help. We don't ask the customer for the sale. We sit and wait for someone to notice us and hand it over, and then we get resentful when they don't.

When you think about asking for something big, your mind will almost certainly say, "Who are you to ask for such things?"

I say: who are you to NOT ask for such things?

This life is a gift. Don't squander it by sitting quietly waiting for permission. Ask intelligently. Ask eloquently. Know your outcome. Know what you want and keep at it until you get it. It'll be scary at first. You'll be surprised by what happens.

In the journal I also said: if you need something, go ask. But ask to give, not just to receive. Walk into your boss's office not with "I deserve more money" but with "Here's the value I've created, here's what I want to take on next, and here's what I'd need to do it." That's a question that makes everyone in the room better off. It's much harder to say no to.

What I was already good at

Once I started asking "What would it take?" the answers came faster than I expected. And a lot of them pointed right at something I'd been doing my whole life without realizing it was a skill.

Before all this, I'd had some success at a Microsoft IT academy. Not the money kind of success, but the kind where you prove to yourself that you can learn hard things and do them well. It mattered, because it was evidence. When I started asking what it would take to have everything I wanted, I had at least one data point that said I could learn.

Then I applied for a sales job. And I worked longer, harder, and smarter than everyone around me.

Sales was a natural path for me. I think I always knew it. My empathetic nature had led me toward sales-related work again and again. Reading someone's need and then finding a solution for it is, and always will be, what I do. In a lot of ways, that's why I'm writing this book. It's the same skill. You tell me where you are and what you want, and I help you find a way to get there.

I found my calling through that seemingly tragic circumstance on the toilet lid. And then I chased it. I chased it in a way that cut out every other

possibility. I operated from a simple mindset: I would never complain, and I would never make excuses. I'd just keep going until I found a way.

If you're in the career you want, ask yourself what it would take to make it better. If you're unhappy in your career, find something you love and chase it. Pursue it like a passion. Wake up for it. Make sure it's something you genuinely care about, and don't stop until you're dominating your market. If you give it everything, you won't be disappointed.

The money, fifteen years later

I want to be honest about how this story ends, because I think it matters more than the rags-to-riches part.

Fast forward fifteen years from that bathroom. I got a lot of what I told myself I'd get. And I can tell you with total certainty that all the money, cars, and houses don't make you happy. Love, family, and gratitude are the only things it takes to be truly fulfilled.

Don't get me wrong. Money is nice. You do get to arrive at your problems in a little more style. You get to worry about losing things you never really needed, and you get to worry about taxes in a whole new way. I'm not going to pretend I'd trade it all back for the ramen days. But the thing I thought was the answer on that toilet lid turned out to be just a tool. The real answer was waiting for me later, and it looked a lot more like a woman dancing in the kitchen than a bank statement.

So here's what I'd tell the guy on the toilet lid if I could. Ask the better question. Chase it hard. But make sure you know what you're really chasing. Because the question "How can I have everything I want?" only works if you're honest about what you actually want. And what most of us actually want, underneath the cars and the bags and the trips, is to feel safe, loved, and proud of who we are.

Morning questions, evening questions

If questions are instructions to your brain, then the first and last questions of the day are especially powerful, because they set the frame for everything in between.

For years, my first question of the morning, if I'm honest, was something like "What's going to go wrong today?" I didn't say it out loud. I just woke up already scanning for problems. And guess what I found.

These days, I try to start with better ones. After my gratitude practice, I'll ask myself a couple of questions while I'm still quiet. What am I excited about today? What would make today great? Who can I help today? How do I want to show up? Those questions point my filter at possibility before the world has a chance to point it at problems.

At night, I use a different set. What did I learn today? What went well? Where did I show up as the person I want to be? Where didn't I, and what will I do differently tomorrow? What am I grateful for that I didn't notice while it was happening?

Notice there's no question in there like "Why did I screw that up again?" I'm not ignoring my mistakes. The "what will I do differently" question takes care of them. But I'm not going to spend my last waking minutes marinating in blame, because whatever I think about as I fall asleep tends to follow me into the next morning.

You don't have to use my questions. Write your own. Just make sure you're choosing them, instead of letting your worst habits choose for you.

The question behind the objection

Here's one more thing I learned about questions on the showroom floor that applies everywhere.

When a customer says, "Your price is too high," most salespeople hear it as a wall. They either argue or start dropping the price. But very often, the objection is really a question in disguise. "Your price is too high" might mean "I'm not sure this is worth it." Or "I'm scared of the monthly payment." Or "I don't trust you yet." The best salespeople get curious. They ask, "Help me understand. Too high compared to what?" And suddenly the real question comes out, and they can answer it.

Your own inner objections work the same way. When your mind says "I can't do that," it's often hiding a question. "What if I fail?" "What will people think?" "Do I deserve this?" Get curious about your own objec-

tions. Ask yourself what the real question is. Once you can see it, you can answer it.

Asking for help

There's one question that a lot of us, especially the driven ones, find almost impossible to ask: "Can you help me?"

I was terrible at it for years. After the toilet lid, I'd decided I was going to make it on my own, and asking for help felt like admitting I couldn't. So I'd grind through problems alone that someone else could have helped me solve in ten minutes. I'd make mistakes that a mentor could have warned me about. I wasted a lot of time proving I didn't need anyone.

What changed was realizing that every successful person I admired had help. Lots of it. They had mentors, partners, coaches, friends who told them the truth. Steve was that for me once I let him be. Jennifer is that for me every day. The people who get furthest aren't the ones who need no help. They're the ones who know how to ask for it.

Asking for help is also a gift to the person you ask. Most people love to be asked. It tells them you value what they know. It lets them give, and we've talked about how good giving feels.

So add this to your list of better questions. Who could help me with this? And then actually ask them.

Three choices

One last tool before we move on. In the journal I wrote about decision-making, and I used a phrase I've leaned on for years: one choice is no choice. Two choices are a dilemma. Three choices are options.

When you're stuck, you usually think you have one or two options. Stay or go. Quit or keep grinding. Say yes or say no. That's what the stuck brain does. It shrinks the world down to a narrow hallway.

A better question blows the walls out. "What else could I do here?" "What are my other choices beyond these two?" Push until you've got at least three. The third option is often the one that turns out to be right,

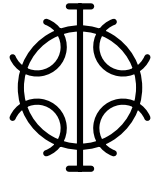
because it only shows up when you force your brain to look past the obvious.

And once you've found your options, ask the most important question of all: What's my outcome? What do I actually want? Which of these choices gets me closer to that?

Then make a decision and act. Keep acting until you get the result you want.

I didn't know any of this sitting on that toilet lid. I just knew I'd been asking the wrong questions for a long time, and I was tired of the answers. The day I changed the question was the day my life started changing.

What question have you been asking? And what would happen if you changed it?



PART THREE

Train the Mind



CHAPTER NINE

Your Thoughts Are on a Loop

"Watch your thoughts, they become words; watch your words, they become actions; watch your actions, they become habits; watch your habits, they become character; watch your character, for it becomes your destiny."

That quote is often credited to Frank Outlaw, who was president of the Bi-Lo grocery chain, though versions of the same idea have been floating around for a long time and have been hung on everybody from Lao Tzu to Gandhi. When I put it in the journal, I said the same sentiment had been expressed by Socrates, Emerson, and, in some ways, the Buddha. The message is so simple it can't be confused, muddied, or refuted.

Your thoughts define you. Period. End of story.

I want to spend this chapter on why that's true, how it works, and what you can actually do about it, because this is where the mental training really begins. Everything we've talked about so far, the filter, gratitude, identity, the monkey trap, runs through your thoughts. If you can learn to work with your thoughts instead of being dragged around by them, everything else gets easier.

A number I've stopped quoting

When I wrote the journal, I included a stat that I'd heard over and over in personal development circles. I said science had shown that humans have between 40,000 and 60,000 thoughts per day, and that 95 percent of them are the exact same thoughts you had yesterday.

I've since learned to be more careful with that one. I've gone looking for the study behind it, and I couldn't find a solid one. Those numbers get passed around a lot, but as far as I can tell, nobody has actually counted. Thoughts are hard to define, let alone count. So I've stopped quoting the exact figures. I'd rather tell you the truth than tell you something that sounds impressive.

But here's what I will stand behind, because anyone who has ever paid attention to their own mind knows it's true. A huge portion of what goes through your head on any given day is repetition. The same worries. The same judgments. The same little stories about yourself. The same replays of the same old conversations. We run on loops.

You don't need a study to confirm this. Just watch your mind for one morning. Notice how many times the same thought shows up. "I'm so behind." "I'm so tired." "Why did I say that?" "They don't respect me." "I'll never get this done." If you're like most people, you'll catch the same handful of thoughts cycling through over and over, like a playlist stuck on repeat.

What loops do

Here's why that matters. Remember the filter from Chapter 3? Every time a thought repeats, it's telling your brain what's relevant. The more a thought loops, the more your filter starts finding evidence for it in the world. And the more evidence it finds, the more the thought loops. It's a self-feeding cycle.

This is why I wrote in the journal: if you're optimistic to a fault, it's probably because your brain continually loops the same optimistic thoughts day after day, week after week, year after year. If you're cynical as

hell, the same thing is happening, but with cynical thoughts, making your world the same world you've grown used to.

Neither person is necessarily seeing the world more accurately. They're both seeing the world their loops have trained them to see.

And the loops don't just shape what you see. They shape who you are. That's the Frank Outlaw ladder. Thoughts become words. If you think "I'm terrible with money" enough times, you'll start saying it out loud. Words become actions. If you say "I'm terrible with money" enough times, you'll start acting like someone who's terrible with money: not checking your account, avoiding the bills, making impulse buys because "what's the point." Actions become habits. Habits become character. And character becomes destiny.

It all starts with a thought you didn't even notice you were having.

The soul takes on the color

Marcus Aurelius understood this almost two thousand years ago. In the *Meditations*, there's a line that's usually translated something like: the soul becomes dyed with the color of its thoughts. In one older translation, it reads, "Such as are thy habitual thoughts, such also will be the character of thy mind; for the soul is dyed by the thoughts."

I love that image. Think about dyeing fabric. You don't dip a white shirt in blue dye once and get a deep navy. You dip it, and it comes out a little blue. Dip it again, a little bluer. Keep dipping it, day after day, and eventually it's the color of the dye all the way through. You can't wash it out.

That's what habitual thoughts do to you. One cynical thought doesn't make you a cynic. But dip your mind in cynicism every day for ten years and you'll be dyed through. Same with gratitude. One grateful thought won't transform you. But dip your mind in gratitude every morning, and over time it soaks all the way in.

The question isn't whether your mind is being dyed. It is, every single day. The question is what color you're choosing.

Make yourself uncomfortable

Here's the part that trips people up. Changing your thought loops feels weird. Really weird. When you've been thinking the same way for years, a new thought feels fake, forced, and uncomfortable, like wearing someone else's shoes.

That's not a sign you're doing it wrong. It's a sign you're doing it.

In the journal, I said: make yourself uncomfortable. Change your world. If you don't like it, you can always go back. I still think that's the right attitude. You're not signing a lifetime contract. You're running an experiment. Try thinking differently for a week, a month. See what happens. If your old way of thinking was really working better, it'll still be there waiting for you.

But I'll tell you what I've found, and what I've watched happen to a lot of people. Once you've tasted what it's like to live with a different set of loops, you almost never want to go back.

Stop. What I really meant was...

So how do you actually change a loop? I've tried a lot of methods, and the simplest one is still the one I put in the journal years ago.

The first step is just catching the thought. That sounds easy. It's not. Most of our loops run below the surface, like background music in a store. You don't notice it until someone points it out. So you have to start paying attention. For a while, it helps to actually write them down, noticing which thoughts keep showing up. Some people like to mark each one with an up arrow or a down arrow. Up arrow means it moves you forward. Down arrow means it holds you back.

You'll be amazed how many down arrows there are, and how few of them you ever questioned.

The second step is what to do in the moment. When you catch a down-arrow thought, you interrupt it. You literally say to yourself, "Stop! What I really meant was this..." And then you finish the sentence with the thought you'd rather have.

"I'm never going to get this done." Stop. What I really meant was: "This is a lot, and I'm going to knock out the most important piece first."

"I'm so stupid." Stop. What I really meant was: "I made a mistake, and I'm going to learn from it."

"They don't respect me." Stop. What I really meant was: "I don't know what they're thinking, and I'm going to earn respect by how I show up today."

"I'm so fat." Stop. What I really meant was: "I'm not where I want to be yet, and I'm taking care of my body today."

Notice that the replacement isn't a lie. It's not "I'm the smartest person in the world" or "I'm a perfect ten." Your brain would reject that immediately. It's a more accurate, more useful version of the same thought. You're not pretending. You're correcting.

And when you catch an up-arrow thought, you reward it. You build on it. You think a similar thought right after it. "I handled that customer well." Great, and what else did I handle well today? You're feeding the good loops so they grow stronger.

This takes repetition. In the journal I said to do it for seven days straight, no exceptions, and to keep repeating it until you get it. That's still my advice. The first few days, you'll catch maybe one out of every twenty negative thoughts. By the end of a week, maybe one in five. After a month, you'll start catching them before they even finish forming. That's when you know the loop is changing.

Better and better

Around the turn of the twentieth century, a French pharmacist named Émile Coué became famous for a simple method of self-suggestion. He noticed that the way patients talked to themselves about their medicine seemed to affect how well they felt, and he developed a practice built around a single sentence, which in English is usually rendered: "Every day, in every way, I'm getting better and better."

He had people repeat it, morning and night, in a relaxed, almost mechanical way. Not straining. Not trying to force belief. Just letting the

words wash through. His idea was that the imagination is more powerful than the will, and that if you gently and repeatedly feed your mind a thought, it will begin to act on it.

People have made fun of Coué for a century. It sounds too simple. But I think he was onto something, and it's the same thing we've been talking about. Thought loops don't care whether they're positive or negative. They just repeat. If you deliberately put a positive loop in, it'll start running on its own, just like the negative ones did.

Jose Silva, whom we'll talk about in the next chapter, built this same phrase into his own method decades later. He had people use a version of it while in a deeply relaxed state, to plant it deeper. We'll get into that. For now, I just want you to notice that some of the smartest people who've studied the mind over the last hundred years keep coming back to the same insight: you can install a new thought on purpose, and if you repeat it enough, it becomes yours.

Watch it like a movie

There's another practice from the journal that I think belongs here, and it's the opposite of fighting your thoughts. It's watching them.

In one of the weeks, I asked people to spend a day writing down how their time was spent, from the moment they woke up to the moment they put their head on the pillow. But the instruction was unusual. I said: don't write to judge, or to change. Just write. If you do it with a feeling of detachment, you'll be able to watch it from afar. Viewing it like a movie, you'll see patterns unfold.

You can do the same thing with your thoughts. Instead of getting pulled into every thought as it comes up, try stepping back and watching them go by, like you're sitting in a theater watching a movie about someone who happens to have your name.

This is a big shift. Most of us believe we are our thoughts. When the thought says "I'm a failure," we assume that's the truth about us. But if you can watch a thought, then you aren't the thought. You're the one watching. The thought is just something happening in the theater.

When you get some distance, thoughts lose a lot of their power. "I'm a failure" goes from a verdict to an interesting line of dialogue. You can notice it, recognize it as an old loop, and let it pass. You don't have to argue with it. You don't have to obey it. You just don't have to buy a ticket to every movie your mind wants to show you.

We raise our own demons

In the journal, I borrowed a line from Marcus Aurelius that I come back to all the time. "Today I escaped anxiety. Or no, I discarded it, because it was within me, in my own perceptions, not outside."

Then I wrote something I still believe: we raise our own demons. By chasing the hows and whys, and by making up meanings for things that might or might not be true, we build our own walls, set our own fires, and bring to life things that might not even be real.

So much of what makes us miserable isn't what happens. It's the story we tell ourselves about what happens. The boss sends a two-line email, and we spend the whole evening building a story about how we're about to be fired. A friend doesn't text back, and we decide they're mad at us. A customer walks off the lot, and we decide we're terrible at our jobs. None of those stories are facts. They're thoughts. Loops we've built out of fear.

Worry isn't real, at least not in the way we think it is. It's a form of fear about something that hasn't happened. Worry and anxiety are self-created, and that means they can be self-dismantled.

I don't say that lightly. I know anxiety can be serious, and sometimes it needs professional help, and there's no shame in that. But for the everyday worries that loop through most of our heads, the kind that keep us up at night over things that never actually happen, the first step is simply seeing them for what they are. Thoughts. Not facts. Stories we're telling in our own theater.

Thoughts are the enemy of action

There's a flip side to all this I want to make sure we don't miss. Sometimes the problem isn't negative thoughts. It's too many thoughts.

In the journal, when I wrote about taking one action toward your goals every day, I said something that surprised a few people: don't think about it. Thoughts are the enemy of action. Do it.

I stand by that. There's a time to think and plan, and there's a time to stop thinking and move. A lot of people get stuck in endless analysis. They think about going to the gym. They think about calling that person. They think about starting the business. They think and think and think until the moment has passed and the thinking has turned into a new loop: "I always think about it but never do it."

At some point, the most powerful thing you can do with a thought is ignore it and act. The world belongs to those who have a moment's courage to do what others won't. Not a lifetime of courage. A moment. Just long enough to get started before your brain talks you out of it.

Loops other people installed

Here's a hard truth about thought loops: a lot of yours weren't written by you.

Think about where your most persistent thoughts came from. The voice that says you're lazy might sound suspiciously like a parent. The one that says you're not smart might be a teacher from fourth grade. The one that says money is scarce might be the sound of your family arguing over bills when you were small. The one that says you have to be perfect to be loved might have been installed by a coach, an ex, or a culture that never let up.

We absorb these loops when we're young and don't have the tools to question them. And then we carry them for decades, repeating them to ourselves in our own voice, until we forget they were ever someone else's words.

When you catch a down-arrow thought, it can help to ask a simple question: whose voice is this? Not to blame anyone. Most of the people who installed those loops were doing their best with the loops that had been installed in them. But noticing that a thought came from outside

you makes it easier to set it down. It's not the truth about you. It's an old recording.

Once you can hear it as a recording, you get to decide whether to keep playing it.

Guarding the door

Jennifer's note about reprogramming your information intake, which I mentioned back in Chapter 3, belongs here too, because what you let into your mind becomes raw material for your loops.

If you spend an hour a day consuming outrage, your mind will loop outrage. If you spend an hour a day comparing yourself to highlight reels, your mind will loop inadequacy. If you fall asleep to true crime, don't be surprised when your mind loops fear. Your brain doesn't distinguish much between "stuff I chose to think about" and "stuff I watched." It's all fuel.

I'm not saying you have to live in a bubble. Stay informed. Know what's going on in the world. But be deliberate about the mix. For every hour of noise, find some signal. A book that makes you better. A podcast from someone who's walked a road you want to walk. A conversation with someone who lifts you up. Silence, even. Silence is underrated fuel.

You wouldn't put garbage in the gas tank of a car you cared about. Your mind deserves at least as much care as your car.

Catch it, name it, change it

When I'm trying to break a thought loop, I use a simple three-step process. It's not fancy, but it works.

First, catch it. That's the hardest part, because loops run so smoothly we don't even notice them. You have to become a kind of detective in your own head. The clue is usually a feeling. A heaviness. A tightness in your chest. A sudden drop in energy. When I feel that, I stop and ask, "What was I just thinking?" Nine times out of ten, I find the loop right there, humming along in the background.

Second, name it. Give it a label. "That's the not-good-enough loop." "That's the they're-all-against-me loop." "That's the worst-case-scenario loop." Naming it does something important. It creates distance. Suddenly it's not me thinking. It's a loop running, and I'm the one watching it. That little bit of space is where your power lives.

Third, change it. Replace the loop with something deliberate. A question. "What would it take?" "What's good about this?" A gratitude. Something you can see, right now, that you're thankful for. Or an action. Stand up, walk, drink water, call someone. The body can break a loop the mind can't.

Catch it, name it, change it. Do it once, and it feels clumsy. Do it a hundred times, and you start catching loops faster. Do it a thousand times, and the old loops start running less often, because you've worn new tracks in their place.

You become what you repeat

Let's come back to where we started, with the ladder. Thoughts become words, words become actions, actions become habits, habits become character, and character becomes destiny.

This is the identity piece again, and it's why I care so much about thought loops. Your identity isn't some fixed thing sitting in your chest. It's built, and a lot of it is built out of thoughts you've repeated so many times that they've hardened into beliefs about who you are.

"I'm not a morning person" started as a thought on a tired day. You repeated it. You said it out loud. You acted like it. It became a habit. Now it's who you are.

The good news is that the same process can build a new identity. "I'm someone who takes care of myself" can start as a thought that feels fake. You repeat it. You say it. You act on it, even just a little. It becomes a habit. And one day, you realize it's just true.

Every thought you repeat is a vote for who you're becoming. Most of us have been voting on autopilot for years. The ballot's been filled in by our parents, our past, and whatever's on our phone.

Start voting on purpose.



CHAPTER TEN

Alpha

WHEN I WAS IN fourth grade, my mom decided to try meditation for the first time.

She got herself all set up. Found a quiet spot. Sat down. Closed her eyes. And then she took a three-hour nap.

My dad and I have been making jokes about it ever since. I'm pretty sure we'll still be making jokes about it when we're all very old. Every time meditation comes up in conversation, somebody in my family asks if you're planning to sit down or lie down, and whether we should wake you for dinner.

I tell that story because I love my mom and because it's funny, but also because it captures what a lot of people think meditation is. You sit down, you close your eyes, and you either fall asleep or you sit there feeling bored and silly, waiting for something mystical to happen. Neither one sounds very useful.

That's not the kind of meditation I'm talking about. And in this chapter I want to show you why the quiet, relaxed mind is one of the most powerful places you can work from, and how I use it every single day to run the three big ideas of this book: gratitude, focus, and becoming someone new.

Touchy-feely? Maybe. Useful? Absolutely.

In the journal, I introduced meditation with a little joke: it can't be a touchy-feely journaling experience without some meditation. Are you ready for this? YES! I knew you were.

I was poking fun at myself, because I know how it sounds. A car guy telling you to sit quietly and breathe. But I've come to believe that a few minutes of deliberate stillness each day is one of the highest-return investments you can make. Not because it makes you mellow. Because it gives you access to your own mind in a way that's nearly impossible when you're rushing around.

Think about the state you're usually in during the day. Phone buzzing. Emails stacking up. Somebody at your door with a problem. Your brain is revved up, bouncing from thing to thing, reacting. That state is useful for getting a lot of small things done fast. But it's a terrible state for changing anything deep. It's like trying to reprogram a computer while it's running fifty programs at once.

Stillness shuts down the extra programs. It lets you get underneath the noise to the operating system.

There's a line often attributed to Deepak Chopra that I put in the journal: prayer is you speaking to God, and meditation is allowing the spirit to speak to you. Whatever your beliefs, I think there's something true in that. Most of our lives are spent talking, to other people and to ourselves, in that nonstop inner monologue. Meditation is the practice of shutting up long enough to hear something else.

Slowing down on purpose

Here's a little of the science, kept general and simple, because I don't want to oversell it.

Your brain runs on electrical activity, and when researchers measure that activity with sensors on the scalp, they see patterns that change depending on your state. When you're wide awake, alert, and busy, the brain tends to show faster activity, often called beta waves. When you relax, close your eyes, and let your mind settle, especially in that drowsy, calm

state right before sleep or just after waking, the brain tends to show slower activity called alpha waves. Go deeper into sleep and the activity slows down even further.

Alpha is the relaxed-but-awake zone. You're not asleep. You're aware. But you're calm, loose, and not grinding. A lot of people naturally pass through it when they're daydreaming, or lying in bed in the morning before they're fully up, or in that pleasant zoned-out feeling on a long drive.

What I've come to believe, based on my own experience and on the work of people who've studied this far more than I have, is that this relaxed state is a great place to do mental work. It's easier to picture things vividly. It's easier to feel emotions deeply. And the constant chatter of the critical mind, the voice that says "That's stupid" and "You can't do that," gets quieter.

Which brings me to a man from Laredo, Texas.

Jose Silva

Jose Silva was born in 1914 in Laredo, Texas. He grew up poor, lost his father young, and started working as a kid to help support his family. He never had much formal schooling. He taught himself electronics and eventually ran a successful radio and electronics repair business.

In the 1940s, Silva got curious about the human mind. He'd been studying psychology on his own and was interested in hypnosis, and he started wondering whether he could use relaxation techniques to help his own children do better in school. His thinking, the way he told it, was that the brain is an electrical system, and since he knew a lot about electrical systems, maybe there were ways to get it working more effectively. He was especially interested in what might happen if a person could learn to be in that relaxed, alpha-level state on purpose, while staying awake and aware, and then use that state for learning and problem solving.

He spent years experimenting and refining his methods, and in the 1960s he began teaching them publicly. It became known as the Silva Mind Control Method, later just the Silva Method, and it spread around the world. Millions of people have taken some version of the course.

I want to be fair here. Some of Silva's claims went well beyond anything science has confirmed, especially the more mystical stuff about psychic abilities. I'm not going to vouch for all of that, and I'm not asking you to buy it. What I've taken from Silva is the practical core, the part I've tested in my own life. That core is this: you can learn to relax your mind deliberately, and in that relaxed state, you can use visualization to rehearse, to solve problems, and to program what you want to focus on.

How Silva taught it

The heart of Silva's approach was a simple way to get into a relaxed state and then use it.

To get there, he taught a countdown method. You close your eyes, take a few deep breaths, and relax your body from head to toe. Then you count down slowly, and with each number you let yourself go a little deeper into relaxation. His basic version used a countdown from three to one, and then from ten to one, with each number taking you a step further into calm. With practice, you learn to reach that state faster and faster.

Once you're there, Silva had people imagine what he called a mental screen. Picture a movie screen, slightly above the level of your eyes, about six feet away from you. That's where you do your mental work. You project images onto it.

One of his best-known techniques is called the Mirror of the Mind. Here's the way I understand and use it. In your relaxed state, you picture a big mirror in front of you with a blue frame. In that blue-framed mirror, you see the problem as it is right now, clearly and honestly. Maybe it's you, overweight and tired. Maybe it's a business that's struggling. Maybe it's a relationship that's strained. You look at it without flinching.

Then you let that image fade or move it off to the side. And you bring in a new mirror, this one with a white frame. In the white-framed mirror, you see the solution. The problem solved. You, healthy and strong. The business thriving. The relationship repaired. You make this image as vivid

as you possibly can. Colors, sounds, feelings. You step into it and let yourself feel what it would feel like for this to be real.

Silva also taught something called the Three Fingers Technique. You press the tips of your thumb and first two fingers together while you're in that relaxed state, so that the gesture becomes connected to it. Later, you can use the same gesture to help bring yourself back to a calm, focused state quickly. It's a lot like what athletes do with a pre-shot routine. A physical cue that tells the brain, "We're doing this now."

Why visualization works

I'm not going to make big scientific claims about visualization. What I'll tell you is something that's widely accepted: athletes, musicians, surgeons, and other performers have used mental rehearsal for a long time as part of their training. Picturing yourself making the free throw, playing the piece, doing the procedure, over and over, in detail, is a standard tool in a lot of fields. The mind rehearses, and the body benefits.

In the journal, I described a strategy for reaching your goals that went like this. Determine your outcome, what you want to happen. Put yourself in the state, the zone, where your mind is clear and you have total clarity on your purpose. Feel your passion in that state and see your outcome over and over again until your mind can't tell it apart from a reality or a memory you've actually experienced. Then take action right now toward that outcome, and keep changing your approach until you get there.

I didn't mention Silva by name back then, but that's his fingerprint all over it. Get into the state. See it. Feel it. Rehearse it until it's familiar.

Here's why I think this works, and it ties right back to the other things we've talked about.

First, it programs your filter. When you vividly picture an outcome in a relaxed state, you're telling your brain, in the most powerful language it understands, what matters. Images and feelings speak louder to the filter than words do. After a session like that, you walk into your day with your brain primed to notice anything related to what you pictured.

Second, it builds identity. Remember, we act consistently with who we believe we are. Visualization lets you practice being the new you before you are the new you. You see yourself walking into the gym, turning down the drink, staying calm in the tough meeting. Over and over. Until the new you starts to feel familiar. By the time you actually face the situation, part of you feels like you've already been there. You're not acting against your identity anymore. You've expanded it.

Third, it cuts fear down to size. Fear feeds on the unknown. When you rehearse a hard situation in your mind, it becomes a little more known. And the more known it is, the less power the fear has.

My practice

Let me walk you through what I actually do. This isn't a prescription. It's just what works for me, pieced together from Silva, from years of trial and error, and from a few other teachers along the way. I put an early version of it in the journal, and it's evolved a little since then, but the bones are the same.

First, I find a quiet, comfortable place. I like to do this in the morning, before the day gets crazy. I sit upright, comfortable, with my back straight.

Then I do a breathing exercise that yoga people call breath of fire. I take thirty quick breaths in and out through my nose only. Then I do that twice more. Three sets. (A quick note: if you have any health issues, especially with your heart or blood pressure, check with a doctor before doing forceful breathing like this. And if you ever feel dizzy, stop and breathe normally.) By the end of the third set, my body is buzzing a little, and my mind has usually stopped racing through the to-do list.

As I finish the third set, I place both hands on my heart. And with my hands there, I think of three very specific things I'm grateful for. Each one is a single experience in time. A specific moment with a specific person. I go back into it. I remember my emotions at the time. The colors around me. The smells. The temperature. I don't list them. I relive them.

Jennifer is always first.

As I create each of those three moments, I offer thanks. To God, to the universe, to whatever feels right to you. I've never cared much what name you use. What matters is that the gratitude has somewhere to go.

When I'm finished with the gratitude, I let my body go still. I rest my hands on my knees. With my eyes closed, I let my gaze drift upward, as if I'm looking toward the top of my head. And I imagine a black dot right in front of me.

The whole world is behind me. All that exists is me and that dot.

I breathe easy. As thoughts come, and they will, every single time, I thank them for their intention and let them go. I picture them floating away while I stay focused on the dot. I don't fight them. Fighting a thought just gives it more attention. I just acknowledge it and return to the dot.

Once I'm settled, I stay there as long as feels right. Sometimes that's a couple of minutes. Sometimes it's longer. If there's something I'm working on, this is when I'll use it. I'll bring up the white-framed mirror, or I'll rehearse a tough conversation I have coming up, or I'll picture the version of myself I'm becoming and let myself feel what it's like to be him.

When I'm ready to come out, I slowly bring my gaze back to straight ahead. I watch the black dot disappear into the horizon of my mind. Then I open my eyes, take a deep breath in, let it out, and offer thanks for the life I have.

That's it. On a busy morning it takes ten minutes. On a slow one, maybe twenty.

Why gratitude goes first

People sometimes ask me why I start with gratitude instead of going straight to visualization. The answer is that gratitude sets the state.

If I sit down and immediately try to visualize my goals, I'm often doing it from a place of lack. I'm picturing what I want because I don't have it, and part of me is anxious about not having it. That anxiety leaks into the picture. It's like painting on a dirty canvas.

When I start with gratitude, I clean the canvas first. My body relaxes. My heart opens. I'm not grasping anymore. And from that place, when I picture what I want, it feels like possibility instead of desperation. It's the difference between "I need this or I'm a failure" and "Wouldn't this be wonderful?"

Remember what I said in the chapter on gratitude: it's impossible to be fearful when you're truly grateful. Starting with gratitude means the rest of the session happens in a mind that isn't afraid. And a mind that isn't afraid can imagine much bigger things.

Using the edges of sleep

One more tip. You don't have to wait for a formal meditation session to use the relaxed state. You pass through it naturally twice a day: right as you're falling asleep, and right as you're waking up.

Those moments are gold. Most of us waste them. We fall asleep scrolling our phones, filling our minds with whatever the algorithm decided to show us. We wake up and immediately grab the phone again, letting the news or our inbox set the tone for the day.

Try something different. Right before you fall asleep, when you're already drifting, run through your three gratitude moments. Or picture yourself tomorrow, handling the day the way the best version of you would. And in the morning, before you reach for the phone, lie there for a minute and do the same.

In the journal, when I asked people to write down their dreams for three minutes straight, I told them to read it every night before bed and every morning when they woke up. I didn't know the science of it back then. I just knew those were the moments when the words seemed to sink in deepest. Now I think I understand why.

When you can't sit still

I know some people read a chapter like this and think, "That's great, but I can't sit still for ten minutes. My brain won't allow it." I get it. For years, sitting quietly felt like torture to me. My mind would race and my leg

would bounce and I'd open my eyes after ninety seconds convinced I'd been there for a half hour.

If that's you, start smaller and get creative. You don't have to do it my way.

Try one minute. Seriously, one. Set a timer, close your eyes, take three slow breaths, and think of one thing you're grateful for, felt in your body. That's a meditation. Tomorrow, try two minutes.

Try moving. Some people find stillness easier while walking. A slow walk where you pay attention to your breath and your footsteps, and let your mind settle, can do a lot of the same work.

Try the car. Not while you're driving in traffic, obviously, but those few minutes after you park, before you walk into work or into the house. Sit. Breathe. Set your state. Picture how you want the next few hours to go. I've done more good mental work in parking lots than I'd like to admit.

Try prayer, if that's your tradition. Many of the people I respect most do their version of this work on their knees. The form matters much less than the practice of getting quiet and turning your attention on purpose.

The goal isn't to become a monk. It's to have a place, even a small one, where you can step out of reaction mode and set your filter by hand.

Rehearsing the hard stuff

One of the most practical ways I use the relaxed state isn't for big life goals. It's for the next hard thing on my calendar.

Say I have a tough conversation coming up. Maybe I have to let someone go, or give difficult feedback, or deal with an upset customer who's been escalated to me. In my quiet time that morning, I'll run it. I picture the room. I picture the person. I see myself calm, clear, kind, and direct. I imagine them getting upset, and I watch myself stay steady. I imagine a few different ways it could go, and I see myself handling each one.

By the time I walk into the actual conversation, my body has, in a sense, already been there. My heart rate doesn't spike the same way. My

words come easier. I'm more present with the person in front of me instead of stuck in my own nerves.

It's the same thing athletes do before a big game. It works for regular life, too.

The quiet before the storm

There's one more reason I guard my morning quiet so carefully, and it has to do with leadership.

When you're responsible for other people, the day will try to grab you before your feet hit the floor. Texts from managers. A problem from overnight. An email from a customer who's upset. If I let those in first, I spend the whole morning reacting, and my team gets a leader who's scattered and reactive.

If I take my ten or twenty minutes first, I walk into the building already settled. I've already felt grateful. I've already set my filter. I've already rehearsed the hardest thing on my calendar. When the problems show up, and they always do, I meet them from a steady place instead of a frantic one.

The people who work with you can tell the difference, even if they couldn't explain it. A calm leader makes a calm building. A frantic one makes a frantic building. Those minutes of quiet in the morning aren't a luxury. For anyone responsible for other people, they might be the most important minutes of the day.

It's not about emptying your mind

I want to clear up one last myth. A lot of people give up on meditation because they think the goal is to empty their mind completely, and they can't do it. Thoughts keep coming. They decide they're bad at it and quit.

Nobody empties their mind. Not me, not the monks, not anyone. Thoughts are going to come. The practice isn't having no thoughts. The practice is noticing the thought and coming back. Noticing and coming back. Every time you do that, you're strengthening the muscle of atten-

tion, which is exactly the muscle you need to run your filter on purpose during the rest of the day.

So if you sit down and your mind wanders a hundred times in ten minutes, congratulations. You got a hundred reps.

And if you fall asleep? Well. You're in good company. My mom would be proud.



CHAPTER ELEVEN

State Before Strategy

PICTURE THE SAME SALESPERSON on two different days.

On Monday, he slept well, hit the gym, had a good breakfast, and on the drive in he listened to something that fired him up. He walks onto the lot with his shoulders back and a real smile on his face. A couple pulls in, and he greets them like he's genuinely glad they came, because he is. He asks good questions. He listens. When they raise an objection, he's curious about it instead of rattled. They buy.

On Thursday, he slept four hours because the baby was up. He skipped breakfast. On the drive in, he scrolled through bad news at every red light and had an argument with his brother over text. He walks onto the lot hunched over, jaw tight, already tired. A couple pulls in, and he greets them with a forced smile that doesn't reach his eyes. He talks too much. When they raise an objection, he gets defensive. They leave.

Same guy. Same skills. Same product. Same training. Completely different result.

What changed wasn't his strategy. It was his state.

Your state runs the show

Tony Robbins has built a huge part of his teaching around this idea. The way he puts it, your state determines your behavior. Not your knowledge, not your talent, not your intentions. Your state. The emotional and physical condition you're in at any given moment decides what you do with everything else you've got.

Think about it. You already know how to be patient with your kids. You know how to eat healthy. You know how to handle a tough customer. You know how to talk to your spouse without starting a fight. Knowing isn't the problem. The problem is that when you're in a lousy state, all that knowledge goes out the window. You snap at the kids, you eat the donut, you get defensive with the customer, and you pick the fight.

Bruce Lee said, "Knowing is not enough, we must apply. Willing is not enough, we must do." I used that line in the journal, and I think the missing link between knowing and doing is very often state. You apply what you know when you're in a state that makes it possible.

So if you want to change your results, one of the most powerful places to start isn't learning more. It's learning to manage your state.

Robbins teaches that your state is shaped by a few big things. How you use your body. What you focus on. And the meaning you give to what's happening, which shows up in the words you use and the questions you ask. We've already talked about focus, and about language and questions. Let's talk about the body, because it's the fastest lever you've got.

Motion creates emotion

Robbins has a phrase for this too: motion creates emotion. The way you move your body changes the way you feel.

Try it right now. Slump down in your chair. Drop your shoulders. Let your head hang a little. Breathe shallow. Frown. Now try to feel excited and confident. It's really hard, isn't it? Your body is sending your brain a message that says "defeated," and your brain is listening.

Now sit up straight. Pull your shoulders back. Lift your chin. Take a big, deep breath. Put a smile on your face, even a fake one. Now try to feel depressed. It's hard to do that, too.

I'm not claiming a power pose will fix your life. But the connection between the body and the mind runs both ways, and most of us only use it in one direction. We let our mood decide our posture. We rarely use our posture to decide our mood.

This is part of why I'm such a believer in physical exercise. Yes, it's good for your heart and your weight. But the bigger reason, for me, is what it does to my state. After a hard thirty minutes, I'm a different person. More patient. More confident. More grateful. Clearer. The problems I walked into the gym with look smaller when I walk out.

It's also why Jennifer's note in the margin of the journal was so smart. If you don't feel motivated or enthusiastic, act like it. Within a few minutes, you'll actually start to feel it for real. That's not fake-it-till-you-make-it nonsense. It's how the machinery works. Move like the person you want to be, and your brain starts to feel like that person.

Breath

If the body is the fastest lever for your state, the breath is the fastest part of the body.

When you're anxious, your breathing gets fast and shallow, high up in your chest. When you're calm, it's slow and deep, down in your belly. You can go the other direction, too. Slow your breath on purpose, and your body starts to calm down.

Before a hard conversation, a big presentation, or a tough negotiation, I'll often take a few slow, deep breaths, making the exhale longer than the inhale. It's not mystical. It just tells my nervous system that there's no tiger in the room. And when my nervous system settles, I think better, I listen better, and I say fewer things I'll regret.

The breath of fire I described in the last chapter does the opposite. It wakes me up and energizes me. Different breath, different state. Once you

know you can use your breath like a dial, you'll find yourself reaching for it all day long.

Beat the day before it shows up in a tank

If you've ever played golf, poker, a video game, bowling, or anything that takes more mental focus than physical effort, you know that the game is often won before it's ever played. It's the old line usually credited to Henry Ford: whether you think you can or think you can't, you're right.

Most of us don't lose our days in the afternoon. We lose them in the first hour.

Here's how it goes for a lot of people. You wake up with great intentions, feeling like good things are going to happen today. Then the chaos begins. Maybe you wake up late and you're in reaction mode from the jump, and it follows you all day. Or maybe you get up early, hit the gym, have the best intentions on the drive in, and then at ten or noon or two, boom. Something you weren't expecting happens, and the waves of reaction start sweeping over you again and again, knocking you on your butt and threatening to drown you.

So what do you do? How do you stop living in reaction?

Plan. Keep calm. Take control.

A lot of stress comes from feeling out of control. In the journal, I got a little dramatic about it and said stress isn't real, that it's a form of fear, of anxiety, a life-sucking spirit that brings nothing good with it. I'd put it a little more carefully now. Stress is real, and some of it is useful. But a lot of the stress we carry isn't about what's actually happening. It's about feeling like we're at the mercy of what's happening.

The fix I gave in the journal is still one of the most effective things I know. Get up thirty minutes earlier than you normally would. Use that time to decide what you want to accomplish that day. Keep your targets specific and doable, and don't let the list get too long. But have a plan. You have to beat the day before the day shows up at your door in a tank demanding to be let in.

When you've already decided what matters today, the unexpected stuff still shows up, but it doesn't knock you over. You deal with it, and then you go back to your plan. You're responding instead of reacting. That's a state thing, too. A person with a plan walks differently, breathes differently, and handles surprises differently than a person who's just waiting to see what gets thrown at them.

J.M. Barrie wrote in *Peter Pan*, "The moment you doubt whether you can fly, you cease for ever to be able to do it." The morning is where you decide whether you can fly today. Believe you can accomplish what you need to. Stay calm. Now go fly, Peter Pan.

What your body is telling everyone else

So far we've been talking about how your body affects your own state. But there's another side to this: your body is also broadcasting your state to everyone around you, all the time, whether you mean it to or not.

This is where Chase Hughes comes in. Hughes is a behavior expert who spent years in the U.S. Navy and has since built a career teaching people how to read behavior, understand influence, and become more aware of the signals we're all sending. He's written books like *The Ellipsis Manual* and *Six-Minute X-Ray*, and he's trained people in law enforcement, the military, and business.

I'm not going to pretend I've mastered his material. It goes deep. But there are a few ideas I've taken from him that have changed how I lead and how I carry myself, and they fit right into this chapter.

The first is the idea of a baseline. One of the biggest mistakes people make when trying to read others is jumping to conclusions from a single gesture. Crossed arms mean they're closed off! Touching the nose means they're lying! Hughes's approach, as I understand it, is much smarter than that. Before you can read anyone, you have to know how they normally act when they're relaxed. What's their normal posture, their normal speed of talking, their normal amount of eye contact? Only once you know someone's baseline can you notice meaningful changes from it.

That's a huge lesson for anyone in sales or leadership, and honestly for anyone in a marriage. You stop making snap judgments about people and start paying real attention. You notice when your best salesperson, who's normally loud and animated, has gone quiet for three days. You notice when a customer who was leaning in and asking questions suddenly leans back and stops talking. You notice when your spouse's voice has a little edge in it that isn't usually there. Those changes are information. They're a chance to ask a question, to check in, to care.

Awareness starts with you

The second idea I've taken from Hughes is that awareness has to start with yourself. Before you worry about reading other people, learn to read you.

What are your nervous habits? Do you fidget with your pen, bounce your leg, touch your face, talk faster when you're anxious? Do you overexplain when you're unsure of yourself? Do you apologize constantly? Do you rush?

Hughes talks a lot about how certain behaviors signal confidence and authority, and others signal anxiety or a need for approval. A lot of it lines up with common sense once you hear it. People who are calm and confident tend to move more deliberately. They don't rush. They don't overexplain or keep seeking reassurance. They're comfortable with a pause. People who are anxious tend to do the opposite, and everyone around them picks up on it, even if they couldn't tell you why.

I've watched this play out on the showroom floor for years. The customer doesn't know anything about body language theory, but they can feel whether the person in front of them is anxious or grounded. They can feel whether they're being pushed or helped. The salesperson who's anxious about making the sale leaks that anxiety through every gesture, and the customer backs away from it. The salesperson who's calm, curious, and genuinely focused on helping gives off a completely different signal, and people relax around them.

Here's where it ties back to state. You can't fake this stuff for long. You can try to control your gestures, but if you're anxious underneath, it'll leak out somewhere. The real fix is to change your state. When you're genuinely grateful, genuinely focused on the other person, genuinely calm, your body takes care of itself. The signals match because they're real.

And I'll add one thing, because I think it matters. Influence is a tool, and like any tool it can be used well or badly. The point of understanding behavior isn't to manipulate people. It's to understand them better, to serve them better, and to make sure the signals you're sending line up with the person you actually want to be. That's the only kind of influence I'm interested in.

Choose your role

In the journal, there's a week with an epigraph that's just me. "You are a Warrior!" - Joe Adams. I'll admit, putting my own name under a quote felt a little bold. But I wanted to make a point about state and identity that I've never found better words for.

In our lives, we all play a lot of roles. I listed some of them back then. A child in need of others, and we all do that as adults every day. A villain, when we make decisions we're not proud of. A giddy teenager, when we meet someone whose affection we want. A miser, when we're broke. And, honestly, sometimes a miser when we're not broke, too. A saint, when we give. A lover, in the arms of the person we love.

We slip in and out of those roles all day long, mostly without choosing. Something happens, and we react, and before we know it we're playing the victim or the villain or the scared kid.

What if you chose your role on purpose?

What if, for one day, you chose to play the warrior? Not a bully. A warrior. Someone who takes charge of their life. Someone who makes decisions and follows through on what they say. Someone who makes things happen and then comes back for more. What would that warrior look like

at breakfast? In traffic? In a tough meeting? Walking in the door at home at the end of a long day?

This is state management and identity work rolled into one. When you choose a role, you're choosing a state, and you're giving your body a template to follow. The warrior stands a certain way, breathes a certain way, talks a certain way. When you step into that role, your physiology follows. And when your physiology follows, your feelings follow. And when you play the role often enough, it stops being a role. It becomes you.

That's how identity change actually happens, a lot of the time. Not with a single dramatic decision, although sometimes it is. More often, it's by choosing a role again and again until one day you realize you're not playing anymore.

It is our choices

There's a line from Dumbledore in the Harry Potter books that I put in the journal: "It is our choices, Harry, that show what we truly are, far more than our abilities."

I love that line because it takes the pressure off talent. You don't have to be the most gifted person in the room. You have to make better choices. And the single biggest factor in whether you make good choices in any given moment is the state you're in when you make them.

When you're exhausted, scared, angry, or ashamed, you'll make choices you regret. When you're rested, calm, grateful, and focused, you'll make choices you're proud of. That's true for pretty much everybody.

So before you work on your strategy, work on your state. Before you plan the conversation, get your body right. Before you make the big decision, take a breath, check your posture, remind yourself of three things you're grateful for, and ask a better question.

Strategy matters. But a great strategy executed from a lousy state will lose to a decent strategy executed from a great one, almost every time.

The boring foundations

I'd be doing you a disservice if I talked about state management and skipped the boring stuff, because the boring stuff is where most of it lives.

Sleep. If you're chronically short on sleep, no breathing technique or power posture is going to save you. Everything gets harder. Your patience shrinks. Your cravings grow. Your mind gets foggy and more negative. I resisted this for years, because in the car business the culture used to celebrate long hours and short nights. I was wrong. A rested version of me is a better leader, a better husband, and a better decision-maker than an exhausted one, every time.

Food. What you eat changes how you feel, often within hours. A lunch that's all sugar and white flour tends to lead to a crash in the afternoon, and a crashed brain makes lousy decisions. I'm not a nutritionist and I won't pretend to be one, but I've noticed the pattern in myself too many times to ignore it.

Water. It sounds too simple to matter. It matters.

Movement. We've covered this, but it bears repeating. Even ten minutes of walking can shift a bad state.

None of this is exciting. Nobody writes motivational posters about getting to bed on time. But if you want to manage your state, start by giving your body what it needs to have a decent state in the first place. You can't build a skyscraper on sand.

Borrowing someone else's state

Here's a trick I've used more times than I can count. When I can't find the state I need, I borrow one.

I'll think of someone who handles this kind of situation beautifully, and I'll ask myself how they would stand, breathe, and talk right now. How would Steve handle this phone call? How would my Uncle Philip approach this frustrating round of golf? How would Jennifer walk into this room?

Then I try it on. I adjust my posture to match. I slow my speech the way they would. I pick the words they'd pick.

It's the same principle as choosing a role, just with a specific person as the model. And it works because our brains are wired to learn by imitation. We've been copying the people around us since we were babies. You might as well do it on purpose, and choose good models.

State is contagious

Your state doesn't stay inside you. It leaks out into every room you walk into.

I've seen this more times than I can count at work. One person comes into a meeting frustrated, and within ten minutes the whole room is tense. One person comes in calm and upbeat, and the room lightens. We pick up on each other's states without even realizing it. Posture, tone of voice, facial expressions. We're wired to read those things and mirror them.

This is a responsibility, and it's also an opportunity.

It's a responsibility because if you walk into your home or your job in a bad state, you're handing that state to everyone around you. Your kids feel it. Your spouse feels it. Your team feels it.

It's an opportunity because the reverse is also true. If you take the time to build a good state before you walk in, you can lift the whole room. You don't even have to say anything special. Just being grounded and grateful and present changes the temperature.

Before I walk into my house at the end of the day, I try to take a minute in the car. Just a minute. Breathe. Think of what I'm grateful for about the people inside. Let the workday go. I don't always remember. But on the days I do, I walk in as a better husband and a better person to be around.

Build your state on purpose

Let me pull this together into what it looks like day to day, because none of this matters if it stays in your head.

In the morning, I set my state before the world gets a chance to. Gratitude, breath, movement, and a plan for the day. That's my foundation.

During the day, I check in with my body. Especially before anything important. How am I standing? How am I breathing? What am I focusing on? What am I telling myself about what's happening? If any of those are off, I adjust. A deep breath. Shoulders back. A better question. A quick gratitude hit.

When I notice myself slipping into a role I don't want, the victim, the grump, the anxious guy, I name it. "Oh, I'm playing the victim right now." Just naming it takes away half its power. Then I choose a different one.

When I'm around other people, I try to pay attention to their baseline and to mine. Not to manipulate. To understand, and to make sure I'm showing up the way I want to.

And at night, I think back on the day and notice the moments where my state ran the show, for better or worse. Where did a good state lead to a good choice? Where did a lousy one lead to a bad one? No judgment. Just learning.

You are not a helpless passenger in your own body. You can take the wheel. It takes practice. It takes attention. But once you know how, you'll wonder how you ever let your mood drive.

You are a warrior. Stand like one.



CHAPTER TWELVE

Callus the Mind

THERE'S A STORY I think about every time I'm tempted to quit a workout early.

A young man is working nights as an exterminator, spraying for cockroaches in restaurants. He's in his mid-twenties and weighs close to three hundred pounds. He's miserable. He comes home from his shift, eats, watches television, and does it all again the next night. By his own account, he's full of fear and insecurity and has spent most of his life running from anything hard.

One night he's watching a documentary about Navy SEAL training, and something in him wakes up. He wants that. He wants to be the kind of person who could make it through that. The problem is that he's about a hundred pounds too heavy to even qualify. So he starts calling recruiters, and most of them won't take him seriously. Finally one tells him that if he can get his weight down in a very short window, there might be a spot.

He loses over a hundred pounds in under three months.

That man is David Goggins. He went on to become a Navy SEAL, making it through the brutal Hell Week portion of training three times because of injuries and setbacks that sent him back. Then he went

through Army Ranger School. Then he became an ultramarathon runner, finishing some of the hardest endurance races on the planet. At one point he set a world record for the most pull-ups done in twenty-four hours.

He tells all of this in his book *Can't Hurt Me*, and when I read it, the part that grabbed me wasn't the SEAL stuff or the records. It was the guy at the start. The overweight exterminator coming home to the couch. Because I'd been that guy, in my own way. I'd stood in a bathroom and stared at a mirror and seen someone I didn't recognize. My number was 271. His was close to 300. Different lives, same moment.

What he did next is what I want to talk about in this chapter. Because Goggins has put words to something I'd felt but never quite named: you can train your mind the same way you train your body. You can make it tougher. You can callus it.

Soft hands, soft minds

Think about what happens to your hands if you start lifting weights or swinging a hammer or climbing rope. At first, it hurts. Blisters form. Your skin tears. It's uncomfortable and you want to stop. But if you keep going, something happens. The skin thickens. Calluses form. Eventually, the thing that used to tear you up doesn't bother you at all.

Goggins talks about callousing the mind in the same way. Every time you do something hard, something you didn't want to do, something that scared you or hurt or bored you, you build up a little toughness. Do it enough, and the things that used to break you barely register.

The opposite is also true. If you avoid every hard thing, your mind stays soft. Every small discomfort feels enormous. A cold morning feels unbearable. A tough conversation feels impossible. A slow week at work feels like the end of the world. It's not that those things are actually unbearable. It's that you've never built the calluses to handle them.

We live in a world that's designed to keep us soft. Food delivered to the door. Climate control everywhere. Entertainment on demand. None of that is bad by itself. I like a comfortable house as much as anyone. But if

you never choose discomfort, you'll find that your capacity for it shrinks, and then life, which always eventually delivers discomfort whether you choose it or not, will flatten you when it arrives.

Choosing hard on purpose

In the journal, I built a lot of weeks around this idea, even though I didn't have Goggins's language for it yet. Thirty minutes of all-out exercise, where "I think I'm going to die" should be part of the week at some point. Getting up an hour earlier than normal for seven days. Only one hour, one twenty-fourth of your day, about four percent of your time. Nothing, really. Eating clean for a week when everything in you screams for sugar.

The point of those weeks wasn't just the workouts or the diet. It was the calluses. It was proving to yourself that you could do hard things. Every time you drag yourself out of bed when the alarm goes off, you're not just getting an early start. You're putting a thin layer of toughness on your mind.

Marcus Aurelius wrestled with this exact problem, and he was the most powerful man in the world. In the *Meditations*, he writes a note to himself about how hard it is to get out of bed in the morning. In one well-known translation, he tells himself that at dawn, when you have trouble getting out of bed, remind yourself that you have to go to work as a human being. He asks himself whether he was made to huddle under the blankets and stay warm. It's a little comforting, honestly, that a Roman emperor struggled with the snooze button too. And it's instructive that his answer was the same as Goggins's, centuries apart. Get up. That's what you were made for.

The accountability mirror

One of the tools Goggins describes that I've found most powerful is something he calls the accountability mirror.

The way he tells it, he started putting sticky notes on his bathroom mirror. Not affirmations about how great he was. Hard truths. The

things he needed to face about himself. And the goals he was going to hit. Every morning he'd look at himself and at those notes and have an honest conversation. No excuses. No sugarcoating. Just the truth about where he was and what he needed to do.

When I read that, I thought right away about my own bathroom mirror at twenty-three. The stretch marks. The scale. That was an accountability mirror moment, but it happened by accident. I didn't choose to look. I just happened to raise my arm at the right angle. And because I'd been avoiding the truth for so long, it hit me like a truck.

What Goggins did differently was make it a daily practice. He didn't wait for the truth to ambush him. He went looking for it every single morning.

There's something important here that I want to handle carefully. An accountability mirror is not the same as beating yourself up. Goggins is famously intense, and some of his language about himself is pretty harsh. That style isn't for everyone, and I don't think you have to talk to yourself cruelly to be honest with yourself. What you do need is to stop lying.

Most of us are lying to ourselves about something. We say we're "trying" to eat better when we haven't changed a thing. We say we "don't have time" to work out when we spend two hours a night on our phones. We say our marriage is "fine" when we haven't had a real conversation in months. We say we'll "start Monday," and we've been saying it for three years.

The accountability mirror cuts through all of that. It asks you, every day, to name what's actually true. And then it asks what you're going to do about it.

This connects to the idea I talked about in the chapter on being a warning or an example. You can't become an example if you won't admit where you're a warning. And it connects to the honest record I mentioned in the first chapter. Not better, not worse, just as you are. That's what the mirror shows you. That's where the work starts.

The forty percent rule

This is the Goggins idea that I think about most often, usually around minute twenty of a hard workout, when my brain starts negotiating.

Goggins describes what he calls the forty percent rule. The idea is that when your mind starts telling you you're done, that you can't go any further, that you've hit your limit, you've actually only used about forty percent of what you're capable of. Your brain is trying to protect you. It sounds the alarm way before you're actually in danger, because it'd rather you stop early than risk running out completely. So that voice saying "I'm done" is really a governor, like the kind that keeps an engine from revving past a certain point. It's not the true limit. It's a safety margin.

Now, I want to be honest about what this is and isn't. The forty percent number is a rule of thumb, not a precise scientific measurement. Nobody's hooked up a gauge that reads exactly forty. Goggins is using it as a way to make a point, and the point is right: the limit you feel is almost always well short of the limit you actually have. And obviously, you should use judgment. If you're genuinely injured, or your body is sending real warning signals like chest pain, stop. There's a difference between the voice that says "this is uncomfortable" and the one that says "something is wrong." Learning to tell them apart is part of the training.

But for most of us, most of the time, it's the first voice. And the first voice lies.

I've felt this in the gym more times than I can count. I'll be on the last set and my brain will scream that I can't do another rep. And then I'll do three more. The same thing happens at work. It's eight at night at the end of a brutal month, and everything in me says I'm too tired to make one more call. I make the call, and it's often the one that matters most.

In the journal, one of the weeks asked people a question I've always liked: what if you had to overcome your limits? What if you didn't have a choice? No choice, gun to your head, have to get it done. What would you do? It's amazing how many "impossible" things become possible when you take quitting off the table. The limit didn't move. Your belief about the limit moved.

Richard Bach wrote in his book *Illusions*, "Argue for your limitations, and sure enough, they're yours." Most of us are world-class debaters when it comes to arguing for our limits. We have every reason why we can't. The forty percent rule is a way of calling your own bluff.

The cookie jar

Here's the Goggins idea that surprised me the most, because it's so close to what I've been saying about gratitude this whole book.

Goggins talks about something he calls the cookie jar. It's a mental jar, and into it goes every hard thing he's ever overcome. Every obstacle he's beaten. Every time he wanted to quit and didn't. Every small victory and every big one.

Then, when he's in the middle of something brutal, a race where his body is falling apart or a moment when everything in him wants to stop, he reaches into the jar. He pulls out a memory of a time he pushed through something hard. He reminds himself of who he's been. And it gives him fuel to keep going.

When I read that, I laughed out loud, because it's basically a gratitude practice for tough guys. It's looking back at your life and noticing what you've already survived and accomplished, and letting that change how you feel about right now. It's what I do every morning with my three gratitude moments, just aimed at a different target.

And it's another way of programming the filter. When you're struggling, your brain naturally scans for evidence that you're going to fail. The cookie jar deliberately floods it with evidence of the opposite. Look at what you've done before. You're not the kind of person who breaks. You have proof.

I have a cookie jar, too, even though I didn't call it that for a long time. There's the morning I walked away from drugs. There's the night I stopped eating after eight. There's the day I stood up from that toilet lid and decided what I was going to do with my life. There's the first time I stepped into a cage to fight, which I'll tell you about in a couple of chapters. And there are a thousand little ones. Early mornings. Hard conversa-

tions. Months where the numbers were terrible and we fought our way back.

When I'm in a tough spot, I reach in. I remember that I've been in worse spots. I remember who I was in those moments. And I remind myself that the guy who got out of the yellow room can handle a bad Tuesday.

You have a cookie jar too, whether you've ever opened it or not. You've survived one hundred percent of your worst days so far. You've done hard things. Maybe you haven't given yourself credit for them. Maybe you've been so focused on what's still wrong that you've never looked back at how far you've come. Start filling the jar. Start reaching into it. You've earned those cookies.

Never give up

Bear Grylls, the adventurer and survival expert, said something I put in the journal: survival can be summed up in three words, never give up. That's the heart of it, really. Just keep trying.

How many times have you tried to lose weight, cut back on drinking, or make it to the gym three times a week, only to watch your efforts fall apart in a pile of excuses and good intentions? Me too.

Here's what I wrote about that in the journal, and I still believe it. Guilt is the least useful emotion in that situation. Motivation, while a great start, has to be fed every day. Knowledge is great, but we all know sugar is bad for us, and how many times do we still give in to "just one donut"?

So with all the methods and mindsets out there, how do we keep going? How do we not give up?

The answer is simple, but not easy. We make the decision. It's not really about working out, or eating right, or kicking the habit. It's about making the decision and keeping the decision.

That's what callousing the mind really comes down to. Every time you keep a decision you made, especially when it's hard, you get a little tougher. And every time you break one, you get a little softer. Not be-

cause you're a bad person. Because you're teaching your mind that your decisions are negotiable.

Everyday calluses

You don't need to run an ultramarathon to callus your mind. Life hands you chances every single day, if you're looking for them.

Make the phone call you've been avoiding. Every salesperson knows the feeling of staring at a phone, knowing they need to call a customer who's upset, or follow up on a deal that went cold. Every minute you stare at it, the call gets heavier. Pick it up. That's a callus.

Have the conversation. The one with your spouse, your kid, your employee, your parent, the one you've been rehearsing in your head for weeks. Have it kindly, but have it. That's a callus.

Do the task you hate first. Whatever's sitting at the bottom of your list because it's boring or unpleasant, move it to the top and knock it out before lunch. That's a callus.

Take the stairs. Park at the far end of the lot. Skip the dessert once. Turn off the show at the end of the episode instead of letting the next one autoplay. Get up when the alarm goes off, the first time.

None of these are dramatic. That's the point. A callus isn't built by one heroic effort. It's built by a lot of small ones, repeated until the discomfort doesn't bother you anymore. Every one of these is a rep. Stack enough reps and you'll find that the things which used to stop you cold now barely slow you down.

The accountability friend

The accountability mirror works best if you're honest. But let's face it, sometimes we're very good at lying to ourselves, even in the mirror. That's where a friend comes in.

Find someone who will tell you the truth. Not someone who'll tear you down, but someone who cares enough to call you on it when you're making excuses. For me, that's been Steve for years, and it's always been

Jennifer. When I tell Jennifer I'm going to skip the gym because I'm "too busy," she's got a way of looking at me that makes me realize I'm full of it.

Tell that person what you're working on. Give them permission to check on you. And when they do, don't get defensive. Say thank you. They're helping you build calluses you might not build alone.

Discipline is a form of self-respect

For a long time, I thought of discipline as something harsh. A drill sergeant in my head, yelling at me to do things I didn't want to do. And sometimes it does feel like that.

But over the years, I've come to see it differently. Discipline is really a form of self-respect. Every time you keep a promise to yourself, you're treating yourself like someone whose word matters. Every time you do the hard thing because you said you would, you're telling yourself, "You're worth the effort."

Think about how you'd feel about a friend who constantly broke promises to you. Said they'd show up and didn't. Said they'd call and didn't. You'd stop trusting them. You'd stop taking them seriously. That's exactly what happens inside you when you keep breaking promises to yourself. You stop trusting yourself.

And the reverse is true. When you keep your word to yourself, day after day, you start trusting yourself. You start believing that when you say you'll do something, you will. That self-trust is the foundation of every big change. You can't become someone new if you don't believe your own promises.

So the next time the alarm goes off and you want to hit snooze, try thinking of it this way. You're not forcing yourself out of bed. You're keeping a promise to someone you respect.

Tough doesn't mean cruel

I want to close with a word of balance, because I think it matters.

Goggins is extreme. He's said so himself. His approach to his own body and mind is far more intense than most people need or want, and

some of it has cost him physically. I'm not telling you to go run a hundred-mile race on broken legs. I'm not telling you to talk to yourself like a drill sergeant twenty-four hours a day.

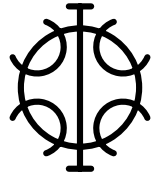
What I'm telling you is that there's a lot of room between where most of us live and where Goggins lives, and most of the growth happens in that room. You don't have to become him. You just have to stop running from every hard thing. Choose a little discomfort every day. Keep your word to yourself. Look in the mirror honestly. Fill the cookie jar. And when your mind says you're done, ask whether it's telling the truth.

It's also worth saying that toughness and gratitude aren't opposites. The toughest people I know are some of the most grateful. They've been through enough to know what matters. They don't take a warm bed or a good meal or a kind word for granted. Toughness without gratitude turns into bitterness. Gratitude without toughness can turn into complacency. Put them together, and you've got a person who can handle almost anything and still appreciate the good stuff when it comes.

Edmund Hillary, one of the first two men to reach the top of Mount Everest, is often credited with saying that it's not the mountain we conquer but ourselves. I think that's right. The mountain doesn't care. The race doesn't care. The early alarm doesn't care. The real opponent is the voice in your head that wants you to stay soft.

Callus that voice. One hard thing at a time.

And remember, the new you, the one we're chiseling out of the marble, is someone who does hard things. Not because they're forced to. Because that's just who they are.



PART FOUR

Face the Storm



CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Obstacle Is the Way

IMAGINE BEING THE MOST powerful man on earth and still having a lousy year.

Marcus Aurelius ruled the Roman Empire from 161 to 180 AD. On paper, it doesn't get any bigger than that. In reality, his reign was a grind. A devastating plague swept through the empire, killing enormous numbers of people. There were wars along the northern frontier that dragged on for years, and he spent long stretches of his rule living in military camps far from Rome, dealing with the fighting himself. He dealt with betrayal, including a general who declared himself emperor in a rebellion. He buried several of his children. By most accounts, his health wasn't great either.

And through all of it, he kept a private notebook. He wasn't writing for us. He was writing to himself, reminding himself how to think and how to act when everything around him was falling apart. Those notes survived, and today we call them *Meditations*.

One passage in particular has become famous, and it's become one of the guiding ideas of my life. In a widely read modern translation by Gregory Hays, it ends like this:

"The impediment to action advances action. What stands in the way becomes the way."

Read that again. What stands in the way becomes the way.

Marcus wasn't saying obstacles don't exist, or that they don't hurt. He was saying that the obstacle itself can become the path forward. The thing blocking you is also the thing that can teach you, strengthen you, or redirect you toward something better. It's raw material. You can't always choose the obstacle. You can choose what you do with it.

Happening for you

Tony Robbins, whom I've long thought of as one of my mentors, puts a modern spin on the same idea. He's often said that life is happening for you, not to you.

When I first heard that, I pushed back. Tell that to someone who just lost their job. Tell that to someone going through a divorce. Tell that to the nineteen-year-old in the yellow room. It sounded like the kind of thing people say when life's been pretty easy for them.

But the longer I've lived, the more I've found it to be true, not as a feel-good slogan, but as a practical way of seeing. When you look at a hard thing and ask, "How is this happening to me?" you're a victim. You're stuck. You wait for it to pass. When you look at the same hard thing and ask, "How might this be happening for me? What's it here to teach me? What's it making possible?" you're back in the driver's seat.

That's the filter again. The question aims your attention. Ask how it's happening to you, and your brain will list every way you've been wronged. Ask how it's happening for you, and your brain will start hunting for the seed of opportunity buried in the mess.

In the journal, I used a saying often credited to the Buddha: every experience, no matter how bad it seems, holds within it a blessing of some kind. The goal is to find it. Whether or not the Buddha actually said those words, I've found them to be true. Stated as simply as possible, every obstacle comes with a seed of success. You just have to find it.

The toilet lid, again

I've told you about sitting on that toilet lid after being left for someone with more money. In the moment, it was one of the worst days of my life. I would've done almost anything to make it not have happened.

And yet, that day is the reason I have the career I have. It's the day I asked a better question. It's the day I decided to chase sales, which turned into management, which turned into everything I've built since. If she hadn't left, I might have stayed comfortable. I might have kept asking how to pay my bills instead of how to have everything I wanted. I might never have found my calling.

The obstacle became the way.

Same with my divorce. When that door slammed in my face, it felt like the end of everything. My ego left me. The world lost all color. But if that marriage hadn't ended, I never would have met Jennifer. I never would have learned what a real partnership looks like. The worst thing that ever happened to me became the doorway to the best thing that ever happened to me.

I'm not saying you should be glad bad things happen. I'm saying that once they've happened, you get to decide whether they're just wreckage or whether they're material. That decision is yours, and it might be the most important decision you ever make.

The broken glass

I want to tell you about a man named Steve Uiterwyk.

Steve was one of my first professional mentors. Among other things, he handles the buying and selling of automotive dealerships, which is a world where you see a lot of people at their best and a lot at their worst. I've never known a man with a more realistic, clear view of the world. He doesn't sugarcoat anything. He sees exactly what's there.

And what's been there for Steve hasn't always been easy. He's faced challenges that could have devastated a lesser man. Companies dissolved. Divorce. Custody concerns. Those are just the ones I know about. Any one of those could knock a person down for years.

But Steve keeps seeing the upside of every situation. When my world is low, or when I'm flying high on an idea and can't see all the sides of it, Steve is my phone call. He brings levity, clarity, and relevance to my world. He'll tell me when I'm wrong. He'll also tell me when I'm being too hard on myself.

In one conversation, Steve said something I've never forgotten. We'd been talking about the way some people constantly see the glass as half empty, and he said, "I couldn't live like that." And then he laid this on me:

"I don't care if the glass is broken. I still call it half full."

I laughed, and then he went further. Even if he cut his hand picking up the broken glass, he said, he's still drinking from a glass that's half full.

I truly love this guy.

What makes Steve's outlook so powerful is that it's not naive. He's not pretending the glass isn't broken. He sees the crack. He knows he might get cut. His honesty recognizes that the world can be dark. He's not blind to it. He just chooses to pursue the light anyway.

That's the key. Steve's disposition is purely a choice. And that choice makes all the difference.

A lot of people think optimism means ignoring reality. That's not optimism. That's denial. Real optimism, the Steve kind, looks straight at reality, sees every crack and sharp edge, and then asks, "Okay, what can I do with this?" It's Marcus Aurelius with a phone and a sense of humor.

Spinning it

In the journal, I asked people to practice something inspired by Steve. Take a problem you're facing. Write it down. Read it. Then look at it through a different lens. How could this problem be a benefit? Better yet, how could you use this problem, this opportunity, to move your life forward?

I called it "spinning it." Drinking from the broken, half-full glass.

This isn't spin in the sense of lying. It's spin in the sense of turning the object in your hands until you see a side you hadn't noticed. Every situa-

tion has more than one side. The problem is that when we're hurting, we get stuck staring at the worst side and forget to turn it.

Here's what spinning looks like in real life. Picture a dealership that loses its top salesperson to a competitor. Terrible, right? That person was responsible for a big chunk of the store's volume. The first reaction is panic. But turn it. Now there's room for someone else to step up. Now the manager has to build a system that doesn't depend on one superstar. Now the rest of the team gets more opportunities. A year later, the store might be stronger than it ever was with that one person carrying it. That doesn't happen automatically. It happens because someone chose to turn the glass.

You can make this choice anytime. Live your life on purpose, with a smile in your soul, even when the glass is broken.

Everything as it should

At the end of that week in the journal, I quoted Marcus again. "Everything that happens, happens as it should, and if you observe carefully, you will find this to be so."

I'll admit that one can be hard to swallow. When something terrible happens, it doesn't feel like it happened "as it should." It feels wrong. And I'm not going to tell you that every tragedy has a neat purpose. Some things are just painful, and part of being human is grieving them.

But I think what Marcus was getting at is acceptance. Not approval. Acceptance. The thing has happened. It's part of reality now. Fighting the fact that it happened just adds a second layer of suffering on top of the first. When you accept it, when you stop arguing with reality, you free up all the energy you were spending on resistance, and you can put it toward what comes next.

The Stoics were big on this distinction between what's in your control and what isn't. What happened is out of your control. It's done. What you do now is completely in your control. Put your energy there.

The letter Lincoln never sent

In July of 1863, the Union Army won the Battle of Gettysburg. It was a massive victory, and Abraham Lincoln believed it was a chance to end the war. Robert E. Lee's Confederate army was retreating, battered, and pinned against the rain-swollen Potomac River. If General George Meade pursued and attacked, Lincoln believed, Lee's army could be destroyed and the war might be over.

Meade didn't attack in time. Lee's army escaped across the river.

Lincoln was devastated. He sat down and wrote Meade a letter. It's an extraordinary document, and you can still read it today. In it, Lincoln tells Meade that Lee "was within your easy grasp, and to have closed upon him would, in connection with our other late successes, have ended the war." He writes, "Your golden opportunity is gone, and I am distressed immeasurably because of it."

And then he did something remarkable. He didn't send it.

The letter was found later among his papers, in an envelope marked, in his words, that it was never sent or signed.

Historians have written about this habit of Lincoln's. When he was angry or frustrated, he'd sometimes write out exactly what he felt, get it all on paper, and then set it aside. He let the letter carry the emotion so he didn't have to act on it. Meade was still his general. The war still had to be fought. Blowing up at the man wouldn't have brought back the opportunity. It would only have made the next step harder.

Think about how much wisdom is packed into that one unsent letter. Lincoln didn't pretend he wasn't angry. He didn't bottle it up. He expressed it fully. But he didn't let it make his decisions. He felt the obstacle, completely, and then chose the response that would actually move things forward.

That's the Stoic practice in action, done by a man who likely never thought of himself as a Stoic. And it connects to something Anne Frank wrote, which I shared at the start of this book: "When I write, I can shake off all my cares." Writing things out, even things no one will ever read, is

one of the oldest tools there is for getting a strong emotion out of your body so it doesn't run your hands.

Lincoln knew obstacles. He lost more elections than he won in the early part of his political life. He lost a race for the state legislature. He lost bids for the U.S. Senate, including the famous 1858 race against Stephen Douglas. He struggled with what people then called melancholy, and what we'd probably recognize today as serious depression. He buried children. He led the country through its bloodiest war. And through all of it, he kept finding a way to turn the thing in his path into the path.

The next time you're tempted to fire off the angry text or the scorched-earth email, write the Lincoln letter instead. Get it all out. Then put it in a drawer. Let the obstacle teach you something before it makes you do something.

It's a mystery

One of my favorite movies is *Shakespeare in Love*, and there's a little exchange in it that I put in the journal because it makes me laugh every time and because I think it's secretly profound.

A theater owner named Henslowe is being grilled by a moneylender named Fennyman about how the play is going to come together, given that everything is going wrong. Henslowe explains that the natural condition of the theater business is one of insurmountable obstacles on the road to imminent disaster. And yet, he says, strangely enough, it all turns out well.

"How?" asks Fennyman.

"I don't know," says Henslowe. "It's a mystery."

I love that. Because it's true of so much of life. If you look back honestly at your own history, you can probably find moments when you were sure all was lost, when it seemed like everything was falling apart, and then somehow, at the last minute, it worked out. Maybe not the way you expected. Maybe better.

In the journal, I asked people to spend time remembering events that originally seemed disastrous but ended up being some of the best things

that ever happened to them. And then to look for patterns. Because once you see the pattern, once you notice how many of your "disasters" turned into doorways, it gets much easier to trust the process the next time you're in the middle of one.

Red lights turn green

Matthew McConaughey wrote a memoir called *Greenlights*, and the central idea of it fits right here. He talks about the green lights in life, the moments when things go your way, and also about the red lights and yellow lights, the setbacks, the detours, the things that stop you in your tracks. And one of his big points is that a lot of the red lights, looked at later, turn out to have been green lights all along. They stopped you from going somewhere you shouldn't have gone, or sent you somewhere better. Sometimes you can only see that in the rearview mirror.

That's the mystery Henslowe was talking about. That's what Marcus meant. That's what Steve means with his broken glass. The obstacle, given enough time and the right attitude, very often becomes the way.

Month-end

Anyone who's worked in car sales knows the particular pressure of the last few days of the month. Numbers are due. Targets are either going to be hit or missed. Everybody's on edge. Deals that seemed solid fall apart. Customers who promised to come in don't. Something breaks in the shop. The bank rejects an approval. It's a pressure cooker.

I've lived through a lot of month-ends. And I've watched the Marcus Aurelius principle play out in them over and over.

Picture a store that's way behind with four days left. The obvious reaction is panic. Managers start yelling. Salespeople start cutting corners. Customers get pushed too hard. And very often, all that panic makes things worse.

Now picture a leader who walks into that same situation and asks a different question: what is this obstacle making possible? Maybe the answer is that it's forcing everyone to go back through every customer who

didn't buy in the last sixty days and actually follow up, something that should have been happening all along. Maybe it's revealing a weakness in the process that's been hidden when times were good. Maybe it's a chance for the team to pull together in a way they haven't before.

The month might still come up short. That happens. But the store that uses the obstacle comes out of it stronger, with better habits and a tighter team. The store that panics just comes out tired.

What stands in the way becomes the way. Even at month-end.

The obstacle and the new you

I want to tie this to identity, because I think it's one of the most important links in the whole book.

Obstacles are where identity gets forged. Anybody can act like their best self when everything is going well. It's in the hard moments that you find out who you actually are, and, more importantly, decide who you're going to be.

Every obstacle is a question: who are you going to be in this? The person who folds, or the person who finds a way? The person who blames, or the person who owns it? The person who lashes out, or the person who writes the Lincoln letter and puts it in a drawer?

When you answer that question well, even once, you collect powerful evidence about yourself. Easy wins teach you very little. Hard ones teach you who you are.

The obstacle as teacher

One way I've learned to look at obstacles is to ask, "What is this here to teach me?"

I don't mean that in a mystical way, like the universe sent this problem specially for me. I just mean that every obstacle carries a lesson if you're willing to look for it. The lesson might be patience. It might be humility. It might be that I need a new skill, or a different approach, or better people around me. It might be that I've been going down the wrong road and need to turn around.

When I look back at the biggest obstacles in my life, the drugs, the weight, the divorce, the breakup that left me eating ramen with my dog, each one taught me something I don't think I could have learned any other way. The drugs taught me what rock bottom looks like and that you can climb out of it. The weight taught me discipline. The divorce taught me how much I had to grow. The ramen days taught me to ask, "What would it take?"

I wouldn't choose to go through any of those again. But I wouldn't trade the lessons for anything. They're the foundation of who I am now.

So the next time something blocks your way, try asking, "What is this here to teach me?" Then be quiet long enough to hear the answer.

Gratitude for the obstacle

Here's the last piece, and it brings us back to where this whole book started. If obstacles can become the way, then it's possible, even in the middle of one, to feel something like gratitude for it.

I'm not asking you to be grateful for pain itself. I'm asking you to be grateful for what the pain might be making possible. Grateful for the strength you're building. Grateful for the lesson. Grateful for the fact that you're still here, still standing, still able to choose your response.

That kind of gratitude is the most powerful kind there is. Being grateful when things are good is easy. Being grateful for the obstacle while you're still in it? That's a callus on the soul. And it changes the whole experience. It turns a wall into a staircase.

It also changes who you are. A person who's grateful for obstacles doesn't fear them the same way. They walk into hard things with a kind of confidence, because they know that whatever happens, they'll find a way to use it. That's the identity I'm after. Not someone who never faces obstacles. Someone who knows what to do with them.

So what's in your way right now?

Turn it over. Look for the other side. Ask how it might be happening for you. Write the Lincoln letter if you need to. Reach into the cookie jar. Call your version of Steve.

And then take the next step, knowing that the thing in front of you might just be the path.



CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Quail the Fear

I WAS SCARED OUT of my mind.

A thousand thoughts were racing through my head. What if he lands a lucky punch or a knee and I end up in the hospital, or worse? What if I look like an idiot up there, in front of my friends, my family, and a room full of strangers? I had no business being there.

I was thirty-seven years old. The closest competitor to my age was in his mid-twenties. I was in a bar in Melbourne, Florida, and I was about to step into the octagon for my first cage fight.

The fight

Let me tell you how it went, since you're probably wondering. The fight itself was over almost as quickly as you can read this.

The matchmaker had put me up against a twenty-two-year-old kid who had me by an easy thirty pounds. Fifteen years younger and thirty pounds heavier. That's not a fair fight on paper. But I'd come too far to back out. I'd trained for it. I'd told people. I was there.

When the announcer said my name, I made my way to the cage, took off my shirt, and stepped in. The crowd was yelling my name. It didn't

hurt that about a quarter of the people in that bar were friends and co-workers who'd come to watch the old guy do something crazy.

The bell rang. After a huge reaction from the crowd, I took him down and went after his kidneys, punch after punch. For a few seconds, I felt like I might actually pull this off. Then, at some point, he managed to reverse our positions, and he landed a bunch of kidney shots of his own. (Those were made considerably worse by my bad idea of going horseback riding the next day. Do not go horseback riding the day after someone pounds on your kidneys. Learn from me.)

I fought him off from underneath as best I could. But about two and a half minutes into the first round, he caught me in an arm bar, and I tapped out.

That was it. Two and a half minutes. Loss.

The funny thing

Two days later, back at work, people met me with condolences. "Sorry about the fight, man." "Tough loss." Like somebody had died.

The funny thing is, I wasn't disappointed at all.

Don't get me wrong. I wanted to win. Of course I did. The loss stung a little. But all of it, the preparation, the buildup, the nervous thrill of walking toward that cage, was part of the experience. And when it was over, I didn't feel like a loser. I felt like a champion.

I was more than a decade older than anyone else who fought that night, and I still showed up. Everyone told me I was crazy. I was still there. My boss told me that professionals didn't do what I was doing. I tipped my lance anyway.

For that, I felt like the world's mightiest warrior.

I tell this story not because I'm recommending that everyone go get into a cage fight at thirty-seven. (Your kidneys will thank you if you don't.) I tell it because it taught me something about fear that I haven't been able to learn any other way.

It's not bravery if you're not scared.

Bravery requires fear

We tend to think of brave people as fearless. The firefighter running into the burning building. The soldier charging the hill. We imagine they must not feel what we feel.

That's backwards. If you're not scared, it's not bravery. It's just doing something easy. Bravery is only possible when fear is present. Bravery is feeling the fear, all of it, and stepping forward anyway.

That's what that night in Melbourne taught me. I was terrified. Every part of me wanted to leave. My brain was generating a highlight reel of every way it could go wrong. And I walked into the cage anyway. That's the part I'm proud of. Not the takedown, not the kidney shots. The walk.

It doesn't mean much if you're playing at half speed against competition you know you can beat. That's comfortable. Anyone can do comfortable. What matters is stepping up anyway, looking right into your fear, and saying, "Here goes."

So what are your fears? What are you scared of? What stresses you out? Whatever it is, here's what I learned in that cage: even if you fail, you won't regret trying. It'll bring out the best in you. I've never met an exception to this.

Our doubts are traitors

Shakespeare has a line in *Measure for Measure* that I put in the journal: "Our doubts are traitors, and make us lose the good we oft might win, by fearing to attempt."

Traitors. That's a strong word, and it's exactly right. Your doubts pretend to be on your side. They pretend to be protecting you. "Don't try that, you might fail." "Don't say that, they might laugh." "Don't apply, you won't get it." They sound like friends giving good advice.

But they're working for the other team. Every time you listen to them, you lose something you might have won. Not because you tried and failed, but because you never tried at all.

I think about all the good I would have lost if I'd listened to my doubts. If I'd listened to the doubt that said a guy with my history

couldn't succeed in sales, I'd never have had my career. If I'd listened to the doubt that said I was too damaged to have a good marriage, I'd never have had Jennifer. If I'd listened to the doubt that said a thirty-seven-year-old had no business in a cage, I'd never have felt like the world's mightiest warrior, kidneys and all.

Your doubts will always have a reasonable-sounding argument. That's what makes them good traitors. Listen to them, sure. Take what's useful. Then ask yourself: what good might I lose by fearing to attempt?

The roller coaster

In the journal, I used an image for anxiety that I still think is one of the best I've ever come up with.

Think about a roller coaster. When is the fear worst? It's not on the big drop. It's on the climb. The click, click, click of the chain pulling you up the hill. That's when your stomach is in knots. That's when your hands are sweating and your mind is racing. That's when you want to get off.

Then you crest the top. Gravity kicks in. The coaster barrels down, the adrenaline hits, and the game is on. And the fear? It's mostly gone. It turned into something else. Excitement. Exhilaration. Even joy.

The anxiety of a roller coaster exists mostly in the click, click, click of the climb.

Life is like that too. The anticipation of the hard thing is almost always worse than the hard thing itself. The dread of the difficult conversation is worse than the conversation. The fear of the cage was worse than the two and a half minutes in it. The worry about the diagnosis is often worse than facing it and starting treatment. The click, click, click is where most of our suffering happens.

So the answer is to get the game on. Stop sitting in the climb longer than you have to. Make the call. Have the conversation. Send the application. Get to the top of the hill and let gravity take over. Once you're moving, the fear has a way of melting into action.

Decide, and the fear erodes

I wrote a week in the journal about pushing through fear to make a hard decision, and I laid out an approach that has worked for me over and over.

First, know your plan ahead of time. What is it you actually want? Does this decision put you in line with that?

Second, once you know the decision moves you toward what you want, fill yourself with gratitude. Gratitude that you're about to be closer to your goal. Gratitude for your spouse, your kids, your life. Gratitude for anything and everything you can think of. Because, as I've said all through this book, it's impossible to be fearful when you're grateful.

Third, know your outcome. Picture what will happen once you've made this decision. Play out the scenario you want in your mind. This is where you're headed, and you'll keep adjusting your approach until you get there.

Then make the decision. Move forward. And stick to it.

Here's what I've found happens every time. Once the decision is made, the fear starts to erode, and the path starts to show up in front of you. Taking action creates its own momentum. Moving in the direction of what you want gives you the energy to keep moving that way.

W.H. Murray, a Scottish mountaineer, wrote a passage that I put in the journal because it captures this so well. He wrote that until one is committed, there is hesitancy, the chance to draw back. But the moment one definitely commits oneself, then providence moves too. All sorts of things occur to help that would never otherwise have occurred. A whole stream of events flows from the decision, bringing all kinds of unforeseen incidents and meetings and material help that no one could have dreamed would come their way.

I've lived that. When I decided to fight, the training partners showed up. When I decided to chase sales, the opportunities showed up. When I decided to die to my old self, the new path showed up. I don't fully understand how it works. Part of it, I think, is the filter. Once you commit, your brain starts noticing all the help that was there all along. Part of it

may be something bigger. Either way, the decision comes first. The help comes after.

Make the decision. Quail the fear.

Everybody has a plan

I'm going to be honest about something, because I don't want to make fear sound like something you conquer once and are done with.

Mike Tyson famously said, "Everybody has a plan until they get punched in the mouth." I can confirm this from personal experience. I had a plan for that fight. I had a plan for what I'd do if he tried to take me down, and what I'd do if I got him down. Then I was on my back with a twenty-two-year-old raining kidney shots on me, and the plan went right out the window.

Fear works the same way. You can do all the prep in the world. You can visualize, meditate, practice gratitude, make the decision. And then you get punched in the mouth by life, and the fear comes roaring back.

That doesn't mean the prep didn't work. It means you're human. The prep isn't there to make sure you never feel fear again. It's there so that when the fear comes back, you have somewhere to go. You've got your breath. You've got your cookie jar. You've got your gratitude. You've got a decision you already made. You've got an identity that says you're the kind of person who keeps going.

In the journal, right after the Tyson quote, I wrote that your strategies make the difference. Know your outcome. Get yourself into the right state. See the outcome over and over. Take action. And keep changing your approach until you get there. The punch in the mouth is just information. It tells you what to change. Adjust and keep moving.

What fear is really protecting

Here's something I didn't understand about fear until I'd been through a lot of it.

A lot of our fear isn't really about physical danger. Most of us aren't stepping into cages. Most of our fear is about something else. When I

sketched out the rough outline for this book years ago, I scribbled a note next to the word "fear." It said: not being enough, not being loved.

That's what most fear comes down to, at the bottom. We're not really afraid of the presentation. We're afraid that if it goes badly, people will see we're not enough. We're not really afraid of asking for the raise. We're afraid of hearing that we're not worth it. We're not really afraid of the first date. We're afraid of being rejected, which feels like proof we're not lovable.

And here's where identity comes in. Fear is very often the old self protecting its territory. When you try to become someone new, the old identity sounds the alarm. "Who do you think you are? That's not you. You'll embarrass yourself. Stay where it's safe." The fear isn't necessarily telling you that the new thing is dangerous. It's telling you the new thing is unfamiliar, and to the old self, unfamiliar feels like a threat.

Once you see that, fear starts to look different. It's not always a stop sign. Sometimes it's a sign that you're right at the edge of who you've been, about to step into who you could be. The fear is the old self clutching at your sleeve.

That doesn't mean every fear should be ignored. Some fears are telling you something real. If you're afraid to walk down a dark alley at 2 a.m., listen to that. But the fear of trying something new, of being seen, of putting yourself out there, of changing? That fear is usually a signal that you're growing.

The fear of not being enough

I'm going to spend the whole next chapter on this, because it deserves it. But I want to plant one thing here.

Most of the fears that keep us small are variations of one fear: I'm not enough. Not smart enough. Not good-looking enough. Not talented enough. Not lovable enough. Not worthy of the thing I want.

In the journal, I kept coming back to one answer, week after week, because I believe it with everything I have. You are enough. Just you. Not

the improved version. Not the version after you lose the weight or get the promotion or fix your marriage. You, right now, as you are.

I know that can sound like a greeting card. But I mean it in a very practical way. When you walk into a hard situation believing you're enough, the fear has much less to grab onto. If the presentation goes badly, you're still enough. If they say no to the raise, you're still enough. If the date doesn't call back, you're still enough. The outcome doesn't get to decide your worth. That frees you up to take the risk.

That night in Melbourne, I lost the fight. And I was still enough. More than enough. I felt like a warrior because I'd shown up, not because I'd won. My worth wasn't riding on the outcome, so the outcome couldn't crush me.

Fear on a Tuesday

Most of us will never step into a cage. But fear shows up in much more ordinary clothes, and I think it's worth naming a few of its disguises, because the everyday versions do more damage over a lifetime than any single dramatic moment.

Fear shows up as procrastination. You're not lazy. You're scared of doing the thing badly, so you don't do it at all.

Fear shows up as perfectionism. You keep polishing the proposal, the resume, the business plan, because as long as it's not finished, nobody can judge it.

Fear shows up as busyness. You fill every hour with small urgent tasks so you never have to face the big important one that scares you.

Fear shows up as cynicism. It's easier to make fun of people who try than to risk trying yourself.

Fear shows up as anger. A lot of the anger I've seen in the workplace, including my own, is fear wearing armor. The manager who blows up when the numbers are bad is usually scared of what it means for him.

Fear shows up as "being realistic." Sometimes being realistic is wisdom. Sometimes it's just fear with a respectable haircut.

Once you learn to recognize these disguises, you start catching fear in the act. And once you catch it, you can apply everything we've talked about. Gratitude. A decision. A deep breath. A better question. The courage to walk up the hill and get the ride started.

Courage is contagious

Here's something I noticed after that fight in Melbourne that I didn't expect. In the weeks after, a few people came up to me, coworkers mostly, and told me about things they'd been scared to do. One was thinking about going back to school. One wanted to start training for a race. One had been putting off a hard conversation with a family member.

They'd seen a thirty-seven-year-old guy do something ridiculous and scary, and lose, and walk away smiling. And something about that gave them permission.

I think this is one of the most underrated effects of courage. When you face a fear, you don't just change yourself. You show the people around you that it's possible. You become an example. Your cage becomes someone else's permission slip.

Afraid of the good stuff

There's a strange fear I've seen in a lot of people, including myself, that doesn't get talked about much: the fear of things going well.

It sounds backwards. Who's afraid of success? But think about it. When things start going well, new fears show up. What if I can't keep it up? What if people expect more from me now? What if I lose it? What if I don't deserve it? What if they find out I'm not as good as they think?

I felt this when my career started taking off. Part of me was waiting for the other shoe to drop. The kid from the yellow room didn't believe he belonged in the rooms I was starting to walk into. So I'd find little ways to sabotage myself. Overwork until I burned out. Pick fights. Hold back from the next opportunity because I was scared of failing at a bigger level.

If you notice yourself pulling back right when things start to go your way, this might be what's happening. The old identity doesn't think you

belong in the new life, so it tries to drag you back to where it's comfortable.

The answer is the same as always. Gratitude for what's happening, instead of fear of losing it. And a decision about who you are: someone who's allowed to have good things, and who can handle them.

Fear is a signal, not a stop sign

I've come to think of fear the way I think of a warning light on a car dashboard.

When a light comes on, you don't ignore it. That would be foolish. But you also don't pull over on the side of the highway and abandon the car. You find out what it's telling you. Sometimes it's serious and you need to stop. Most of the time, it's something you can deal with while you keep driving.

Fear works the same way. Sometimes it's telling you something true: this is actually dangerous, this person isn't safe, this decision is reckless. Listen to that. But most of the fear we feel in modern life isn't about real danger. It's about embarrassment, rejection, uncertainty, looking foolish, losing some comfort we've gotten used to. Those are warning lights, not engine fires.

So when fear shows up, ask it a question. "What exactly are you warning me about?" Make it specific. Most of the time, once you name it, the fear shrinks. "I'm afraid I'll look stupid in the meeting." Okay. And then what? "People might think less of me." Okay. And then what? Usually, by the third "and then what," you've reached something survivable.

Then decide. If it's a real danger, respect it. If it's just the discomfort of growth, thank the fear for trying to protect you, and keep driving.

Step into the cage

Everybody has their cage. For some people it's literal. For most of us, it's a conversation, a decision, a risk, a change. It's the thing you've been circling for months, maybe years, because you're scared.

I can't make the fear go away. Nobody can. But I can tell you what I learned walking toward that cage with a thousand thoughts screaming in my head.

The fear is loudest right before you step in. The click, click, click of the climb is the worst part. Once you're moving, the fear changes into something else. And whatever happens after that, win or lose, you'll have done the one thing that matters most. You'll have shown up.

It's not bravery if you're not scared. So be scared. Then be brave.

Face it. End it. Even if you fail, you won't regret it. You've got this. Go for it.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Brave Enough to Be Seen

Remember what I told myself on that toilet lid, after she left me for a guy with more money? I said I'd never be in that position of hurt again. I said I'd never be that vulnerable again.

I meant it. And for a long time, I lived it. I built walls. I worked harder than anyone. I got the money and the cars and the house. I made sure nobody could ever look at me and see the broke guy sharing ramen with his dog. I armored up.

It worked, in a way. It got me a career. But it cost me something, too, and it took me years to understand what.

You can't armor yourself against pain without also armoring yourself against love, joy, connection, and growth. The walls that keep hurt out also keep everything else out. You end up safe and alone in a fortress you built yourself, wondering why nothing feels as good as you thought it would.

It took meeting Jennifer, and a lot of patience on her part, for those walls to start coming down. And it took a researcher from Texas to help me understand what had happened.

The researcher

Brené Brown is a research professor at the University of Houston who has spent decades studying shame, vulnerability, courage, and empathy. In 2010, she gave a TED talk called "The Power of Vulnerability," and it became one of the most-watched talks ever. She's written a stack of books since, including *Daring Greatly* and *The Gifts of Imperfection*.

I first came across her work at a point in my life when I thought I had things figured out. I was successful. I was married to the love of my life. I had my morning practice. And yet something in her message hit me right between the eyes.

She defines vulnerability as uncertainty, risk, and emotional exposure. It's the feeling you get when you put yourself out there without knowing how it'll turn out. Telling someone you love them first. Asking for help. Sharing an idea in a meeting that might get shot down. Admitting you made a mistake. Stepping into a cage in a bar in Florida.

And her big finding, the one that changed how I saw everything, is that vulnerability isn't weakness. It's the most accurate measure of courage we have. You can't be brave without being vulnerable, because bravery means acting when the outcome is uncertain. If you know you'll win, it's not courage. It's just a sure thing.

In a later talk, she said something I've come back to many times: "Vulnerability is the birthplace of innovation, creativity and change."

Think about that in light of everything we've talked about in this book. Change requires vulnerability. Becoming someone new means stepping into uncertainty. It means risking failure. It means being seen as a beginner, fumbling around, not yet good at the new thing. If you're armored against ever looking foolish or ever getting hurt, you can't change. You'll stay locked in the old identity, because at least it's safe.

That was me for years after the toilet lid. Successful, yes. Growing? Not as much as I could have been. Because I'd decided never to be vulnerable again, I'd also quietly decided never to be a beginner again.

Armor in the showroom

I see this everywhere in the business world, and I've seen it in myself as a leader.

Picture a sales manager who's never wrong. At least, he never admits to being wrong. When a deal goes bad, it's the salesperson's fault, or the finance office, or the customer. When a new process he rolled out flops, he doubles down instead of adjusting. He's got his armor on all day long, because in his mind, admitting a mistake would make him look weak in front of his team.

Now picture his team. They're afraid of him. They don't bring him problems until it's too late, because they know how he'll react. They don't suggest new ideas, because the last person who did got shot down. They cover their own mistakes, because that's what he models. The whole store gets defensive, rigid, and slow.

Now picture a different manager who walks into the morning meeting and says, "Hey, that new follow-up process I gave you last month isn't working. That's on me. Let's figure out something better together." Something shifts in the room. People relax. They start talking. They bring up problems early. They take risks, because they've seen that failure isn't fatal. The whole team gets more creative and more honest.

That second manager isn't weaker. He's stronger. He's secure enough to be seen.

I'd love to tell you I've always been the second manager. I haven't. But the older I get, the more I try to be.

Shame and guilt

One of the most useful distinctions I've ever learned came from Brené Brown's work on shame.

She draws a line between guilt and shame. Guilt says, "I did something bad." Shame says, "I am bad." Guilt is about behavior. Shame is about identity.

That might sound like a small difference, but it's enormous. Guilt can actually be healthy. It's the feeling that you've done something that

doesn't match your values, and it can push you to make it right. You apologize. You change what you're doing. Guilt points at the behavior and says, "That's not who you want to be."

Shame does the opposite. Shame says, "This is who you are." And if that's who you are, why bother changing? Shame keeps people stuck. It tells the addict he's worthless, so he uses again to numb the feeling of being worthless. It tells the overweight person she's disgusting, so she eats to comfort herself. It tells the guy who got divorced that he's damaged goods, so he stops trying.

Brown's research also found that shame grows in secrecy, silence, and judgment. The more you hide something, the more power it has over you. And the antidote, she found, is empathy. When you share your story with someone who responds with understanding, shame starts to lose its grip.

This hit me hard, because I lived in shame for a long time. After the drug years, after the weight, after the divorce, I carried around a lot of "I am bad." I was a failure. A loser. I'd be marked for life. Damaged goods. Those are words I actually used about myself after that bedroom door slammed.

And notice what that does to identity, the third big theme of this book. Shame is a terrible foundation for change, because it attacks the very identity you're trying to rebuild. You can't build a new self on top of "I'm worthless." The ground won't hold.

That's why, when I talk about dying to yourself, I'm careful to say it comes from something closer to clean disgust than shame. Disgust says, "That behavior is not who I'm going to be." Shame says, "I'm garbage, and garbage can't change." One opens a door. The other bolts it shut.

Why I tell my stories

People have asked me why I'd put the drug years, the weight, and the divorce into a book. Aren't I embarrassed? Doesn't a general manager at a dealership have a reputation to think about?

Here's my answer. I tell those stories because shame grows in secrecy. For years, I kept them hidden, and they sat in me like a stone. Every time

I've told them to someone who responded with understanding, the stone got a little lighter. Writing them down for you is the next step.

I also tell them because I know someone reading this is carrying their own version. Maybe you're in your own yellow room right now. Maybe you're standing in front of your own bathroom mirror. Maybe you're sitting on your own toilet lid. And I want you to hear, from someone who's been there, that you are not garbage. You did some things, or some things were done to you, or both. That's not who you are. You can become someone else.

In the outline I sketched out for this book years ago, under the word "fear," I wrote: not being enough, not being loved. That's the fear at the bottom of all shame. And the only answer I've ever found that actually works is the one I kept writing in the journal, week after week, until Jennifer probably got tired of reading it.

You are enough.

Love yourself or don't

One of the weeks in the journal opened with a line I wrote: "Love is a reward or punishment for those who believe in it."

What I meant was that love, including love for yourself, isn't something that happens to you. It's something you choose to believe in and act on, or not. Love yourself, or don't. Reward yourself, or don't. Acknowledge yourself, or, you guessed it, don't.

I asked people that week to pay themselves compliments. One thing a day they genuinely liked about themselves. And if they couldn't think of anything, I told them to write down what they would say if they could. Then expand on it. Why do you like it? How does it help you or others? How could you build on it?

I closed that week with a line from RuPaul that makes me smile every time: "If you can't love yourself, how in the hell you gonna love somebody else?"

It's funny, and it's dead serious. Shame makes it almost impossible to love other people well, because you're always protecting yourself, always

waiting to be found out, always armored. When you can accept yourself, flaws and history and all, you've got so much more to give.

Don't kill it, just hit it

Now I want to tell you about my Uncle Philip, because he taught me something about authenticity on a golf course that I've been applying to the rest of my life ever since.

Uncle Philip Johns is one of my greatest heroes. The first time he said this to me, we were on hole nine of the golf course at the local Army base. I was standing over the ball, gripping the club like I was trying to strangle it, about to try to knock the crap out of that little white pill.

He looked at me and said, "Don't kill it. Just hit it."

In the dedication of the first journal, I thanked him for telling me to keep my head down, my eye on the ball, and stop trying to kill it. Just hit it.

You've probably seen what happens when you try to kill a golf ball. You swing as hard as you possibly can, every muscle tensed, and the ball goes fifteen feet straight up in the air and lands just short of the ladies' tee box. The harder you try to force it, the worse it goes.

Life works the same way. How many times have we acted like Chris Farley in *Tommy Boy*, in that scene where he's describing how he suffocates, destroys, and torches a potential sale because he's so desperate to close it? We get close to something we really want, a relationship, a promotion, a meaningful moment with someone we love, and all of a sudden, there it is. We get overeager. We try way too hard. And our less-than-authentic self shows up. We talk too much. We perform. We try to be impressive instead of real. And the moment is ruined.

Relax. Breathe. Be yourself. Let go of the idea of killing it, of making a great impression, of representing something you're not. Just be your authentic self.

I promise you, the real you will be enough.

That's what vulnerability looks like on a tee box. It's being willing to show up as you actually are, without the performance. It's trusting that

your natural swing, the one you've practiced, is enough. Don't strive to impress. Just be in the moment. Don't try so hard. Just do.

Stronger than a mother bear

When I was fifteen or sixteen, my mother was leaving my room one night. She'd just shared something with me that was bothering her. I don't even remember what it was now. But I remember that as she was walking out, I called after her.

"Mom, you pretend you're weak, when really you're stronger than a mother bear. Don't forget that."

I don't know where that came from. I was a teenager, and teenagers aren't known for their wisdom. But I think I saw something in her that she couldn't see in herself. She'd convinced herself she was fragile, and I could see she wasn't.

In the journal, right before that story, I used a line that a lot of people think comes from the original Winnie-the-Pooh books, though it actually comes from a later Disney movie, *Pooh's Grand Adventure*. Christopher Robin tells Pooh, "You're braver than you believe, and stronger than you seem, and smarter than you think."

Here's what I believe, and what I told readers then. What holds you back usually isn't weakness. It isn't time. It's your perception of your own strength. You're stronger than you ever thought. You're braver than you ever thought. And you're enough, just as you are.

Most of us are like my mom that night. We've convinced ourselves we're weaker than we are, because it feels safer. If we're weak, nobody can expect much of us. If we're weak, we don't have to risk being seen trying and failing. But underneath the armor, there's a mother bear. There's always been one.

The man in the arena

Brené Brown took the title of her book *Daring Greatly* from a speech Theodore Roosevelt gave in Paris in 1910. It's one of the most quoted passages in American history, and for good reason. Here's the heart of it:

"It is not the critic who counts; not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles, or where the doer of deeds could have done them better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood; who strives valiantly; who errs, who comes short again and again... who at the best knows in the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly."

When I read that, I think of the foreword I wrote for the very first draft of the journal. It said: "Herein lies the story of a person who has accomplished great things. The path has never been straight. They have been off course most of the time, but their strength, fortitude, and discipline have carried them. They have strove valiantly again and again, failed time after time, but continued on the journey."

I didn't know I was echoing Roosevelt when I wrote that. But I think we were getting at the same thing. The people who matter aren't the ones who never fell. They're the ones who stepped into the arena, got dirty, failed, and kept going. The critics in the stands don't count. The person with dust and sweat and blood on their face does.

Every time you try to become someone new, you step into the arena. People will watch. Some will criticize. Some will wait for you to fall so they can say, "Told you." Let them. They're in the stands. You're in the arena. That's the only place anything real ever happens.

Your own path through the forest

Joseph Campbell, who spent his life studying myths from cultures all over the world, described a scene from the old stories of King Arthur's knights. When they set out in search of the Holy Grail, they thought it would be a disgrace to go forth as a group. So each one entered the forest at a point he himself had chosen, where it was darkest and there was no path. Campbell's point was that if there's already a path, it's someone else's path, and you're not on your own adventure.

Being seen means walking into your own dark part of the forest. People will encourage you to take the well-worn path. They'll do it out of

love. They want to protect you. Growth is dangerous. Growth is painful. You can take the easy path, or you can take the one that leads to you.

It takes courage to leave the trail. It takes vulnerability to be seen stumbling through the trees, not knowing exactly where you're going. But it's the only way to find what you're actually looking for.

Armor and men

I want to say a word specifically to the men reading this, because I think a lot of us were raised with armor built in.

Many of us learned early that showing weakness was dangerous. Don't cry. Don't complain. Don't admit you're scared. Handle it. Be tough. And some of that has real value. There's a time for toughness, and I've spent a whole chapter praising calluses.

But toughness and armor aren't the same thing. Toughness is being able to take a hit and keep going. Armor is refusing to let anyone see that you got hit at all. And a lot of men I know, including the younger version of me, have been wearing armor so long they've forgotten there's a person inside it.

The cost is real. Men who can't be vulnerable often can't ask for help, so they suffer alone. They can't talk about what's hurting, so it comes out sideways, as anger or drinking or withdrawal. They can't let their partners all the way in, so their marriages stay on the surface. They can't admit a mistake at work, so their teams stop trusting them.

I'm not saying you need to start crying in every meeting. I'm saying that the bravest thing some of us will ever do is tell one trusted person the truth about how we're really doing. That's not weakness. That's the arena.

Vulnerability as a leader

I learned something about leadership when I started taking my own armor off, and it surprised me.

I'd always assumed that if I admitted I didn't know something, or that I'd made a mistake, my team would respect me less. The opposite hap-

pened. When I started saying things like "I got that one wrong," or "I don't know, what do you think?" people leaned in. They started bringing me problems earlier. They started offering ideas. They started owning their own mistakes, because they'd seen me do it.

It turns out people don't follow perfect leaders. They follow honest ones.

Start small

If being vulnerable feels impossible for you right now, start small.

You don't have to write a book about your worst years. You don't have to stand up in front of a crowd. Start with one person you trust, and tell them one true thing you've been keeping to yourself. It doesn't have to be the deepest thing. Just something real.

"I've been struggling lately."
"I'm scared about this new job."
"I don't actually know what I'm doing here."

Watch what happens. Most of the time, the other person doesn't pull away. They lean in. Very often, they say, "Me too." And in that moment, something opens between you that wasn't there before.

Then do it again. And again. Each time, it gets a little easier. Each time, the armor gets a little lighter.

I'm still learning this. Writing some of the chapters in this book was uncomfortable. There were parts I almost left out. But every time I've chosen to be honest about who I've been, I've found that it connects me to people instead of pushing them away. The things I was most ashamed of have turned out to be the things that help people the most.

Take off the armor

Here's the thing I wish I could go back and tell the guy on the toilet lid.

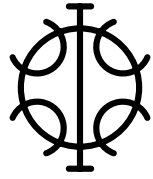
You don't need to become invulnerable. You need to become brave. Those are different things. Invulnerable means nothing can touch you,

which also means nothing can reach you. Brave means things can hurt you, and you show up anyway.

The walls you build to keep out pain also keep out Jennifer dancing in the kitchen. They keep out the friend who wants to help. They keep out the new idea, the new habit, the new version of yourself trying to be born. Take off the armor. Not all at once, maybe. One piece at a time. Let someone see you. Tell someone the truth. Try something you might be bad at.

You'll get hurt sometimes. That's the price of admission. But you'll also be alive in a way that armor never allows.

Don't kill it. Just hit it. The real you is enough.



PART FIVE

Live It Out



CHAPTER SIXTEEN

An Ever-Fixed Mark

WHEN I FIRST SKETCHED out an outline for a real book, years before I wrote this one, the very first word on the page was "Love." And the last word on the page was "love," too. Everything else was in between.

That wasn't an accident. After everything I've been through, the drugs, the weight, the divorce, the chasing, the money, I've landed on a pretty simple conclusion. Love is the beginning and the end of it. Everything else is what happens in the middle.

Under that first "Love," I wrote a few lines about Shakespeare's Sonnet 116. I want to start this chapter there, because I haven't found a better description of what real love looks like.

Let me not

Here's how the sonnet opens:

> *Let me not to the marriage of true minds*
> *Admit impediments. Love is not love*
> *Which alters when it alteration finds,*
> *Or bends with the remover to remove.*

O no! it is an ever-fixed mark
That looks on tempests and is never shaken.

In plain English, Shakespeare is saying that real love doesn't change just because circumstances change. It doesn't bend when things get hard. It doesn't walk away when the other person changes, or when someone tries to pull it apart. It's an ever-fixed mark, like a lighthouse or a landmark that sailors steer by. It looks straight at the storm and doesn't move.

When I wrote about this in the outline, I noted that Shakespeare wrote it long before there were marriage counselors or anyone had fully developed the idea of strategic planning. And yet there's a beauty in it that no amount of strategy can match.

Then I tried to put it in my own words. It's like the hurricane is right there. You can see it. It's coming at you, ready to engulf you, thrash you, possibly destroy you. And yet you don't move. You're held to your spot by love, something a great deal stronger, in fact, than any storm the world can throw at you.

That's the kind of love I'm talking about in this chapter. Not the kind in movies, where everything is fireworks and grand gestures. The kind that holds when the storm hits.

I didn't always know that kind of love. For a long time, I didn't even believe it existed. Let me tell you about the before.

Love that alters

I've been married twice. The first time, I was in my twenties.

It started out with real potential. She was radically successful in a male-dominated field, which I admired. I was a young man with a world of opportunity in front of me. We had fun. We took road trips. And we were elated when we found out we had a perfect baby girl on the way to bless our family.

Then, as happens, things went dramatically south.

It started innocently enough. An argument that never got resolved. A continual displeasure at being in each other's presence. Mutual frustra-

tion, not always voiced, but present in the air like a dripping faucet slowly driving the whole family crazy, with nobody taking ownership of fixing it.

Then it got bigger. Public outbursts. One spouse leaving the other without a car eight hours from home. It all built up to the serving of divorce papers.

The moment I remember most came near the end. My then-wife slammed the bedroom door in my face and told me to get out. Out of the house, but more emphatically, out of her life. Forever.

For a fraction of a second, I actually considered breaking the door down. The rage and frustration had reached their peak. But the same thought that made me want to stay also stopped my foot from splintering that door. My not-quite-one-year-old daughter was on the other side, in that room.

For a guy who believed he could make anything work, who thought he could be anything to anyone as the need arose, it was the biggest blow of my young life. All I wanted was to not feel the way I felt. I was a failure. A loser. I'd be marked for the rest of my life. Damaged goods. My ego left me. My soul evaporated through my pores. The world lost all color. It was over.

When it was done, everything I owned fit in a Jeep Wrangler. Not the Unlimited. The short, two-door kind.

What I learned from the wreckage

I want to be careful here. There are two people in every marriage, and I'm only telling you my side. I'm sure she has hers, and I'm sure there are parts of mine that don't make me look good. I was young. I was still carrying a lot of damage from the years before. I didn't know how to love well, because I'd never learned. I own my part in how it ended.

But here's the lesson I took from that marriage, and it's one I think applies to a lot of people. The right relationships can take you to the most epic highs. The wrong relationships can destroy you in a way where good people turn bad and the best intentions in the world can't save you.

I've seen it over and over, in my own life and in the lives of people around me. Two decent people get together, and something in the combination brings out the worst in both of them. Neither one is a villain. But together, they're poison. They start keeping score. They start assuming the worst. They start saying things they'd never say to anyone else. And it gets worse and worse until one of them is slamming a door and the other is standing outside it, wondering who they've become.

Remember the idea of being a warning or an example? That marriage turned both of us into warnings, at least for a while. And the one who'd have paid the highest price for that was the little girl in the room behind the door.

Love that holds

My experiences back then are a crazy contrast to the world I know now.

Jennifer, my wife, is my best friend, my biggest advocate, my first good morning and my last call. When I get home, I run through the house to find her. When I first wrote that sentence in my journal draft, we'd been together eleven years, and I wrote that I loved kissing her more then than I ever had before. That's still true.

In the dedication of that journal, I tried to tell her what she means to me. I called her my best friend, my editor, my business partner, my ride-or-die fellow traveler. I told her the world truly spins for her. And I wrote something I believe with my whole heart: "You resurrected me, taught me how to love and more importantly how to live. You quiet the restlessness in my soul."

I don't use the word "resurrected" lightly. I died to myself once, in that yellow room, and walked out a different person. But the new guy was still guarded, still armored, still carrying around a lot of the damage from the divorce and the toilet lid. Jennifer brought the rest of him back to life. She taught me that love didn't have to be a battlefield. That you could be completely yourself with someone and still be loved. That home could be a place where you exhale.

And she dances in the kitchen. I've told you about the day she ate the world's best cupcake and started dancing around, with Avicii playing in the background. When I laughed, she told me, "It's not the music I'm dancing to." That's who she is. That's the joy she brings into every room. Every morning, when I sit down and put my hands on my heart and think of three things I'm grateful for, she's the first one.

So what's the difference?

People have asked me, and I've asked myself: what made the difference? How can the experience of marriage have such a completely different complexion from one relationship to the next? How are some people still blissfully together after decades while others want to kill each other after a couple of years?

The answer is simple. Not easy, but simple.

Gratitude.

When we're grateful, we can't be mad, hurt, upset, or jealous, at least not for long. Gratitude and resentment can't live in the same house. And when you're genuinely grateful for someone, that gratitude will always lead you to put them before yourself.

Think about the first marriage. What was running underneath it? Frustration. Displeasure. A dripping faucet of resentment that nobody fixed. The operating system was scarcity: what am I not getting, what is she not doing, why isn't this better? And every interaction ran on top of that.

With Jennifer, the operating system is gratitude. I start every day being thankful for her, specifically, with my whole body. Do you know how hard it is to pick a fight with someone you just spent a full minute being deeply grateful for? It's almost impossible. When she does something that bugs me, and she does, because we're both human, it lands on a foundation of gratitude, and it just doesn't have the same weight.

This is the filter from Chapter 3 at work in a marriage. If your brain is set to scan for everything your partner does wrong, you'll find it. Every dish left in the sink. Every forgotten errand. Every tone of voice. You'll

have a highlight reel of their failures and a blacked-out screen for everything they do right. If your brain is set to scan for what you appreciate about them, you'll find that too. The coffee they made you. The way they listened. The text in the middle of the day. Same person. Different filter. Completely different marriage.

Put your wants on hold

When I wrote about relationships in the journal, I said something that some people found a little harsh. I'll say it again, because I believe it.

If you're in a relationship that isn't working, or one that's going through a trying time, throw away what you want. Do it now. If you can't put your wants on hold for five minutes for the needs of the person you claim to love, how real is your love?

Most relationship fights are two people standing on opposite sides of a table, each one demanding to be heard first. Each one waiting for the other to give. Each one keeping score. And nobody moves.

Somebody has to go first. Let it be you. Put their needs ahead of yours, not as a doormat, but as a gift. By giving in that way, you get more than you could ever ask for or hope for. I've seen it happen over and over. When one person stops keeping score, the game changes.

Mumford & Sons have a line in one of their songs that I put in the journal: "Love, it will not betray you, dismay or enslave you, it will set you free." I think the freedom comes from exactly this. When you stop grasping for what you're owed, you're free. You're not a prisoner of the scoreboard anymore.

When to let go

Now, I need to say something important, because I don't want anyone to read "put your wants on hold" and think I'm telling them to stay in a situation that's hurting them.

There are some relationships you just shouldn't be in. The ones that take you down roads you know you don't want to be on. The ones that drain you. The ones that bring out the lowest version of yourself. And

certainly the ones where you're not safe. Those aren't relationships to sacrifice for. Those are monkey traps.

In the journal I wrote: jettison these. It's time to shed the unneeded, unwanted, undeserved weight. I know it's sometimes painful. The pain of regret is greater.

This applies to friendships, too, and to business partnerships, and to family relationships that have become toxic. Remember what I said in the chapter on dying to yourself: your standards will be as high as the lowest standards of the people you surround yourself with. You can't become someone new while you're surrounded by people who need you to stay the old you.

Letting go of a relationship doesn't have to mean hating the person. You can be grateful for what you learned, grateful for the good times, and still know it's over. Open your hand. Let it go. Make room for something better.

Curious, not judgmental

There's a line I used in the journal that I attributed to Walt Whitman: "Be curious, not judgmental." I've since learned that, as far as anyone can tell, Whitman never actually wrote it. It's been floating around the internet with his name on it for years, and it got a big boost from a popular TV show. I'm telling you that because I promised to be straight with you about quotes. But I'm keeping the idea, because I think it's one of the most important things you can bring to any relationship.

We become creatures of habit. Instead of seeing people fresh, we fall back on quick first impressions and never give them a second thought. Worse, we adopt the opinions of the people around us. We find out someone is from a certain place, or a certain religion, or a certain background, and we think we know everything about them.

I said it pretty bluntly in the journal: that's nonsense. Actually, I used a stronger word, in all caps, with four exclamation points. Become curious. Learn about the world around you, the people around you, and what they believe and care about.

And start with the people closest to you. When's the last time you had a truly meaningful conversation with your spouse, your kids, or your parents? Not about logistics. Not about who's picking up whom. A real conversation, where you asked questions because you genuinely wanted to know the answers.

This is where Chase Hughes's idea of a baseline comes back in. When you pay close attention to the people you love, you learn their normal. And then you notice when something shifts. The quiet dinner. The short answer. The look that isn't usually there. Most people blow right past those moments, because they're not paying attention. A curious person notices and asks. "Hey, you seem a little off today. What's going on?" That one question, asked with real curiosity instead of judgment, can change the whole direction of a relationship.

Vulnerability in love

I talked about Brené Brown in the last chapter, and I want to bring her back for a minute, because her work on vulnerability matters more in love than anywhere else.

Love requires vulnerability. There's no way around it. To love someone deeply is to hand them the power to hurt you. That's terrifying, especially if you've been hurt before. After my divorce and the toilet lid, I told myself I'd never be that vulnerable again. And for a while, I wasn't. I kept a piece of myself locked away, even in relationships.

It didn't work. You can't have deep love with part of your heart behind a wall. The other person can feel the wall, even if they can't name it. Jennifer could feel it. And she was patient with me, and brave enough to be vulnerable herself, and slowly the wall came down.

What I've learned is that the risk of loving fully is worth it. Yes, you might get hurt. But the alternative is a life where you never really get hurt and never really get loved, either. I'll take the risk.

Love as identity

Let me tie this into the bigger theme of becoming someone new.

For years, part of my identity was "the guy who's bad at relationships." I had evidence: a divorce, a girlfriend who left, a string of disappointments. My filter was set to find more evidence. Every little conflict became proof that I was damaged goods.

Part of what changed with Jennifer wasn't just that I found the right person. It's that I decided to become the right person. I decided that I was someone who could love well. Someone who puts his partner first. Someone who starts every day with gratitude for the person next to him. Someone who runs through the house to find her.

At first, that identity felt like a stretch. But I acted like it anyway. And every morning of gratitude, every time I put her needs ahead of mine, every time I chose curiosity instead of judgment, I was collecting evidence. Now it's just who I am.

If you believe you're bad at love, you'll find a way to prove it. If you decide you're someone who loves well, and then start acting like it, you'll start proving that instead.

Small rituals, fixed marks

Love that holds through storms isn't built in the storms. It's built in the thousand ordinary days in between.

I've come to believe that the strongest relationships run on small rituals. Not grand gestures. Little, repeated acts that say "you matter to me" without needing words.

For me, one of those is the gratitude practice I've described so many times in this book. Jennifer is the first thing I'm thankful for every morning, and that ritual has done more for our marriage than any vacation or gift ever could. Another is simply going to find her when I get home. Not yelling "I'm home" from the door and heading to the fridge, but actually going to find her. It takes thirty seconds. It says something important every single time.

Your rituals will look different. Maybe it's coffee together before the kids wake up. Maybe it's a walk after dinner. Maybe it's a text in the middle of the workday that says nothing more than "thinking about you."

Maybe it's putting the phones in a drawer at dinner. The specific ritual matters much less than the consistency.

This is identity work again, just applied to a couple. Every small ritual is a vote for "we are the kind of couple who takes care of each other." Stack up enough of those votes, and when the hurricane comes, you're not scrambling to find your footing. You're standing on years of evidence that you're in this together.

Love when you've been hurt before

If you've been hurt badly in love, and a lot of us have, the idea of an ever-fixed mark might sound naive. I understand. After everything I'd been through, I didn't believe that kind of love existed, or if it did, I didn't believe it was available to someone like me.

What changed my mind wasn't an argument. It was experience. It was Jennifer showing up, again and again, in ways that didn't match my old story. My filter was set to find evidence that love always ends. She kept handing me evidence that it doesn't have to.

If you've been hurt, your filter might be set that way too. It might be scanning every new relationship for signs of the old betrayal. That's understandable. It's also worth noticing, because it can make you push away the very people who could prove you wrong. Be careful, yes. Use good judgment. But leave the door open a crack for evidence that doesn't fit your old story.

Gratitude on the hard days of marriage

I don't want to give the impression that a marriage built on gratitude never has rough days. Jennifer and I have them. Every couple does. We get tired. We get short with each other. We misunderstand each other. We bring the stress of work home.

What gratitude does isn't prevent those days. It changes what happens on them.

On a hard day, when I'm frustrated with her, or she's frustrated with me, the morning practice is still in there somewhere. I've still started the

day thinking of her first. That creates a kind of floor. The frustration can only drop so far before it hits a solid layer of appreciation and stops. It's very hard to say something truly cruel to someone you spent a full minute being grateful for that morning.

And when the rough patch passes, gratitude speeds up the repair. It's easier to apologize to someone you're thankful for. It's easier to forgive. It's easier to remember that the fight was a moment, and the love is the ever-fixed mark.

If your marriage is in a hard season, I'm not going to tell you gratitude will fix everything. Some things need counseling, honest conversations, real change from both people. But I'd bet it won't hurt to start each morning thinking of one specific thing you're grateful for about your partner. Feel it. Then go into the day and see if anything shifts.

The fixed mark

I'll end where Shakespeare ends. After describing love as an ever-fixed mark that looks on tempests and is never shaken, he goes on to say that love isn't the fool of time. Looks fade. Circumstances change. But real love doesn't alter with the hours and weeks. It bears it out, as he puts it, even to the edge of doom.

That's what I want for you. Not a perfect relationship, because there's no such thing. A fixed mark. A love that's rooted in gratitude, practiced every day, chosen over and over. A love that sees the hurricane coming and doesn't move.

It starts with being grateful for the person in front of you. Tomorrow morning, before you do anything else, think of them. Not in general. A specific moment. Feel it. Let it fill you up.

Then go find them. Maybe even run through the house.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Work You Chase

Reading someone's need and then finding a solution is, and always will be, what I do.

I wrote that sentence in my journal draft when I was telling the story of the toilet lid and how I found my way into sales. When I read it now, it still feels like the truest description of my working life I've ever managed. It's what I did as a young salesman on the floor. It's what I do now as a general manager. It's what I'm trying to do in this book.

I want to use this chapter to talk about work. Not just careers and money, although we'll get to those. I want to talk about work as one of the main places where the person you're becoming actually shows up. You spend a huge chunk of your waking life working. If gratitude, focus, and identity don't show up there, they don't really show up anywhere.

What selling actually is

People have a lot of ideas about car salespeople, and most of them aren't flattering. I get it. The industry earned some of that reputation. There were, and still are, people who treat customers like marks and deals like battles to be won.

But here's what I learned on the floor, and it's the opposite of the stereotype. The best salespeople I've ever known aren't the pushiest. They're the most empathetic. They're the ones who can sit across from a family and figure out what they actually need, not what they say they want in the first five minutes, but what they really need. The dad who says he wants something sporty but has three kids and a long commute. The retired couple who say price is all that matters but light up when they talk about road trips to see their grandkids. The young woman buying her first car who's scared to death of being taken advantage of.

My empathetic nature led me toward sales-related work again and again, long before I understood why. I think it's because I'd been so broken myself that I could recognize it in other people. I knew what it felt like to be scared, to feel stupid, to feel out of options. When someone walked onto the lot carrying that, I could see it. And I wanted to help.

That's what selling actually is, when it's done right. You listen. You understand. You find the thing that genuinely solves their problem. And you help them get there. If you do that, the sale takes care of itself, and so does the career.

Chase it like you mean it

When I decided on that toilet lid that I was going to be successful, I chased it in a way that cut out every other possibility. I let go of a lot. Relationships, time, leisure hours. Anything that didn't have to do with where I was headed got cut. If I'm being honest, it was painful much of the time. But it was my decision. I decided what I wanted, and I chased it.

Nothing is gained without sacrifice. I believe that. Just make sure you're chasing what you want. Don't waste time chasing someone else's dream or someone else's career path. The people who truly love you will understand in the end. The ones who don't will try to hold you back. Don't let them.

Here's the approach I took, and it's the approach I'd recommend to anyone serious about their work. Decide what you want professionally, and then chase it harder than you chase anything else. Pursue it like a pas-

sion. Wake up for it. Make sure it's something you actually love, and don't stop until you're dominating your market.

I operated from a simple mindset: never complain, never make excuses. Keep going until you find a way.

If you're already in the career you want, ask yourself what it would take to make it better. If you're unhappy where you are, find something you love and chase it. If you give it everything, you won't be disappointed.

Dabbling leads to disaster

Bear Grylls said, "Tentative is no power." I put that line at the top of one of the weeks in the journal, and underneath it I wrote a phrase I've repeated to more salespeople than I can count: dabbling leads to disaster.

How many worlds do you halfway exist in? How many things do you dabble in? A little of this, a little of that, never fully committed to any of it?

In the journal, I used an example I still love. Ask any twelve-year-old what they want to be when they grow up, and they'll tell you. In detail. "I want to be a policeman, have three kids, a house with a pool, a fast car, a truck, and two dogs, one a husky and the other a golden retriever." They don't hedge. They don't say, "Well, maybe, depending on the market." They know exactly what they want.

What would happen if we took a lesson from a twelve-year-old?

When I was building my career, I focused hard on fewer things. Only the activities I'd decided mattered got my attention. Everything else, the stuff I might have liked to do, or got roped into, didn't make the cut. You'll be surprised how much you get done by focusing on fewer things.

This is the filter again, working in your career. When you're dabbling, your attention is spread across a dozen targets, so your brain doesn't know what to look for. When you commit to one clear target, your brain starts spotting every opportunity related to it. The customer who might be ready to buy. The skill you need to build. The mentor who could help. They were always there. Now you can see them.

Leading from the front

These days, most of my work is leading other people. And if there's one thing I've learned about leadership, it's that everything we talked about in the chapter on being a warning or an example gets multiplied by the number of people watching you.

When you're a salesperson, your attitude affects your own results. When you're a manager, your attitude affects everyone's results. If I walk into the building in a lousy state, the whole store feels it within an hour. If I walk in grateful, focused, and calm, that spreads too. I've watched it happen both ways more times than I'd like to admit.

The culture of a place isn't what's written on the wall. It's what the leader does when things get hard. And in a dealership, things get hard pretty much every month.

I want to tell you about a moment when a leader faced about as hard a situation as a leader can face, and what he did with it.

Washington's spectacles

In March of 1783, the Revolutionary War was essentially over, but the Continental Army hadn't been paid in a long time. The officers were furious. Congress was broke and seemed unable or unwilling to make good on what it owed them. At the army's camp in Newburgh, New York, an anonymous letter began circulating among the officers, urging them to take matters into their own hands. There was real talk of the army defying Congress. It was one of the most dangerous moments in American history. The whole experiment in self-government could have ended right there, with the military taking over.

George Washington called a meeting of the officers. He walked in and gave a speech urging them not to throw away everything they'd fought for. By most accounts, the room was cold. The officers weren't moved.

Then Washington pulled out a letter from a member of Congress that he wanted to read to them. He started reading, and he stumbled. He couldn't make out the words. So he reached into his pocket and pulled

out a pair of spectacles, which most of his officers had never seen him wear.

And he said something that's been recorded, in various versions, ever since: "Gentlemen, you will permit me to put on my spectacles, for I have not only grown gray but almost blind in the service of my country."

According to the accounts of people who were there, that moment broke the room. Hardened officers were in tears. They saw their commander not as a distant figure of authority, but as a man who'd sacrificed alongside them for eight long years. After Washington left, the officers voted to reaffirm their loyalty to Congress. The crisis passed.

I love this story for a lot of reasons. It's leadership by example, obviously. Washington had earned the right to ask for their loyalty because he'd given his own for years. But it's also a story about vulnerability. His speech didn't win the room. His argument didn't win the room. What won the room was a moment of genuine human weakness. An aging man who needed glasses to read. Brené Brown would have loved it.

Remember the boy who copied out the Rules of Civility? This is where that private work paid off in public. The character he'd built over decades showed up in the one moment when the country needed it most.

Influence with integrity

I mentioned Chase Hughes back in the chapter on state. I want to come back to him here, because influence is a huge part of work, whether you're in sales or not. You're always trying to influence someone: a customer, a boss, a coworker, a team.

Hughes has spent years studying how influence and persuasion actually work, down to the level of body language and behavior. And one of the things I appreciate about the parts of his work I've studied is his emphasis on awareness, of yourself and of others. You can't influence people well if you're not paying attention to them, and you can't influence them honestly if you're not aware of what you're projecting.

Here's my take, as a guy who's spent his career in an industry known for manipulation. There's a line between influence and manipulation,

and it's pretty simple. Manipulation is using what you know about people to get what you want at their expense. Influence, the good kind, is using what you know about people to help them get what they need, in a way that also works for you.

Zig Ziglar, one of the great sales trainers of all time, said it better than I can: "You can have everything in life you want, if you will just help other people get what they want." That's the whole philosophy. If you're focused on helping people, the skills of influence become tools for service. If you're focused on taking from people, those same skills become weapons. And people can feel the difference, even if they can't say why.

Compete with yourself

Jennifer left a note in the margins of the journal that made me laugh. She suggested I write about healthy competition, because, as she put it, competition is a huge motivator for her, "like when I kill ya' in poker." I'm not going to confirm or deny who wins more of our poker games. But she's right that competition can light a fire.

The best kind of competition, though, isn't against other people. I've heard it said that Michael Jordan, when he was dominating the NBA, saw himself as competing against his own standard more than against anyone else in the league. Whether or not he put it exactly that way, the idea is sound. When you compare yourself to others, you end up either arrogant or resentful. When you compare yourself to who you were yesterday, you just get better.

Jordan also said something in a famous Nike commercial that's worth remembering whenever work gets hard: "I've missed more than 9,000 shots in my career. I've lost almost 300 games. 26 times, I've been trusted to take the game-winning shot and missed. I've failed over and over and over again in my life. And that is why I succeed."

The greatest player of his generation built his success on a mountain of misses. Every salesperson, every manager, every entrepreneur should have that one taped to their desk.

Three things a day

Let me get practical for a minute, because work is where abstract ideas either get real or get forgotten.

In the journal, I had a week built around commitment. For seven days, isolate three things you absolutely must get done each day. Not a list of twenty. Three. And whatever you do, don't miss them.

I added a warning that still makes me smile. A person is defined by the goals they set. So if your three goals are eat breakfast, drive to work, and catch Monday night football, that might not be how you want to be defined.

Three meaningful things a day adds up fast. That's over a thousand meaningful things in a year. Most people don't do a thousand meaningful things in a decade, because they spend their days reacting to whatever lands on their desk. The three-things rule forces you to decide what matters before the day decides for you. It's the "beat the day before it shows up in a tank" principle applied to your work.

A guarantee

Another of Jennifer's margin notes was about guarantees. In sales, she pointed out, a guarantee often closes the deal. Think of *Tommy Boy*, where the whole plot turns on whether you can trust the guarantee on the box. Her idea was to give yourself a guarantee. If I hit this target, I'm guaranteed this reward. Something concrete that makes the goal feel real.

I think there's something smart in that, and it goes a little deeper than just a reward system. A guarantee is a promise. When you give yourself one, you're making a commitment to yourself, and every time you keep it, you're building the identity of someone who keeps their word. That's worth more than any reward.

She also suggested moving the goalposts, setting a big, specific goal instead of a small one, because a big goal has a big effect. I agree. Small goals don't get your blood pumping. They don't get your filter excited. A big, specific, slightly scary goal gives your brain something worth hunting for.

Gratitude at work

I've talked about gratitude as an operating system in your personal life. It works at the office too, maybe even better.

A leader who's grateful for their team treats them differently. They notice what people do right, not just what they do wrong. They say thank you, specifically and often. They see the porter who's been there since seven in the morning. They thank the finance manager for staying late to get a deal done. They remember that every person in the building has a life, a family, and a set of worries that don't disappear when they clock in.

And here's the thing: people work harder for a leader who sees them. Not because they're being manipulated, but because being seen feels good, and people naturally want to give back to someone who makes them feel that way. Gratitude reciprocates. At least in my building, it does.

Gratitude also protects you from the grind. Work can wear you down. Month after month of targets, pressure, problems, complaints. If your operating system is scarcity, you'll burn out. Every month will feel like a failure because it's never enough. If your operating system is gratitude, the same pressure lands differently. You're grateful for the job, grateful for the team, grateful for the chance to solve hard problems. The pressure is still there, but it's not crushing you.

When the work goes wrong

Every career has seasons where nothing works. The market turns. A new boss comes in who doesn't like you. The big deal falls through. You get passed over. You get let go.

I've had seasons like that, and I've led teams through them. Here's what I've learned.

First, run the gratitude operating system harder, not softer. When work goes bad, the natural instinct is to drop the morning practice because you're too stressed. That's exactly backwards. That's when you need it most. Being grateful for what you still have, your health, your people, your skills, is what keeps you from making desperate decisions.

Second, ask the better question. Not "why is this happening to me?" but "what would it take?" and "how can I use this?" The toilet-lid question works in every career crisis I've ever seen.

Third, separate your worth from your results. A bad quarter isn't a verdict on who you are. It's a set of results that you can learn from and respond to.

Fourth, go back to basics. When I've seen salespeople in a slump, the ones who climbed out fastest didn't look for a magic trick. They went back to the fundamentals they'd gotten lazy about: the follow-up calls, the thorough walkarounds, the genuine curiosity about the customer. Slumps are often just the bill coming due for skipped basics.

And fifth, remember that the obstacle can become the way. Some of the best career moves I've seen people make came right after the worst career moments they'd had.

Leave it better than you found it

One of the quiet measures I use for my own work is simple: am I leaving this place better than I found it? The store. The team. The individual people who work here. Is anyone's life better because they worked with me?

That question keeps me honest in a way that numbers alone don't. You can hit every target and leave a trail of burned-out people behind you. You can also build something that lasts beyond you, people who grow, who go on to lead their own teams, who remember what they learned from you long after you've moved on.

That's the kind of legacy I'm after at work. Not the plaques on the wall. The people.

The thirty-year conversation

Here's a question I like to ask people who are thinking about a career change, and I ask it of myself too.

Picture yourself thirty years from now, looking back on your working life. What would you regret more: trying something new and failing, or never trying at all?

For almost everyone I've asked, the answer is the same. They'd regret not trying.

That doesn't mean you should quit your job tomorrow with no plan. When I made my move into IT, I didn't just leap. I asked "What would it take?" and then did the work. The academy, the certifications, the late nights. I took the smallest real step I could, then the next one.

But it does mean that fear of failure shouldn't be the thing that makes the decision for you. Fear is a lousy career counselor. It will always tell you to stay where you are, because where you are is known, and known feels safe.

The work you chase should be work you can look back on and be proud you went after, whether or not every attempt worked out. The thirty-years-from-now version of you is counting on the current version to be brave.

You are not your title

One more thing, and it's the most important.

For a long time after the toilet lid, my work was my identity. I was my job. I was my numbers. I was my title. When the month went well, I was a success. When it went badly, I was a failure. My worth rode on the scoreboard.

That's a dangerous way to live, and it's exactly the trap I wrote about in the journal when I said that when you chase accomplishments, it will never be enough. Every accomplishment leads to the need for another one. If you HAVE to accomplish to be happy, your happiness will always be fleeting.

Why not happily accomplish instead?

Your work is something you do. It's a place where your character shows up. It can be a calling, a passion, a way to serve. But it's not who you are. Who you are is the person underneath the title: someone grate-

ful, someone focused, someone who keeps their word, someone who reads a need and finds a solution. If you lose the job, that person is still there. If the title changes, that person is still there.

Years after the toilet lid, I can tell you with total certainty that the money and the cars and the titles don't make you happy. Love, family, and gratitude are what make you truly fulfilled. The work matters. I love my work. But it's one room in the house, not the whole house.

Chase your work like it matters, because it does. Just don't let it become the only thing you are.

Own this one. It pays dividends.



CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Give More Than You Get

"And in the end, the love you take is equal to the love you make."

That's Paul McCartney, from the closing lines of the Beatles' *Abbey Road*. I put it at the top of one of the early weeks in the journal, and I've always thought it's one of the wisest lines in all of popular music. Not because it's complicated. Because it's so simple you can't get around it.

What you give is what you get. Not always right away. Not always from the same person you gave to. But over the long haul of a life, the love you make is the love you end up with.

I built that week of the journal around one idea: for seven days, focus on giving more than you get. And I want to build this chapter around the same idea, because I've come to believe that giving isn't just a nice thing to do. It's one of the most powerful tools for changing who you are.

The greatest winners love to run

In that week of the journal, I wrote a line I still think about: the greatest winners in the world aren't obsessed with winning. They just love to run.

I think the same is true of the most generous people I know. They're not giving to get something back. They're not keeping a ledger. They just love to give. It's become who they are.

That's why, in that week, I told people something that surprised some of them. I said I thought it would be a mistake to try to record all the ways you give. I thought it would cheapen the exercise and put the focus in the wrong place. The minute you start keeping score on your generosity, it stops being generosity. It becomes a transaction. You're giving so you can feel good about how much you gave, which means it's really about you.

Instead, I asked people to do something different. Start each day by taking note of all your blessings. Write them down. Fill your heart with abundance. If you can't think of anything, write down what you could be grateful for if you really had to be. And then go out into the world with that abundance in your heart and on your mind, and do for others.

Do you see the order there? Gratitude first. Then giving.

That's not an accident. It's very hard to give from a place of scarcity. If you believe there isn't enough, time, money, love, attention, you'll hoard it. You'll protect what you have. You'll give only when you're sure you'll get something back. But when you start the day grounded in gratitude, feeling how much you already have, giving becomes natural. It overflows. You're not giving from your last dollar. You're giving from a full cup.

Help a brother out

In the journal I wrote: if you see someone in need, remember all that you have, and with that feeling of gratitude, go help a brother or sister out. Be on the lookout for how you can add value to any situation you're in.

That phrase, "be on the lookout," is doing more work than it looks like. Remember the filter? When you decide that adding value matters, your brain starts scanning for chances to do it. You start noticing the coworker who's overwhelmed. The customer who's confused. The neighbor whose trash can blew over. The stranger struggling with a heavy door. They were always there. Now you see them, because you told your brain to look.

This is one of the most practical ways I know to reprogram your filter. If your brain has been scanning for threats and slights and problems your whole life, give it a new job. Tell it to scan for ways to help. It'll take a while to switch over, but when it does, the world starts looking different. It becomes a place full of opportunities to make a difference, instead of a place full of things that might hurt you.

Ask to give

I also wrote something in that week that confused some people at first. If you need something, go ask. But ask to give, not just to receive.

What I meant was this. Most of us approach every interaction with a question running in the background: what can I get out of this? What's in it for me? That question isn't evil. We all have needs. But if it's the only question, every conversation becomes a negotiation, and people can feel it.

The question I suggested instead was: how can I meet my needs and still give?

That question changes everything. It doesn't ask you to be a doormat or ignore your own needs. It asks you to find the path where both people win. When you walk into your boss's office to ask for a raise, the question isn't just "How do I get more money?" It's "How do I get what I need while giving my boss something valuable too?" When you're negotiating with a customer, it's not "How do I get the most out of them?" It's "How do I meet my goals and make sure they drive away genuinely happy?"

I called it a seminal question, one that plants seeds. Ask it for a week, and I promise you'll start seeing possibilities you never noticed before.

It feels different at first. But be careful: giving is addictive. You might just fall in love with it.

Why giving changes you

Here's what I've come to understand about giving that goes deeper than "it's nice."

When you give, you're casting a vote for who you are. Remember, identity is built out of evidence. Every time you help someone, you're collecting a piece of evidence that says, "I'm someone who helps." Every time you give when you didn't have to, you're building the identity of a generous person. And we act consistently with who we believe we are. So the more you give, the more of a giver you become, and the easier the next gift gets.

Giving also breaks the grip of self-focus, which is where a lot of our misery lives. When you're stuck in your own head, obsessing over your own problems, the world shrinks down to the size of your worries. Giving blows that open. For the few minutes you're focused on helping someone else, your own problems move to the background. You come back to them a little lighter, with a little more perspective.

I've seen this in myself a hundred times. On days when I'm stressed out and spinning, the fastest way out isn't more thinking about my problem. It's walking out onto the floor and helping someone else with theirs. By the time I'm done, my own problem looks smaller. Not because it changed. Because I did.

And giving is a powerful antidote to shame, which we talked about a couple of chapters ago. Shame says you're worthless. Giving proves you have something of worth to offer. It's very hard to keep believing you're garbage when you've just made someone's day better.

The people who gave to me

I wouldn't be here without people who gave to me when they had no reason to.

My parents, who showed me unconditional love and were always there for me regardless of the cost. And believe me, during some years, the cost was high. They gave without keeping score, even when I wasn't giving much back.

My grandmother, whom I've always measured my life by. I'm still trying to catch up to her.

My Uncle Philip, who took the time to teach a young guy how to swing a golf club, and in the process taught him how to stop forcing life.

Steve Uiterwyk, who picked up the phone whenever I called and gave me the gift of clarity and perspective, and who still does.

Levi and Jeyben, who in many ways shared this whole journey with me. In the dedication of the journal, I called Levi a true modern savage, the sterling and extraordinary example of a man who isn't scared to follow his heart and his dreams, and the thought I've turned to many times over the years when I needed strength. And I told Jeyben that he is, always has been, and always will be my brother. No matter what corner of the world he's in, there's a part of him here with me, and no matter what, he always has me in his corner.

Katherine and Danielle, who are my heart, who keep me on my toes and remind me there's always more to learn.

And Jennifer, who gave me back my life.

None of them were keeping score. None of them gave to get something back. They just gave. And their giving changed who I became.

That's the thing about giving. You never know where it's going to land. The time you take with a struggling young person, the phone call you return, the word of encouragement, might end up being the thing that turns their whole life around. You'll probably never know. Give anyway.

The people who are hard to love

Now, it's easy to give to people you like. The real test comes with people who are difficult.

Marcus Aurelius, whom we've met a few times now, opens the second book of his *Meditations* with a note to himself that I think every leader, every parent, and every person who deals with the public should read. In Gregory Hays's translation, it begins: "When you wake up in the morning, tell yourself: The people I deal with today will be meddling, ungrateful, arrogant, dishonest, jealous, and surly."

I laughed out loud the first time I read that. It sounds like a description of a hard day in a car dealership. But Marcus isn't just complaining. He goes on to say that people act that way because they can't tell good from evil, and that he can't be harmed by them unless he lets himself be. He reminds himself that we're all made to work together, like hands and feet, like the upper and lower rows of teeth. To work against each other is unnatural.

What he's doing there is setting his state before the day begins. He's expecting difficult people, so he won't be thrown by them. And he's choosing, ahead of time, to respond with understanding instead of anger.

I've found that incredibly useful. When you expect everyone to be pleasant, every difficult person feels like an attack. When you expect some people to be difficult, and decide ahead of time how you'll respond, they lose their power to ruin your day. You can even give to them. Patience is a gift. Kindness to someone who hasn't earned it is a gift. Not taking the bait is a gift, both to them and to yourself.

With malice toward none

In March of 1865, the Civil War was nearly over. The Union was winning. After four years of slaughter, a lot of people in the North wanted revenge. They wanted the South punished.

Abraham Lincoln stood up to give his Second Inaugural Address, and instead of calling for vengeance, he closed with these words: "With malice toward none, with charity for all, with firmness in the right as God gives us to see the right, let us strive on to finish the work we are in, to bind up the nation's wounds."

With malice toward none. With charity for all.

This was a man who'd lost friends to the war, who'd been cursed and threatened and hated by millions of people, and who was about to win. He could have gloated. He could have demanded punishment. Instead, he chose to give. He offered grace to the people who'd tried to tear the country apart.

I can't read those words without being moved. And I can't read them without asking myself: who am I holding malice toward? Who am I withholding charity from? What would it look like to give to them instead?

Giving where you work and live

Let's bring this down to earth, because giving doesn't have to mean grand gestures.

At work, giving looks like teaching the new hire what you know instead of guarding it like a secret. It looks like covering for a coworker whose kid is sick. It looks like giving credit to the team when things go well and taking the blame yourself when they don't. It looks like telling a customer the truth even when a little fudge would close the deal faster. It looks like remembering the names of the people who clean the building.

At home, giving looks like putting your phone down when your kid starts talking. It looks like doing the dishes without being asked and without announcing that you did them. It looks like listening to your spouse talk about their day when you'd rather zone out. It looks like five minutes of your full attention, which, in a world where everyone's attention is split in a dozen directions, might be the rarest and most valuable gift there is.

In your community, it looks like showing up. Coaching the team. Volunteering at the food bank. Checking on the elderly neighbor. Buying coffee for the person behind you. None of it has to be big. The small stuff, done consistently, is what builds the identity of a giver.

Everyday motivation

When I sketched out that outline for this book, one of the items on the list was "everyday motivation." I've thought a lot about what keeps people going day after day, and I keep landing on giving.

Motivation built on getting runs out. You get the raise, the car, the promotion, and a few weeks later the thrill is gone and you need the next thing. It's the accomplishment treadmill I've talked about. It never ends, and it never satisfies.

Motivation built on giving is different. It renews itself. When you get out of bed because someone is counting on you, because your team needs you, because your kids need you, because there's a customer out there who's going to be scared and confused and you're going to help them, that motivation doesn't wear out. It grows. The more you give, the more reasons you find to keep giving.

Tony Robbins often says that the secret to living is giving. I believe it. I've lived on both sides. I've lived for what I could get, and I've lived for what I could give. The second way is better. Not just morally better. Better to live inside of.

Warning or example, revisited

Remember the question from Chapter 2? Everybody's life is either a warning or an example. What they see is up to you.

Giving is the fastest way I know to become an example. Nobody looks at a generous person and thinks, "Whatever I do, don't let me end up like that." People look at generous people and want to be like them. Every act of giving is a small demonstration of what a good life can look like.

And here's the beautiful part. When you give, you also give other people permission to give. You show them it's possible. You start a ripple that goes out further than you'll ever see.

Giving without being a doormat

I want to add a note of balance, because I know some people hear "give more than you get" and hear "let people walk all over you."

That's not what I mean. Giving from a full cup is powerful. Giving from an empty one, because you can't say no, because you're afraid people won't like you, because you've never learned you're allowed to have needs, is something else. That's not generosity. That's a monkey trap wearing a halo.

Healthy giving has boundaries. It comes from choice, not compulsion. You can be deeply generous and still say, "I can't take that on this week." You can love someone and still refuse to rescue them from the conse-

quences of their own choices. You can serve customers wholeheartedly and still refuse to be abused by one.

This is why I keep coming back to that question from the journal: how can I meet my needs and still give? Both halves matter. If you only meet your needs, you become selfish. If you only give, you burn out and eventually have nothing left to give. The sweet spot is where both happen at once.

Gratitude helps here too. When you're grateful for what you have, including your own time and energy, you treat them as the gifts they are. You give them freely, but not carelessly.

The rarest gift

If I had to pick one thing to give that almost everyone needs and almost no one gets enough of, it would be attention.

Real attention. Not the half-listening we do while checking our phones. Not the nodding while we plan what to say next. Full, curious, undistracted attention, the kind that makes the other person feel like they're the only one in the room.

It's rare because it's expensive. It costs you your own agenda for a few minutes. It costs you the little hit of whatever your phone is offering. It costs you the comfort of staying in your own head.

But it's one of the most powerful gifts there is. I've watched customers relax completely when a salesperson actually listened to them. I've watched employees open up when a manager put the phone face down and asked how they were really doing. I've felt it myself, when Jennifer sets everything aside and just listens.

Chase Hughes's idea of noticing people's baseline starts here. You can't notice anything about someone you're not paying attention to. And Brené Brown's research on connection points the same direction. People need to feel seen.

Give your attention like it's valuable. Because it is.

Giving at work

A lot of people think giving belongs to their personal life, and work is where you take. Get the raise, close the deal, win the promotion. I spent years thinking that way.

What I've found is the opposite. The people who do best over the long run, at least in my experience, are the ones who give the most at work. They share what they know instead of hoarding it. They help the new person figure out the system. They give credit to the team when things go well and take responsibility when they don't. They make introductions, answer questions, and show up for people who can't do anything for them in return.

In sales especially, the instinct is to protect your territory and your secrets. But the best people I've ever worked with were generous with both. And people remembered. Customers remembered who treated them like a human being instead of a number. Coworkers remembered who helped them on a hard day. That memory turns into trust, and trust turns into everything else.

As a leader, I try to ask myself a simple question at the end of the week: "Who did I help grow this week?" Not what did I accomplish, but who did I help. Some weeks the answer is embarrassing. But asking the question keeps me honest. And when the answer is good, it's the part of the week I'm most proud of.

The love you make

So here's what I'm asking. Not as homework. Just as a way of living.

Start your day with gratitude. Fill your cup. Then go out and look for chances to pour it out. Help a brother or sister out. Add value wherever you are. Ask how you can meet your needs and still give. Expect difficult people, and give to them anyway. Don't keep score.

And watch what happens. Watch how your filter changes. Watch how the people around you respond. Watch who you become.

In the end, the love you take is equal to the love you make.

Make a lot of it.



CHAPTER NINETEEN

It Is Later Than You Think

There's a poem by Robert Service, the poet who wrote about the Yukon gold rush, that ends with a stanza I put in the journal. It's a little haunting. Here it is:

Lastly, you who read; aye, you
Who this very line may scan:
Think of all you planned to do...
Have you done the best you can?
See! the tavern lights are low;
Black's the night, and how you shrink!
God! and is it time to go?
Ah! the clock is always slow;
It is later than you think;
Sadly later than you think;
Far, far later than you think.

Every time I read that, it lands in my chest. The clock is always slow. It is later than you think.

This chapter is about time. How much we have, how we spend it, and what it means to live like it's running out. Because it is. For all of us.

Only so many tomorrows

Michael Landon, the actor from *Little House on the Prairie* and *Bonanza*, said something near the end of his life, when he was dying of cancer, that became the quote for the second week of my journal:

"Somebody should tell us, right at the start of our lives, that we are dying. Then we might live life to the limit, every minute of every day. Do it! I say. Whatever you want to do, do it now! There are only so many tomorrows."

There are only so many tomorrows.

We don't live like that, most of us. We live like tomorrow is guaranteed. We put off the call to our parents. We put off the trip. We put off the hard conversation, the new career, the book we always wanted to write. We put off being happy until the kids are grown, or until we retire, or until we lose the weight. We act like we've got an endless supply of days.

And then someone we love gets sick. Or we get a scare of our own. And suddenly all the things we put off feel unbearably urgent, and we wonder what we were waiting for.

J.M. Barrie gave us the perfect image for this in *Peter Pan*. Captain Hook is terrified of the crocodile that swallowed a clock, because he can always hear it coming: tick, tock, tick, tock. There's a line from the story that I used in the journal: "I suppose it's like the ticking crocodile, isn't it? Time is chasing after all of us."

It is. The clock is ticking inside all of us. Most of us just learn to tune it out.

Remember that you will die

That sounds morbid, and I don't mean it to be. I mean it to be the opposite. I've found that remembering my own death is one of the most life-giving things I can do.

The Stoics had a practice for this. They called it *memento mori*, which roughly means "remember that you will die." Marcus Aurelius returns to it again and again in the *Meditations*. In one passage, in Gregory Hays's

translation, he tells himself: "You could leave life right now. Let that determine what you do and say and think."

Not as a threat. As a clarifier. If you could leave life right now, would you really spend the next hour scrolling through strangers' vacation photos? Would you really stay angry at your brother over something from five years ago? Would you really keep putting off telling the people you love that you love them?

Steve Jobs said something similar in his commencement speech at Stanford in 2005, a line I put in the journal: "Remembering that you are going to die is the best way I know to avoid the trap of thinking you have something to lose. You are already naked. There is no reason not to follow your heart."

You are already naked. I love that. All the fears that keep us small, what will people think, what if I fail, what if I look foolish, shrink down to nothing when you remember that the clock is running and none of us are getting out of here alive.

In the journal, I asked people to sit with a hard question. What would you do if you knew you'd die one day from now? One week? One year? Here's the thing: one day your heart will stop beating. What will you leave behind? Is there anything you'll wish you'd done differently? Anything you'll wish you had done, or hadn't?

And then I told them the great news, the part I want you to hear most of all: it's not too late.

It isn't. Not for you. Not today. You're reading this, which means you're still here, which means the clock hasn't run out. There's still time to make a difference in your life. But you have to realize there are only so many chances. Don't let this one slip by.

Where does it actually go?

"Time is always against us." That's Morpheus, played by Laurence Fishburne in *The Matrix*, and I put it at the top of a week in the journal that asked people to do something simple and eye-opening.

For a day or a week, write down how your time is actually spent. From the moment you wake up to the moment you put your head on your pillow. Don't write to judge it or change it. Just record it. If you do it with a feeling of detachment, you'll be able to watch it from afar, like a movie, and patterns will start to show up.

If you've never done this, I'd encourage you to try it at least once, even for a single day. Most people are shocked. We think we know where our time goes. We don't. We think we're busy with important things. Then we see the actual record, and we find hours disappearing into things that don't matter to us at all. Forty minutes here on the phone. An hour there on a show we don't even like. Twenty minutes stuck in a loop of worry. It adds up.

In another week of the journal, I asked people to think back to yesterday and identify the activities they knew weren't making the most of their time. Then write down how that time could have been better used. And then, every day, replace the unproductive actions with productive ones.

I called it replacing your time killers with dream makers.

Every day, the time-killing serpents rear their heads. The scroll. The unnecessary meeting. The gossip. The TV that's on just because it's always on. The time killers aren't evil. They're just empty. And every minute you give them is a minute you'll never get back.

How you invest your time today will mark today, forever. You'll never get it back.

Breadth and depth

There's a problem with how we spend time that goes beyond just wasting it. It's about how shallow we've become.

In the journal I wrote that so many of us have fallen into the social media trap of getting a top-level idea of every relationship, every situation, every encounter. We've become a society of breadth, not depth. Face value, not core spirit.

We know a little about a thousand people and a lot about almost no one. We skim articles instead of reading books. We text instead of talking.

We watch highlights instead of games. We're present everywhere and truly present nowhere.

I used a quote in the journal that's credited to Deepak Chopra, about how the intention to live as long as possible isn't one of the mind's best intentions, because quantity isn't the same as quality. You can live a long, shallow life. You can live a shorter, deep one. The goal isn't to maximize your days. It's to make your days count.

How do we get out of the shallows? Stop. Take your time. Involve yourself deeply in things that are worthy of your involvement. Care about what you do. Focus on the things that matter, and only on the things that matter.

That last part requires a word most people are terrible at saying.

Learn to say no

No.

If it's not important, don't spend your time on it. Say no. To the extra commitment you don't care about. To the event you're only going to out of guilt. To the project that doesn't move you forward. To the person who only calls when they need something.

This is hard, especially for people who like to please others, which, if you're reading a book like this, might be you. Every no feels like a small betrayal. But every yes to something that doesn't matter is a no to something that does. You're not choosing between yes and no. You're choosing between two yeses: yes to the empty thing, or yes to the thing you'll actually care about when the clock runs out.

Jennifer suggested a question in her margin notes that I love: is it better to do one thing well, or a ton of things half-assed? You know the answer. We all know the answer. We just don't live it.

Try the thing

At the same time, saying no to empty things should free you up to say yes to the things you've been putting off.

In the journal, I had a week inspired by the movie *Yes Man* with Jim Carrey. I called it an easy week. Super easy. For seven days, give yourself permission to do the things you normally only think about. Try one new thing every day. The restaurant you keep driving past. The yoga class you keep meaning to try. The guitar you've always wanted to learn. The play you're curious about. The book you've been putting off.

I opened that week with a line from Lin-Manuel Miranda's *Hamilton*: "There's a million things I haven't done, but just you wait."

The clock is ticking. There are a million things you haven't done. Start doing some of them. Not someday. This week. Because someday has a way of turning into never, and never has a way of turning into regret.

Happily accomplish

Now I need to say something that might sound like it contradicts everything I just said. It doesn't, but it balances it.

Living like time is short doesn't mean cramming every minute with productivity. Some of the most important time you'll ever spend looks, from the outside, like you're doing nothing at all.

In the journal, the week I introduced with Jennifer dancing in the kitchen asked a question I still think about all the time: when is the last time you laughed at the mere existence of being?

We all have distractions every day. Timelines to meet. Quotas to exceed. Places to be that we're running late for. How many days do we spend running at breakneck speed, with our ambition sharpened to an edge, and end the day feeling unfulfilled and frustrated, reaching for a six-pack to numb the disappointment long enough to fall asleep?

When is the last time you smiled at the sunrise? Felt content on the first day of fall? Or, heaven forbid, danced around the kitchen in your underwear at the start of the day?

Here's another secret I shared in that week. When you chase accomplishments, it will never be enough. Never. Every accomplishment will lead to the need for another one. If you HAVE to accomplish to be happy, your happiness will always be fleeting.

Why not HAPPILY accomplish?

Find joy in the moment. Take pleasure in a favorite food. Find the smile in the sunrise. Feel the bliss in a mile run. Look at your significant other and smile at the fact that someone in this world is willing to put up with you.

That's not wasting time. That's the whole point of time.

Dance like a dervish

In *Meet Joe Black*, Anthony Hopkins plays a wealthy man who knows he's about to die. In one scene, he gives a toast, and he talks about wanting his daughter to be swept away, to sing with rapture and dance like a dervish. I used that line in the journal, because I think it's one of the most beautiful pictures of a full life I've ever heard.

How many times do we trudge through the day as if it were exactly the same as the hundreds before it? When you try to remember a time you were blissfully happy, with no worries, is it hard to find one?

What would make you dance like a dervish if nothing else on the planet existed? What's your one true thing? My guess is it isn't anything money can buy. It isn't anything that can be taken from you. If it is, dig deeper.

When you know what that thing is, make time for it. Real time. Not what's left over after everything else. Put it first. The clock's ticking. Don't let it run out before you've danced.

Knowing when to step down

I want to tell you one more story about George Washington, because it's about time, too, in a way. It's about knowing when your time in a role is done.

In December of 1783, after winning the Revolutionary War, Washington did something that stunned the world. He went before Congress and resigned his commission as commander-in-chief. He gave the power back. He went home to Mount Vernon to be a farmer.

This was a man who could have made himself king. The army loved him. Many people would have followed him anywhere. Instead, he handed back the power and walked away. There's a story, reported secondhand through the painter Benjamin West, that when King George III heard Washington intended to give up power and go home, he said that if Washington did that, he would be the greatest man in the world.

And then Washington did it again. After two terms as president, he declined to run for a third, even though he likely would have won. He set a precedent that shaped the country for generations.

Why does this belong in a chapter about time? Because part of using your time well is knowing when to let go of something. Washington understood that his time in power had a limit, and that the most important thing he could do with the end of it was to set an example. He wasn't clinging. He wasn't grasping. His hand was open.

We all have roles we'll eventually need to step down from. Jobs. Titles. Ways of being that have served their purpose. Knowing when to let go, and doing it with grace, is one of the best uses of time there is.

Time with the people who matter

If I'm honest, the biggest time mistake I've made in my life isn't wasting time on my phone, though I've done plenty of that. It's the years I spent pouring almost everything into work and not enough into the people I love.

When I was chasing success after the toilet lid, I cut relationships, time, and leisure hours. I told you that was painful, and I told you I thought it was necessary at the time. Some of it probably was. But some of it I'd do differently. There were phone calls to my parents I didn't make. There were friends I let drift. There were moments I wasn't fully present for, because I was physically in the room but mentally still at the dealership.

Nobody on their deathbed wishes they'd sent more emails. I've never heard of anyone who, near the end, said they wished they'd spent more

time at the office. What people talk about is the people. The ones they loved, the ones they lost touch with, the words they wish they'd said.

So when you audit your time, don't just look for the time killers. Look at how much of your best time, your most alert, most present, least distracted time, goes to the people who matter most. For a lot of us, they get the leftovers. The tired hour at the end of the day, with half our attention on a screen.

Give them better. Put your phone in a drawer. Look them in the eye. Ask a real question. The clock is ticking for them, too.

Every moment counts

In the journal, one of the weeks carried the title "Every Moment Counts," and I think about that phrase a lot, especially on ordinary days.

Most of life isn't made of big moments. It's made of Tuesday afternoons. Drives to work. Dinners that aren't special. Conversations in the kitchen about nothing in particular. If you only count the big moments, the weddings and promotions and vacations, you're going to miss most of your life.

The practice I've found most useful is simply noticing the ordinary on purpose. The way the light hits the kitchen in the morning. The sound of someone you love laughing in another room. The first sip of coffee. The quiet of the lot before anyone else gets there. Those moments are going by right now, whether you notice them or not. Gratitude is just the act of noticing.

When I think about what I'd want back if time ran out tomorrow, it isn't the big stuff. It's a lot of small, ordinary moments I'd like to have paid more attention to while they were happening.

Protect the big rocks

You've probably heard some version of the story about the jar and the rocks. If you fill the jar with sand first, the big rocks won't fit. If you put the big rocks in first, the sand fills in around them.

I don't know who told it first, but I know it's true.

Your time works exactly that way. The sand is everything that fills up a day without you choosing it: email, notifications, scrolling, small errands, other people's emergencies. The big rocks are the things that actually matter. Your marriage. Your kids. Your health. Your morning practice. The work you care most about.

If you don't put the big rocks in first, the sand will always win. It's not that the sand is evil. A lot of it has to get done. But it expands to fill whatever space you give it. There will never be a day when the sand is finished and you finally have room for what matters.

So I try to schedule the big rocks first. My morning practice happens before the phone comes on. Time with Jennifer gets protected like an important meeting, because it is one. Workouts go on the calendar. Then the sand fills in around them.

I still get it wrong. Some weeks the sand wins. But when I look back on the weeks that felt the best, they're always the weeks when I put the big rocks in first.

How you want to be remembered

Let's come back to where we started. The Robert Service poem. The tavern lights getting low. It is later than you think.

In the journal, I asked people to spend time thinking about how they want to be remembered by their spouse, their friends, and their kids. Not in a morbid way. In a clarifying way. If you know how you want to be remembered, you know how to spend your time now.

I want to be remembered as a man who loved his wife with everything he had. Who told the truth. Who helped people find what they needed. Who got knocked down a lot and kept getting back up. Who was grateful. Who became someone better than he started out as, and who helped other people do the same.

Every day, I try to spend at least some of my time on those things. Some days I do better than others. But knowing what I want to be remembered for makes it a lot easier to say no to the time killers and yes to the dream makers.

What do you want to be remembered for? Are you spending your time on it?

There are only so many tomorrows. The clock is always slow. It is later than you think.

But it's not too late. Not yet. Not today.

Start now. You deserve it.



CHAPTER TWENTY

Your Hero Is Ten Years Away

In March of 2014, Matthew McConaughey walked onto the stage at the Academy Awards to accept the Oscar for Best Actor. A lot of people remember the speech for the ending, when he signed off with his trademark "Alright, alright, alright" and told everyone to "just keep livin'." But the middle of that speech is the part that's stayed with me for years. I've thought about it more than almost any other few minutes of television I've ever seen.

He said there were three things he needed each day. One of them was something to look up to. Another was something to look forward to. And another was someone to chase.

Something to look up to, he said, was God. He'd opened the speech by thanking God, and talking about gratitude, which we talked about back in the chapter on gratitude as an operating system.

Something to look forward to was his family. His wife and kids, and his late father, and his mother, who was sitting in the audience.

And someone to chase? That was his hero.

Me in ten years

Then he told a story. When he was fifteen years old, he said, somebody important in his life asked him who his hero was. He thought about it and said he'd get back to them. A couple of weeks later, he came back and said, "You know who my hero is? It's me in ten years."

So at twenty-five, the same person came back and asked, "So, are you a hero?" And he said, "Not even close." Because his hero was him at thirty-five.

And then he said the line that I've come back to again and again: every day, every week, every month, every year of his life, his hero is always ten years away. He said he's never going to be his hero. He's not going to attain that. He knows he won't. And he said that's just fine with him, because it keeps him with somebody to keep on chasing.

When I heard that, it lit something up in me. Because it's exactly what this whole book has been about.

Your hero is you. Not the you that exists right now. The you that's ten years down the road, if you keep chiseling. The sculpture that's still partly inside the marble. You'll never quite catch them, because every time you get closer, you'll be able to see a little further. And that's not a failure. That's the whole point. It means you'll always have someone to chase.

Gratitude, then the chase

Notice the order of McConaughey's three things. Something to look up to. Something to look forward to. Someone to chase.

The chase comes last.

That's not an accident, and it's the same order I've been pushing all through this book. You start with gratitude, with looking up, with grounding yourself in something bigger than your own ambition. Then you anchor yourself in the people you love, the things you look forward to. And only then do you chase.

If you chase without the first two, the chase becomes desperate. It becomes the accomplishment treadmill I've warned you about, where noth-

ing's ever enough and every win just leads to the need for another one. You're running from something, not toward something.

But when the chase sits on top of gratitude and love, it changes completely. You're not running because you're empty. You're running because you're full, and you want to see what else is possible. The chase becomes a joy instead of a burden. You happily accomplish instead of needing to accomplish to be happy.

McConaughey got it right. Look up first. Look forward next. Then chase.

A letter across time

In the second week of my original journal, I asked people to do something that I think is one of the most powerful exercises there is. Write a letter to yourself. Either from sometime in the future, or to your younger self.

What would you warn yourself about? What would you encourage yourself to pursue? What regrets would you help yourself avoid? How would you guide the younger version of you to make the most of every opportunity?

I'm not going to assign it to you. But I want to tell you what happens when you imagine it, because it connects straight to McConaughey's hero.

When you picture yourself ten years from now, really picture it, the way Jose Silva taught, in a relaxed state, with color and sound and feeling, something interesting happens. That future you starts to become real to your brain. And a real future self starts to pull on you in the present.

Think about the filter we talked about in Chapter 3. When you have a vivid picture of who you're becoming, your brain knows what to look for. The opportunities that the future you would take start jumping out at you. The habits the future you would have start feeling more natural. The things the future you wouldn't tolerate start feeling intolerable now.

And think about identity. We act consistently with who we believe we are. When you get clear on who you're becoming, and you start to iden-

tify with that person, you begin acting like them. Not all at once. Not perfectly. But the pull is real.

I've done this more times than I can count. When I was at 271 pounds, I pictured a guy who jogged in the morning and felt good in his body. When I was sitting on the toilet lid, I pictured a guy who'd built something real. When I was armored up after the divorce, I pictured a guy who could love without walls. Every one of those pictures was ten years away at the time. And every one of them pulled me forward.

Compare yourself to yourself

This is why I've always told people to stop comparing themselves to others. In the journal I wrote that we look around us and resent other people, or compare ourselves to them, and then wonder why resentment stares back at us from the mirror.

The only comparison that makes sense is you against you. You know what you've accomplished in the past. You know what it'll take to feel fulfilled in the future. You know where you are today and where you should be.

In that same week, I asked people to sit down, close their eyes, and picture the best possible version of themselves standing right in front of them. What would they look like? What would they sound like? And then set your targets for that future self. Not what you want in comparison with others. What you want, period.

That's McConaughey's hero. That's the white-framed mirror from Silva. That's the sculpture inside the marble. It's all the same idea, seen from different angles. There's a better version of you out there, and your job is to chase them.

And here's the key: you'll never be finished. The sculpture is never done. Every time you knock away a piece of marble, you see more of what's underneath, and you realize there's still more to go. That used to frustrate me. Now it excites me. It means there's always somebody to chase.

You will never be the same

On the outline I scribbled out for this book years ago, near the bottom of the list, there's a line that just says: "You will never be the same."

I wrote it as a promise, and I want to keep it.

If you've read this far, you're not the same person who picked up this book. Maybe the change is small. Maybe it's just a new question you've started asking yourself, or a morning where you thought of three things you're grateful for before you reached for your phone. Maybe it's bigger. Maybe you've already started to kill off an old version of yourself.

Either way, something has shifted. Your filter has new information. You can't unknow the monkey trap. You can't unhear "warning or example." You can't forget that the obstacle can become the way, or that it's impossible to be fearful when you're grateful.

That's the thing about real change. Once it starts, you can't go all the way back. You can slide. You can slip. But you'll always know. The old identity will never fit quite as comfortably again, because you've seen what's under the marble.

Hope and action

Two of the last items on that old outline were "your destiny" and "hope and action." I put them next to each other for a reason.

Hope without action is just wishing. It's the person who's been saying "someday" for twenty years. They hope things will get better. They hope they'll lose the weight, find the job, fix the marriage. And they keep hoping, year after year, while nothing changes, because hope alone doesn't move anything.

Action without hope is grinding. It's the person who's working hard but doesn't believe it'll make a difference. They show up, they put in the hours, but there's no fire in it. Eventually they burn out, because you can't sustain effort you don't believe in.

Put them together, and you get something powerful. Hope gives you a reason to act. Action gives your hope something to stand on. Every step

you take makes the hope more believable. And the more you believe, the more you're willing to act.

That's what destiny really is, I think. Not some fixed fate written in the stars. Destiny is what happens when hope and action keep feeding each other for long enough. It's the person you become when you keep chasing your hero, one step at a time, for years.

Remember the ladder from Frank Outlaw? Thoughts become words, words become actions, actions become habits, habits become character, and character becomes destiny. Your destiny isn't waiting for you somewhere out in the future. You're building it right now, with every thought you choose, every word you speak, every action you take.

Just keep livin'

McConaughey has a motto he's lived by for years, and he closed that Oscar speech with it: "Just keep livin'."

It sounds simple, almost like a throwaway line. But I think there's a lot packed into it. It means don't quit. It means keep going even when it's hard. It means life doesn't stop for your setbacks, so don't let your setbacks stop you from living. The red lights will turn green. The obstacles will become the way. Just keep livin'.

In *Greenlights*, he writes about a lot of the hard stuff in his life, not just the successes. He talks about the moments when everything seemed to be going wrong, and how he learned, over time, to see many of them as setting him up for something better. That's a hard lesson to learn in the moment. It's much easier to see in hindsight. But the more times you've seen a red light turn green, the easier it gets to trust that the next one will too.

A year in the life of you

When I first wrote *A Year in the Life of You*, I told people that a year from now, they'd look back with amazement at how much they'd grown. I still believe that.

So picture it. A year from today. Not ten years, just one. If you took even a handful of the ideas in this book seriously, what could be different?

You could be starting every day with gratitude, felt in your body, not just listed in your head. You could have a filter that's been reprogrammed, so you see opportunities and kindness where you used to see only threats and slights. You could have let go of at least one monkey trap. You could be asking better questions. You could have a morning practice that puts you in a strong state before the day shows up in its tank. You could have a thicker callus on your mind. You could have turned at least one obstacle into a path. You could have walked into at least one cage, literal or not, while you were scared. You could have taken off some of the armor. You could love someone better. You could be giving more than you get. You could be spending your time on what matters.

And above all, you could be a different person. Not a better-behaved version of the old you. Someone new. Someone who does these things not because they're forcing themselves, but because that's just who they are now.

That's a year. Imagine ten.

What I'd tell my younger self

Since I brought up the letter to your younger self, I'll share a little of what I'd put in mine. Not the whole thing. Just the parts I think might be useful to you.

I'd tell the kid at the window that the thought "I'll be doing this for the rest of my life" is a lie. It feels like a fact. It isn't. Nothing about who you are right now is permanent.

I'd tell the guy at 271 to stop hating himself for the stretch marks and start being grateful he noticed them. That pain is the best thing that'll happen to you this year.

I'd tell the young husband outside the bedroom door that his life isn't over. That the worst night he's ever had will eventually lead him to the best person he'll ever know.

I'd tell the guy on the toilet lid to ask the better question, and chase it hard, but not to believe the lie that money will fix what's hurting. And not to build the walls so high.

I'd tell every version of me the same thing I've been telling you this whole book. Be grateful. Watch what you focus on. And remember that you can become someone new, any time you decide to.

I think if he'd heard that, some things would have been easier. But I also think he had to walk the path he walked to become the man who could write it down. Maybe that's the mystery Henslowe was talking about.

Someone is chasing you, too

Here's a thought that stopped me in my tracks the first time I had it. If my hero is me in ten years, then there's a younger version of me, ten years back, whose hero was me right now.

The guy on the toilet lid was chasing someone. He couldn't see exactly who, but he was chasing. And I'm who he became. In a strange way, I'm living the life he was reaching for.

That makes me want to honor him. To not waste what he fought for. To keep going so the version of me ten years from now can look back and say the same thing.

The same is true for you. Somewhere back there, there's a younger you who was hoping, fighting, and reaching toward the person you are right now. You're their hero, whether you feel like it or not. Honor them by continuing the chase.

The hero in the room

I'll add one more thought about McConaughey's idea, because it connects to being a warning or an example.

When you chase your hero, the future you, you also become someone's hero right now. Someone younger, or struggling, or just starting out is watching you. Your kids. The new hire. The friend who's where you were a few years ago. The person in recovery who's thirty days in while you're ten years in.

You may never feel like a hero. I certainly don't most days. But to the person a few steps behind you, you're proof that the path goes somewhere. That it's possible to get from where they are to where you are.

So chase your hero with that in mind. Not just for your own sake, but for the people who are chasing you. Every step you take lights the path a little for the ones coming after.

Chase your hero

So here's my last push in this chapter, and it's the same thing McConaughey said, and the same thing I've been saying all along.

Find something to look up to. For me, that's God, and it's gratitude for everything I've been given. For you, it might look different. But find it, and start every day there.

Find something to look forward to. The people you love. The things that make you dance like a dervish. Anchor yourself in them.

And find someone to chase. Picture yourself ten years from now. The best version. The one who's knocked away a decade of unneeded bits. See them clearly. Feel what it would be like to be them. And then start chasing.

You'll never catch them. That's fine. That's the point. It keeps you with somebody to keep on chasing.

Your hero is ten years away.

Go get 'em.



THE FINAL WORD

The Day Is Yours

WHEN I WROTE THE very first draft of the journal, before there were fifty-two weeks, before there was a title, before any agent had a chance to tell me it wasn't substantial enough, I wrote a single paragraph at the top of the page. I called it a foreword. I've thought about that paragraph a lot while writing this book, and I want to give it to you here, at the end, because I think I finally understand what I was trying to say.

> *Herein lies the story of a person who has accomplished great things. The path has never been straight. They have been off course most of the time, but their strength, fortitude, and discipline have carried them. They have strove valiantly again and again, failed time after time, but continued on the journey. With the dust settled and the sun setting, they have found what all heroes find... The day was and will always be theirs. Follow your path, loved ones. When all appears lost, victory is just around the bend.*

When I wrote that, I think I was writing about myself, or at least the self I hoped I was becoming. Now I know I was writing about you.

The path was never straight

If you've been honest with yourself while reading this, you know your path hasn't been straight either. Nobody's has. Mine went through a yellow room with a glass pipe, a bathroom scale that read 271, a slammed bedroom door, a two-door Jeep, a toilet lid, a cage in a bar in Florida, and a thousand smaller detours nobody but me will ever know about.

Off course most of the time. That's the truth of every life I've ever seen up close. We think the people we admire have been on a straight line from the start. They haven't. They've been zigzagging, falling, getting up, correcting, and falling again. The only difference between them and the people who give up is that they kept correcting.

So if you're off course right now, you're not failing. You're normal. The question isn't whether you've drifted. It's whether you'll correct.

Three things to carry

If you forget almost everything in this book, I hope you'll remember three things. They're the three ideas that have run under every chapter, the spine I told you about in the introduction.

Gratitude is your operating system. Not a feeling you wait for. A practice you run every day, starting first thing in the morning. Felt, not listed. Specific, not general. It's the ground you stand on. It quiets fear, dissolves resentment, softens your grip on the things you need to let go of, and makes change feel safe enough to attempt. When everything else falls apart, start here. It is impossible to be fearful when you are truly grateful.

What you focus on, you find. Your brain is filtering the world every second, deciding what gets through and what gets ignored. You can let the news, your fears, and your worst memories set that filter, or you can set it yourself. Tell your brain what matters. Ask better questions. Look for the good on purpose. Rehearse the future you want in the quiet of the morning. The blue SUV was always on the road. So was every opportunity, every kindness, every open door you've been driving past.

You can become someone new. Not just someone with new habits. Someone new. We act consistently with who we believe we are. That's hu-

manity's cardinal rule, and it can lock you in a room for years or walk you right out the door. You can die to your old self any time you choose. You can decide who you are, act like that person before you feel like them, collect the evidence, and let the old identity burn. Like the phoenix. I've done it more than once. You can too.

Those three things work together. Gratitude calms you down enough to change. Focus shows you where to go. Identity is the change itself. Run them every day, and your life will not look the same a year from now.

The people I carry

I want to take a moment, here at the end, to be grateful out loud, because it would be a strange book about gratitude that didn't end with some.

To my parents, who loved me without conditions when I gave them every reason to put conditions on it. To my grandmother, the measuring stick for my life; I'm still trying to catch up. To Uncle Philip, who taught a young man on hole nine that you don't have to kill it. You just have to hit it. To Steve, who taught me that even a broken glass can be half full. To Levi and Jeyben, who walked a lot of this road with me. To Katherine and Danielle, who are my heart.

To the examples and the warnings. To the ones who hurt me and taught me to heal. To the ones who blessed me and taught me gratitude.

To the teachers I've never met in person but who've been in my car and on my nightstand for years. To Tony Robbins, for "warning or example" and for teaching me that my state and my questions run my life. To Marcus Aurelius, for writing notes to himself that an emperor never meant for a car guy in Michigan to read. To Jose Silva, for showing me what the quiet mind can do. To David Goggins, for the cookie jar and the reminder that I'm rarely as done as I think. To Brené Brown, for teaching me that my armor was keeping out more than pain. To Matthew McConaughey, for reminding me my hero is ten years away. To Chase Hughes, for teaching me to pay attention, starting with myself. To Lincoln and Washington, for proving that character is built in private and tested in public.

And to Jennifer. My best friend, my editor, my business partner, my ride-or-die fellow traveler. You resurrected me. You taught me how to love and, more importantly, how to live. You quiet the restlessness in my soul. Every day, I start my meditation with the three things I'm most thankful for. Every day, you're the first one. This book would never have happened without you, just like the first one wouldn't have. I love you, my angel.

The journey is yours

At the end of the old journal, I wrote a short epilogue. It said that the journey was the reader's now. That everything they'd recorded, all their thoughts, all their creation, had been in them the whole time.

That's true of you, too. Nothing in this book gave you anything you didn't already have. The gratitude was always available. The filter was always there, waiting for instructions. The new you was always inside the marble. All I've tried to do is hand you a chisel and point at the stone.

How much more is there? What's left that you want to accomplish or work through? What's the next piece of marble to knock away?

You have everything you need. Now is the time to blaze your own trail. Don't be surprised if it takes you everywhere you've ever wanted to be. Leave the fear and hesitation behind. You're only limited by your imagination and your desire.

There's a line that closed the last draft of the journal, sitting there on its own at the bottom of the page: "All who wander are not lost." It's a twist on Tolkien's line that "not all those who wander are lost," and I've always liked it. If you've wandered, and you have, and I have, it doesn't mean you're lost. It might just mean you're on your own path through the dark part of the forest, the one where there wasn't a trail until you made one.

When you fall off

I want to say something to the version of you who reads this book, gets fired up, starts strong, and then, three weeks from now, finds themselves

right back in the old patterns. Skipping the gratitude practice. Letting the phone set the filter. Slipping into the old identity.

That's going to happen. It happens to everyone. It still happens to me.

Falling off isn't failure. Staying off is. And even staying off for a while isn't permanent. The door is always open. You can come back tomorrow morning and start again with three things you're grateful for, as if you'd never left.

Don't let the old identity use the slip as evidence. When it says, "See, you'll never change," answer it: "I'm someone who comes back." That sentence alone has carried me through more restarts than I can count.

The sculpture doesn't get ruined because you put the chisel down for a while. It's still there. Pick the chisel back up.

A challenge

So here's my challenge to you, and then I'll let you go.

For the next thirty days, start every morning with gratitude. Three specific things, felt in your body, for a full minute each. Before your phone. Before the news. Before the day gets its hands on you.

That's it. One practice. Thirty days.

I'm not asking you to do everything in this book at once. I'm asking you to install the operating system. Because once gratitude is running underneath, everything else gets easier. The filter starts shifting on its own. The questions get better. The fear gets quieter. The old identity loosens its grip. You'll find yourself naturally reaching for the other tools, not because you're forcing it, but because you're becoming someone who does.

If you do that for thirty days and nothing changes, you can always go back. That's what I told readers in the journal about changing their thoughts, and it's still true. But I don't think you'll want to.

Own the day

So here's where I'll leave you. Same place I left the readers of that first journal, because I haven't found a better place to stop.

Growth is sometimes painful. It won't always be easy. My guess is you already know that. My guess is that if you've read this far, you're not opting for the easy life. You've chosen the extraordinary one.

I honor you for that. I mean it.

Tomorrow morning, before you touch your phone, sit for a minute. Put your hands on your heart. Think of three things you're grateful for, and feel them. Then ask yourself a better question. Picture the person you're becoming. Decide to be the example. And then go out and meet the day before it shows up at your door in a tank.

Let's make a real difference. Let's make a lasting difference. Let's own this day.

It is ours, if only we summon the will to take it.

You've got this. You deserve it. I'm in your corner.

JA